The Way Up and the Way Down

MAP 08



ὁδὸς ἄνω κάτω μία καὶ ὠυτή

The way up and the way down: one and the same.

The Way Up and the Way Down



Palintropic Form, Anamnetic Space, and the Architecture of Aletheia in the Metroidvania

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair



THE WAY UP AND THE WAY DOWN

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Abstract

The metroidvania — the action-exploration form crystallized in Nintendo's *Metroid* (1986) and Konami's *Castlevania: Symphony of the Night* (1997), and elaborated across four decades of commercial, independent, and auteurist production — has been understood by its designers, its critics, and the small academic literature attending to it as a formula: a contiguous world, progression gated by abilities that double as instruments of traversal, and the obligatory revisitation of explored space. This dissertation contends that the formula conceals a philosophy, and that the philosophy is older than the medium that has given it its most exact expression. Its central claim is that the metroidvania is the first popular aesthetic form to render the structure of understanding itself — the hermeneutic circle, in which wholes are grasped through parts and parts through wholes, so that every comprehension is a re-comprehension — as navigable architecture. The genre's defining and long-disparaged operation, the return, is not a concession to the economy of assets or an artefact of hardware constraint but the constitutive act through which its worlds mean.

I designate this structure *palintropic form*, after Heraclitus's *palintropos harmoniē*, the "back-turning" attunement of the bow and the lyre, and after the cognate fragment declaring the way up and the way down one and the same. Palintropic form is articulated through five movements, the *palintropic pentad*. *Prolepsis*, the anticipatory display of the unreachable, converts the visible but inaccessible ledge into a preconception that makes inquiry possible. *Aporia*, the productive impasse, generates desire in the precise sense of Diotima's myth of Eros as the child of Poros (passage) and Penia (lack). *Metamorphosis*, the acquisition of capacities, transfigures not only the avatar's body but — as Jakob von Uexküll's theory of the *Umwelt* predicts — the world that body inhabits. *Anagnorisis*, recognition upon return, discloses the remembered impasse as a passage, so that one never enters the same room twice. *Aletheia*, the terminal unconcealment — at once un-hiding and un-forgetting — discloses, in the genre's canonical works, that the final secret of the explored world is the explorer.

The study proceeds by hermeneutic phenomenology; by a comparative mythopoetics modelled on Aby Warburg's tracing of the afterlives of forms rather than on the Campbellian monomyth; and by media archaeology. It reads *Metroid*, *Super Metroid*, *Metroid Fusion*, *Metroid Prime*, *Metroid Dread*, *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest*, *Symphony of the Night*, *Aria of Sorrow*, *Cave Story*, *La-Mulana*, *Axiom Verge*, *Ori and the Blind Forest*, *Hollow Knight* and *Hollow Knight: Silksong*, *Blasphemous*, *Animal Well*, *Prince of Persia: The Lost Crown*, and *Outer Wilds* alongside the labyrinth from Knossos to Borges and Eco; the Gothic castle from Walpole to Stoker and Piranesi; the katabasis from Inanna to Dante; the Grail castle of Chrétien de Troyes; the art of memory from Simonides to Bruno; the veil of Isis from Plutarch to Novalis; the Simurgh of Attar and of Ferdowsi; the speculative fictions of Kafka, Le Guin, the Strugatsky brothers, Arthur C. Clarke, Gene Wolfe, Mark Z. Danielewski, and Susanna Clarke; the cinema of Ridley Scott, Stanley Kubrick, Andrei Tarkovsky, and Jim Henson; and the philosophies of Husserl, Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty, Sartre, Gadamer, Bloch, and Deleuze and Guattari, placed throughout in dialogue with the Japanese spatial concepts of *oku*, *ma*, *miegakure*, and *shakkei*.

Its contributions are five. It redefines the genre at the level of syntax rather than iconography, identifying the return as the genre's structural dominant. It offers a phenomenology of ability as Umwelt-transformation and reads the genre as an anti-Aesopian pedagogy that refuses the consolations of sour grapes in favour of a disciplined hope. It proposes an erotics of aporia accounting for the peculiar desire the gated world produces. It develops a critical theory of *theriomorphic accretion* — the explorer's progressive assimilation to the monstrous, alien, and colonized world it explores — with consequences for the genre's imperial and gendered imaginaries. And it advances a theory of the *reflexive secret*, according to which the metroidvania's ultimate disclosure is the anagnorisis of the self. The dissertation concludes that the metroidvania is a philosophy of return whose imperative is at once hermeneutic and ethical: one goes back not to repeat but to recognize.

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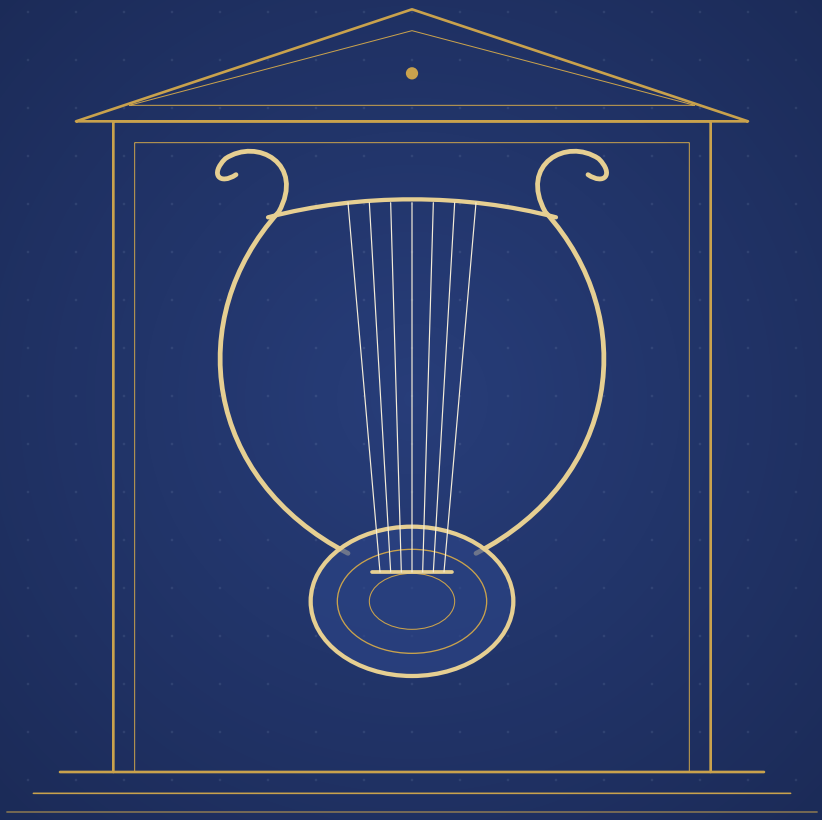
CHAPTER ONE

α'

Eisodos

εἴσοδος

The Problem of the Return



ὁδὸς ἄνω κάτω μία καὶ ὠυτή.

The way up and the way down: one and the same.

— Heraclitus, fragment B60 (Diels–Kranz)

What is a man? A miserable little pile of secrets.

— Dracula, in *Castlevania: Symphony of the Night* (Konami, 1997), after André Malraux, *Antimémoires* (1967)

1.1 *The Scandal of Return*

Among the forms the digital game has generated in its half-century of existence, the metroidvania is distinguished by a peculiar scandal: its defining operation is one that, in almost any other genre, would be diagnosed as a failure of design. The lexicon of professional criticism and design pedagogy has long treated *backtracking* — the obligatory re-traversal of space already explored — as a symptom of padding, an index of insufficient content stretched across excessive duration, the ludic equivalent of the novelist's filler chapter. Yet the metroidvania does not merely tolerate backtracking. It elevates the return to the rank of structural principle, such that a work in the form which eliminated revisitation would cease, by common consent, to belong to it. A genre whose essence is constituted by what its own medium regards as a defect presents a theoretical problem of the first order: either the medium's prevailing norms are mistaken, or the return performed in the metroidvania is not the same act those norms condemn.

The second hypothesis is the point of departure for this dissertation. Consider the opening minutes of the form's paradigmatic text, *Super Metroid* (Nintendo R&D1 and Intelligent Systems, 1994). Having descended through a storm to the surface of the planet Zebes, Samus Aran — bounty hunter, orphan, adoptive daughter of a vanished avian civilization — encounters in short order a passage too narrow for her armoured body, a ledge beyond the reach of her leap, and a door whose colour announces a weapon she does not yet possess. None of these is an obstacle in the ordinary sense. An obstacle is something to be overcome in the present; these are things whose overcoming is explicitly deferred to a future the game guarantees but does not schedule. They are, more precisely, promises: inscriptions in the architecture of a debt that the world owes the player and the player owes the world. The passage will admit Samus once she can curl into the

Morph Ball; the ledge will yield to the Hi-Jump Boots or the Space Jump; the door to the appropriate ordnance. When, hours later, she returns, passage, ledge, and door are physically unchanged and yet altogether transformed, because what has changed is the relation between the world and the body that inhabits it. The return does not repeat the first encounter. It completes it.

This structure — in which the meaning of a locus is constituted not at its first encounter but at its return under altered conditions — distinguishes the metroidvania's return from the padding that design orthodoxy deplores. Padding is iterative: it repeats an experience without altering its significance. The metroidvania's return is recursive: it re-enters an experience in order to transform it. The difference is that between rote and re-reading. The first traversal of Crateria is a reading that cannot yet understand what it reads; the last is a re-reading in which the whole, now possessed, retroactively illuminates every part. In this respect the metroidvania stands in a relation to its own space precisely analogous to that which hermeneutics since Friedrich Schleiermacher has described between interpreter and text, in which the parts are intelligible only in the light of a whole that is itself intelligible only through the parts.

Why, then, a form whose essence is return? The literature has answered at three levels, partially and for the most part implicitly. At the level of production, the return has been explained economically: a world re-used is a world whose assets need not be multiplied, and the genre emerged, as Gunpei Yokoi's design maxim of "lateral thinking with withered technology" (*kareta gijutsu no suihei shikō*) would predict, from hardware whose memory constraints rewarded the intensive exploitation of limited space. At the level of reception, it has been explained psychologically: the visible but unreachable item exploits what Bluma Zeigarnik, working in Kurt Lewin's Berlin laboratory, demonstrated in 1927 to be the superior retention of interrupted tasks, so that the world's deferred promises function as mnemonic hooks and the genre's notorious completionism as the compulsive closure of open loops. At the level of structure, it has been explained formally: the metroidvania is a directed graph whose edges are conditional upon the possession of keys, and its design is the art of arranging locks so that the solution traverses the graph more than once. Each explanation is correct, and none suffices. None accounts for the phenomenological fact on which the genre's devotees insist and which its detractors cannot perceive: that the return, in a well-made metroidvania, is experienced not as cost but as meaning; that the instant in which a remembered impasse yields is among the most intense satisfactions the medium affords; and that its intensity is disproportionate to any reward the yielding confers.

The argument of the following chapters is that this disproportion has a philosophical explanation, and that the explanation lies in the genre's having rendered spatial an operation that philosophy, myth, and literature have long recognized as constitutive of understanding itself. The metroidvania is, on the thesis advanced here, *the hermeneutic circle made walkable*: a form in which the structure of comprehension — anticipation, impasse, transformation, recognition, disclosure — is not represented but enacted, not narrated but traversed. Its scandal is the scandal of every serious account of understanding from Plato's doctrine of recollection to Heidegger's insistence that the decisive thing is not to escape the circle of interpretation but to enter it rightly: that one learns only what one has, in some sense, already encountered; that to know is to recognize; and that the road forward runs, of necessity, back.

1.2 *Naming the Form*

Portmanteau, Genre, and the Dominant

The genre's name is itself a symptom. "Metroidvania" is a portmanteau of two franchise titles, *Metroid* and *Castlevania*; it entered general circulation through the enthusiast press of the early 2000s and is most closely associated with the critic Jeremy Parish, who popularized the term while disclaiming its coinage. Its variants — "Castleroid," and the auteurist "Igavania," after Koji Igarashi, producer of the *Castlevania* entries that followed *Symphony of the Night* — testify to an unstable provenance, while Japanese-language discourse has tended toward the more descriptive designation of exploration-type action (*tansaku-gata akushon*). Generic nomenclature in game culture is characteristically eponymous: the roguelike takes its name from *Rogue* (1980), the Soulslike from FromSoftware's *Demon's Souls* (2009) and *Dark Souls* (2011). The metroidvania is unusual in fusing two eponyms. Its name is genealogical rather than descriptive; like a patronymic, it designates a lineage rather than an essence, and it designates that lineage as a hybrid — a crossing of science-fictional and Gothic bloodlines whose offspring bears the features of both parents and the full name of neither. Chapter Five will argue that hybridity is not incidental to the form but thematically central to it. The name, before any argument, already announces that the genre is a chimera.

The definitional criteria commonly adduced for the genre may be summarized under six heads: a single, contiguous, interconnected world rather than a sequence of discrete levels; progression gated by abilities or items that function simultaneously as instruments of traversal or combat; a non-linear but structured exploration requiring the revisitation of previously explored areas; a cartographic interface, typically an auto-completing map; predominantly side-scrolling, two-dimensional platforming and action; and a stratum of optional, concealed upgrades rewarding exhaustive exploration. Each criterion admits damaging counter-examples. *Metroid Prime* (Retro Studios, 2002) abandons the second dimension for first-person three-dimensional space while retaining every other feature. *Dark Souls* possesses an interconnected world of extraordinary intricacy without ability-gating in the strict sense. *Outer Wilds* (Mobius Digital, 2019) eliminates ability-gating altogether, gating progression on knowledge alone. *Batman: Arkham Asylum* (Rocksteady, 2009) and *Star Wars Jedi: Fallen Order* (Respawn, 2019) export the genre's gating logic into the idiom of the three-dimensional blockbuster. Definition by enumerated features founders on the problem that afflicts all such definitions, and the genre seems better described by Wittgenstein's family resemblances — "a complicated network of

similarities overlapping and criss-crossing" (*Philosophical Investigations*, §66) — than by any list of necessary and sufficient conditions.

Family resemblance, however, describes the extension of a genre without explaining its cohesion. Three bodies of genre theory permit a more rigorous approach. Hans Robert Jauss's "horizon of expectations" (1967) locates genre in the anticipations a reader brings to a text: the player who enters a new metroidvania expects to find locked doors and to return to them, and the genre exists, in part, as that expectation. Jacques Derrida's "The Law of Genre" (1980) observes that texts participate in genres without belonging to them — *participation sans appartenance* — since the mark that designates a genre is never itself a member of the class it marks; the metroidvania's porous borders, through which the Soulslike, the roguelike, the immersive simulation, and survival horror pass in both directions, exemplify this participation without belonging. The most productive framework, however, is Rick Altman's semantic/syntactic approach to film genre (1984), which distinguishes a genre's semantic elements — its iconography, settings, character types, and properties — from its syntax, the structural relations into which those elements are placed. Semantic elements migrate freely between genres; syntax is what holds a genre together across semantic variation.

Applied to the metroidvania, Altman's distinction is clarifying. The genre's semantics are strikingly variable: the Gigeresque caverns of Zebes, the Gothic galleries of Dracula's castle, the Mesoamerican luchador mythology of *Guacamelee!* (DrinkBox Studios, 2013), the Andalusian Catholic baroque of *Blasphemous* (The Game Kitchen, 2019), the insect necropolis of *Hollow Knight* (Team Cherry, 2017), the Persian cosmic mountain of *Prince of Persia: The Lost Crown* (Ubisoft Montpellier, 2024). What remains constant is a syntax that can be stated as a single relation: *the accessibility of the world is a function of the capacities of the subject, and the capacities of the subject are acquired from the world*. Space and self are mutually determining variables. Every locus of the world is indexed to a capacity that will render it accessible; every capacity is located at some locus of the world. The genre's characteristic temporality follows from this reciprocal determination. Because capacities are acquired in sequence and loci are indexed to capacities, the world is necessarily encountered in an order that differs from the order in which it can be understood. The return is the mechanism by which these two orders are reconciled.

This yields a criterion more exact than family resemblance. Roman Jakobson, in lectures on Russian Formalism delivered at Brno in 1935, defined "the dominant" as the focusing component of a work: the element that rules, determines, and transforms the remaining components and guarantees the integrity of the structure. I propose that a work is a metroidvania to the degree that the

return is its dominant. Many works contain returns. *The Legend of Zelda* (1986) and its successors return to an overworld between dungeons; *Resident Evil* (Capcom, 1996) obliges the player to re-traverse its mansion with each new key; *System Shock* (Looking Glass Technologies, 1994) and its immersive-simulation descendants interlace their decks; *Dark Souls* coils its world upon itself through shortcuts that open, retrospectively, onto regions long left behind. But in *Zelda* the return to the overworld is subordinate to the modular dungeon; in *Resident Evil* it is subordinate to the economy of scarcity and dread; in *Dark Souls*, to the agonistic mastery of combat. In the metroidvania the return organizes and transforms everything else. Combat becomes the instrument by which capacities are seized from the world's guardians. Narrative is deposited in the world's strata for archaeological recovery upon return. Even difficulty is calibrated to the moment of return, when the player's enhanced capacities render the once-perilous route trivially traversable and so make the player's own growth perceptible as a change in the world. The metroidvania is the form in which return is dominant. The others are its satellites, and the theory developed here applies to them in proportion to their proximity.

1.3 *Two Origins and a Prehistory*

1986 and Its Antecedents

The year 1986 deserves to be called the *annus labyrinthi* of popular culture. In February Nintendo released *The Legend of Zelda* for the Famicom Disk System; in August, *Metroid*; in September Konami published *Akumajō Dracula*, known in the West as *Castlevania*; in October the MSX2 *Vampire Killer*, whose non-linear castle and key-based progression already gestured toward what the series would become; in December *Kid Icarus*, built by the *Metroid* team on shared foundations. In the same year Jim Henson's *Labyrinth* sent its heroine through an M. C. Escher staircase in pursuit of a stolen child; Jean-Jacques Annaud adapted Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose*, with its murderous library-labyrinth; James Cameron's *Aliens* returned to the biomechanical catacombs that had already furnished *Metroid* with its imagery; and Hayao Miyazaki's *Castle in the Sky* suspended above the clouds a ruined, overgrown citadel of lost technology. The coincidence is not causal, but it is symptomatic. The labyrinth returned to the collective imagination at the very moment a new medium acquired the material capacity to sustain persistent space. The Famicom Disk System's rewritable magnetic media permitted the saving of game state, and the Japanese release of *Metroid* exploited them; its North American cartridge release substituted a twenty-four-character password, a cryptographic compression of the entire state of the world that the player was obliged to transcribe and preserve. The labyrinth's memory was entrusted to the player's own.

Metroid was produced by Nintendo's Research and Development 1 division under Gunpei Yokoi, in collaboration with Intelligent Systems, by a team that included Satoru Okada; Yoshio Sakamoto, who would become the series' presiding auteur; the designer Hiroji Kiyotake; the scenario writer Makoto Kano; and the composer Hirokazu Tanaka. Its debts to Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) are openly acknowledged. The dragon-like Space Pirate commander Ridley bears the director's name; the eponymous Metroids are parasites that drain the life of their hosts; and the game's architecture of ducts, vertical shafts, and organic-mechanical encrustation rehearses the interiors H. R. Giger designed for the derelict alien vessel of Scott's film. Tanaka's score, which withholds conventional melody for long stretches in favour of ambient, quasi-biological sound, was conceived by its composer as an attempt to dissolve the boundary between music and sound effect, so that the player would feel the presence of a living thing; it established the genre's acoustic signature, in which the world does not accompany the explorer but breathes around her. The game provided no in-game map. Its players drew their own on graph paper, and the maps published

by the enthusiast magazines of the period circulated as precious samizdat. In 1986 the player was Ariadne, spinning the thread in pencil. Most famously, the armoured protagonist was revealed at the game's conclusion — more fully the faster the game was completed — to be a woman, a late development decision whose implications, at once emancipatory and scopophilic, Chapter Five examines.

Castlevania, directed by Hitoshi Akamatsu, began not as an exploratory form but as a linear and cinematic one: a progression through the stages of a castle conceived as a horror-film set, its closing credits parodically attributing the roles to "Christopher Bee," "Belo Lugosi," and their like in homage to Universal and Hammer. It was the 1987 sequel, *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest*, that opened the series onto the non-linear: a Transylvanian countryside of towns and mansions, a cycle of day and night, cryptic villagers whose counsel was frequently false, and a quest to recover the scattered relics of Dracula's dismembered body — rib, heart, eyeball, nail, ring — whose reassembly would permit their destruction. The myth beneath this structure is older than Stoker: it is Isis gathering the scattered members of Osiris along the Nile, a correspondence to which Chapter Seven returns. The synthesis came a decade later with *Castlevania: Symphony of the Night* (1997), directed by Toru Hagihara with Koji Igarashi as assistant director and principal writer, illustrated by Ayami Kojima, and scored by Michiru Yamane in an eclectic idiom ranging from baroque organ to Gothic rock and jazz. *Symphony of the Night* fused the interconnected, ability-gated architecture of *Super Metroid* with the Gothic semantics of its own lineage and a role-playing apparatus of experience, equipment, and familiars, and it concealed behind an obscure ritual involving two rings and a pair of spectacles an entire second castle — the first, inverted — that many players never discovered at all. Over the following decade Igarashi produced the handheld entries *Harmony of Dissonance* (2002), *Aria of Sorrow* (2003), *Dawn of Sorrow* (2005), *Portrait of Ruin* (2006), and *Order of Ecclesia* (2008), which consolidated the template; *Super Metroid* (1994), directed by Sakamoto, had already fixed the canonical toolkit of Morph Ball, bombs, missiles, Grapple Beam, X-Ray Scope, Speed Booster, Space Jump, Screw Attack, and the Varia and Gravity Suits.

Neither origin was without prehistory. Its deepest stratum is the text-based *Colossal Cave Adventure* (Will Crowther, 1975–76; expanded by Don Woods, 1977), whose geography Crowther, a programmer and caver, modelled on the Bedquilt section of Kentucky's Mammoth Cave system, and whose most famous line — a maze of twisty little passages, all alike — named, before the medium possessed images, the anxiety of the undifferentiated labyrinth. Warren Robinett's *Adventure* (Atari, 1980) translated Crowther's spaces into graph-

ics and concealed within them the first celebrated "Easter egg," a secret room bearing its creator's name: the inaugural instance of the hidden chamber as authorial signature. The British home-computer scene produced flip-screen explorations of mansions and caverns — Matthew Smith's *Jet Set Willy* (1984), Ultimate Play the Game's *Underwurlde* (1984) — while in the United States Robert Jaeger's *Montezuma's Revenge* (1984) sent its explorer through an Aztec pyramid of keyed doors. Japanese computer culture developed a parallel tradition of side-scrolling action role-playing in Nihon Falcom's *Xanadu* (1985) and Yoshio Kiya's *Dragon Slayer IV: Drasle Family* (1987; localized as *Legacy of the Wizard*), in which a family of characters with distinct abilities divided between them access to a single subterranean world, and in Konami's *Knightmare II: The Maze of Galious* (1987), whose castle prefigured *La-Mulana*. Westone's *Wonder Boy III: The Dragon's Trap* (1989) made the Ovidian logic of the form explicit: its cursed hero is transformed successively into lizard, mouse, piranha, lion, and hawk, each body opening regions closed to the others.

The genre's afterlife has been, by the standards of game history, extraordinarily long. After a period in which the major publishers neglected it, the form was revived by solitary and small-team authorship: Daisuke Amaya's *Cave Story* (2004), developed alone over five years; the GR3 Project's *La-Mulana* (2005), an archaeological homage to the MSX; Nifflas's *Knytt* games; Bit Blot's *Aquaria* (2007). The digital storefront era produced a renaissance — Chair Entertainment's *Shadow Complex* (2009), *Guacamelee!* (2013), Thomas Happ's single-authored *Axiom Verge* (2015), Moon Studios' *Ori and the Blind Forest* (2015), *Hollow Knight* (2017), Motion Twin's self-described "roguevania" *Dead Cells* (2018), *Blasphemous* and Igarashi's crowdfunded *Bloodstained: Ritual of the Night* (both 2019) — and a contemporary maturity represented by MercurySteam's *Metroid Dread* (2021), *Ender Lilies: Quietus of the Knights* (2021), *Prince of Persia: The Lost Crown* and Billy Basso's *Animal Well* (both 2024), and Team Cherry's long-deferred *Hollow Knight: Silksong* (2025). The form has persisted across four decades, three generations of designers, and every tier of production. A formula that persists so long is not merely a formula. It is a solution to a problem, and the problem must be one that recurs.

1.4 *The State of the Field*

The academic study of digital games has attended to space with increasing sophistication since the late 1990s, but it has produced no sustained account of the metroidvania, and the accounts it has produced of adjacent phenomena treat the return as a structural or economic feature rather than as an ontological and epistemological one. Espen Aarseth's *Cybertext: Perspectives on Ergodic Literature* (1997) supplied the field's foundational term. "Ergodic" literature, from the Greek *ergon* (work) and *hodos* (path), is literature in which "nontrivial effort is required to allow the reader to traverse the text." The etymology is more prophetic than Aarseth could have intended, for the metroidvania is ergodic in the most literal sense: a text whose reading is a laboured path, whose work is the work of the way. In "Allegories of Space" (2001), Aarseth argued that computer games do not simulate space but allegorize it, offering reductive, discontinuous, rule-bound representations whose spatiality is defined by the contrast between accessible and inaccessible regions. The metroidvania is the genre in which that contrast becomes temporally dynamic, so that the inaccessible is not a boundary but a horizon.

Henry Jenkins's "Game Design as Narrative Architecture" (2004) proposed that games tell stories spatially: through evocative spaces that draw upon preexisting narrative associations, enacted narratives performed in space, embedded narratives deposited in the environment for discovery, and emergent narratives generated by player activity. The metroidvania is the paradigm of the embedded narrative. Its histories are buried in its strata, legible in ruins, inscriptions, and the arrangement of corpses, and they are recovered in the order of the player's descent rather than the order of their occurrence. An earlier collaboration, Mary Fuller and Henry Jenkins's "Nintendo and New World Travel Writing: A Dialogue" (1995), read Nintendo's spatial games against the Renaissance literature of colonial exploration, observing that both privilege the mastery of space over the development of character and organize narrative as a sequence of territorial acquisitions; this reading, which drew upon Michel de Certeau's distinction between the map and the tour, is extended and complicated in Chapter Five. Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck* (1997) distinguished the "solvable maze," which offers the reassuring narrative of a navigable world with a discoverable exit, from the "tangled rhizome," which offers neither exit nor centre. The metroidvania, it will be argued, is a form that begins as rhizome and ends as maze, converting the disorientation of its opening into the total legibility of its completed map.

Jesper Juul's distinction between games of emergence, in which a small number of rules combine to yield variation, and games of progression, in which the player performs a predetermined sequence of actions, illuminates the genre's peculiar hybridity. The metroidvania is formally a game of progression, its keys and locks arranged by design into an intended sequence; yet its density of interconnection and the elasticity of its movement systems permit an emergent counter-practice, the "sequence break," by which players reach regions earlier than intended. Gordon Calleja's model of player involvement (2011), with its account of spatial involvement and "incorporation"; Steve Swink's *Game Feel* (2008); and Brendan Keogh's *A Play of Bodies* (2018) furnish resources for the phenomenology of movement developed in Chapter Five. Ian Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric (2007) licenses the question of what arguments the genre's procedures make. Michael Nitsche's *Video Game Spaces* (2008) and Mark J. P. Wolf's taxonomy of game space (2001) supply vocabularies of spatial description. From design practice, Christopher Totten's *An Architectural Approach to Level Design* (2014) imports Jay Appleton's prospect-refuge theory of landscape preference, illuminating the alternation of vista and sanctuary that structures the genre's rhythm, while Joris Dormans's work on graph grammars for the procedural generation of missions and spaces in action-adventure games (2010) formalizes the lock-and-key dependency structures the genre's designers have long arranged by hand. Mark Brown's dependency-graph analyses of *Zelda* dungeons in the *Boss Keys* video series exemplify a mode of public, design-literate criticism that has done more, outside the academy, to articulate the genre's craft than the academy itself.

Philosophical accounts of play provide a further body of resources: Johan Huizinga's magic circle (1938); Roger Caillois's taxonomy of *agôn*, *alea*, *mimicry*, and *ilinx* (1958), whose final term, the pursuit of vertigo, names the kinetic pleasure of the genre's movement systems more exactly than any concept of "fun"; Bernard Suits's definition of game-playing as "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles" (1978), which the sequence break subjects to a second-order elaboration; Hans-Georg Gadamer's ontology of play in *Truth and Method* (1960), whose identification of play's essence with a to-and-fro movement (*Hin und Her*) renewing itself in constant repetition proves central to this argument; and Eugen Fink's *Play as Symbol of the World* (*Spiel als Weltsymbol*, 1960), which reads play cosmologically, after Heraclitus's fragment on time as a child at play.

What is missing is the convergence of these resources upon a specific form. The literature has analysed return as a graph, as an economy (the design discourse of asset reuse and "padding"), and as an affect (the psychology of completion-

ism). It has gestured toward the mythic resonances of exploration, most often through the flattening template of Joseph Campbell's monomyth. It has developed phenomenologies of game space that do not discriminate between forms. It has not asked why, in this form, return should be experienced as meaning; it has not traced the form's specific mythography — not the generic hero's journey but the particular myths of descent, recollection, and homecoming that the return reactivates; and it has not recognized that the genre's spatial syntax reproduces with uncanny exactness the structure philosophical hermeneutics has identified as the structure of understanding. These are the lacunae this dissertation addresses.

1.5 *Method*

Hermeneutic Phenomenology, Comparative Mythopoetics, Media Archaeology

The method of this study is threefold, and each strand is chosen for its fitness to the object. The first is hermeneutic phenomenology. The metroidvania's significance is constituted in play, and the primary datum of analysis is therefore the structure of the player's experience as it unfolds in time: the intending of the unreachable, the frustration of the impasse, the transformation of capacities, the shock of recognition upon return. Edmund Husserl's analyses of intentionality and of the horizon — the co-intended field of possible perceptions that surrounds every actual perception, the unseen far side of every seen object — supply the descriptive vocabulary. Heidegger's hermeneutic of facticity and Gadamer's philosophical hermeneutics supply the recognition that such description is itself interpretive, situated, and circular. Phenomenological description in game studies faces a familiar objection: that there is no single player, and that the experience described is therefore an abstraction. The objection is met here, as in literary hermeneutics, through the construct of an implied subject. Wolfgang Iser's "implied reader" (1972) designated not an empirical person but the structure of response a text prefigures, and Aarseth has proposed a corresponding "implied player" (2007), the role a game's design anticipates and solicits. Iser's account of reading as the completion of "blanks" (*Leerstellen*), the indeterminacies a text leaves for its reader to fill, finds in the metroidvania a literalization so exact as to seem parodic: the genre's map is a grid of literal blanks, filled square by square by the player's traversal.

Close play, the analogue of close reading, is the practice through which this phenomenology is conducted. It attends to specific rooms, transitions, sounds, and the micro-temporalities of particular encounters, and its claims are in princi-

ple verifiable by any reader who replays the works discussed. They are not claims about what every player feels but about what the works' structures solicit.

The second strand is comparative mythopoetics. The thesis draws extensively upon myth, legend, scripture, and literature, and it must therefore guard against the method most often applied to such comparisons in popular game criticism: the Campbellian reduction of all narrative to variants of a single monomyth. The vice of the monomyth is not that it is false but that it is indiscriminate. By subsuming every story under a universal pattern, it renders invisible the specific differences that make a form what it is. The model adopted here is instead that of Aby Warburg, whose unfinished *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–29) arranged images from antiquity to the Weimar present upon black panels in order to trace not archetypes but afterlives: the *Nachleben* of particular forms, and the "pathos formulas" (*Pathosformeln*) through which particular intensities of feeling were transmitted, transformed, and inverted across historical distance. Warburg's atlas is itself a kind of map of returns, a spatial arrangement of recurrences. Following Ernst Robert Curtius's study of the literary topos (1948) and its reformulation for media history by Erkki Huhtamo as "topos study," this dissertation traces the afterlives of specific figures — the labyrinth, the katabasis, the forbidden chamber, the veiled goddess, the memory palace — rather than the instantiations of a universal pattern.

Within this comparative practice three kinds of claim are distinguished and marked. *Genealogical* claims assert documented influence: that *Metroid* draws upon *Alien*; that the script of *Symphony of the Night* paraphrases André Malraux; that the visual idiom of *Blasphemous* descends from the Sevillian baroque of the city in which it was made. *Analogical* claims assert a structural correspondence without influence: that the opening divestiture of powers in *Metroid Prime* or *Symphony of the Night* corresponds to the Sumerian Inanna's surrender of her regalia at the seven gates of the underworld. *Homological* claims, the strongest and rarest, assert that a correspondence obtains because both terms express a common underlying structure: that the metroidvania's return and the hermeneutic circle correspond because both are articulations of the structure of understanding itself. The thesis's central argument is homological; its supporting arguments are frequently analogical; its historical arguments are genealogical. Confusion of these registers is the characteristic error of mythopoetic criticism, and the discipline of distinguishing them is the condition of its legitimacy.

The third strand is media archaeology, after Siegfried Zielinski's "deep time" of media (2002) and the work of Huhtamo and Jussi Parikka: an attention to the material conditions — rewritable disks, passwords, memory constraints, the persistence of save states — through which the labyrinth's ancient figure acquired,

in the 1980s, a new mode of existence. Finally, because the form's origins are substantially Japanese, the theoretical apparatus of European philosophy is placed throughout in dialogue with Japanese aesthetic and spatial thought: the concepts of *oku*, the innermost depth; *ma*, the interval; *miegakure*, the hide-and-reveal of the stroll garden; and *shakkei*, borrowed scenery. These enter the argument not as exotic ornament but as indigenous theorizations of the very experiences the genre organizes.

1.6 *The Thesis*

Palintropic Form

Among the fragments of Heraclitus preserved by later authors, several bear directly upon the form this study examines. The first, B51, preserved by Hippolytus, reproaches those who fail to understand how a thing at variance with itself agrees with itself, and names the principle of that agreement: a *palintropos harmoniē*, a back-turning attunement, like that of the bow and the lyre. Bow and lyre are instruments whose function depends upon tension in contrary directions. The string drawn back is the condition of the arrow's flight forward; the string stretched between the arms of the lyre is the condition of its sound. The second, B60, declares the way up and the way down one and the same (*hodos anō katō mia kai hōutē*). The third, B123, contains three words that may stand as epigraph to the entire genre: *phusis kruptesthai philei*, "nature loves to hide." To these may be added B18, which warns that one who does not hope for the unhoped-for will not find it, since it is untraceable and *aporon* — literally, without passage — and B52, which declares that *aiōn*, the lifetime or the age, is a child at play, moving pieces upon a board.

From these fragments I derive the central concept of this dissertation. *Palintropic form* designates an aesthetic structure in which the meaning of any element is constituted only through return to it under transformed conditions, such that forward progress is produced by backward movement and the whole is disclosed only through the iterated re-traversal of its parts. The metroidvania is the purest instance of palintropic form yet produced by any medium. Its progress is a bowstring drawn backward: each return to an earlier region is the tension that propels the subject toward regions not yet reached. Its way up and its way down are one. The same corridors are traversed in both directions, and the inverted castle of *Symphony of the Night* literalizes the Heraclitean identity by turning the world upon its axis, so that the ascent through the first castle becomes, room for room, a descent through the second. Its nature loves to hide:

every wall is potentially false, every floor potentially breakable, every surface a candidate veil. Its passages remain *aporoi* until hope — the anticipation of capacities not yet possessed — renders them traversable. And its time is a child at play: the aeonic duration of the world, in which civilizations have risen, fallen, and been buried, unfolds within the ludic duration of a single exploration.

The concept of palintropic form permits a reformulation of the genre's significance in the terms of philosophical hermeneutics. Schleiermacher's principle that the parts of a text are understood through the whole and the whole through the parts was generalized by Wilhelm Dilthey into an account of understanding in the human sciences, and transformed by Heidegger into an existential structure. In *Being and Time* (1927, §32), the circle of understanding is not a vicious circle to be escaped but the expression of the fore-structure of all interpretation, and the decisive thing, Heidegger insists, is not to get out of the circle but to come into it in the right way. Gadamer, in *Truth and Method*, characterized the movement of understanding as a "fusion of horizons" between interpreter and interpreted; in the same work, he located the essence of play in a to-and-fro movement bound to no goal that would bring it to an end, renewing itself in constant repetition. Gadamer did not connect these two analyses. The metroidvania connects them for him. In its worlds the hermeneutic circle becomes a literal circuit, and the to-and-fro of play becomes the to-and-fro of the return. Each traversal of a region is an interpretation; each return is a re-interpretation in the light of a fuller grasp of the whole; the completed map is the whole that the parts have constituted and that retroactively constitutes the parts. The metroidvania is, in a phrase that will recur throughout this study, *the hermeneutic circle made walkable*.

The hermeneutic tradition is not the only one the form makes walkable. Plato's *Symposium* places in the mouth of the priestess Diotima a myth of the birth of Eros. Conceived at the feast celebrating the birth of Aphrodite, Eros is the child of Poros — Resource, Expedient, but etymologically *passage*, the way through, and himself the son of Mētis, cunning intelligence — and of Penia, Poverty or Lack. Eros is therefore neither rich nor poor, neither wise nor ignorant, but always between: always lacking, always contriving a way. Sarah Kofman, in the essays collected as *Comment s'en sortir?* (1983) — "how does one get out?" — traced the semantic field of *poros* and *aporia* across Greek thought, showing that its language of knowledge was from the first a language of passage, the aporetic dialogue being one that has run out of road. Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant's *Les Ruses de l'intelligence: la mètis des Grecs* (1974) identified in *mētis* the form of intelligence proper to a world without fixed routes: the intelligence of the pilot, the hunter, and the craftsman, of Odysseus *polytropos*,

the man of many turns. The metroidvania stages Diotima's myth with precision. Its gates are *aporiai*, each a localized Penia, a lack inscribed in space. Its abilities are *poroi*, ways through. And the desire it produces — the peculiar, persistent longing for the unreachable ledge that its players describe and its designers cultivate — is Eros in the strict Diotimean sense, born between passage and lack. The genre constitutes what this study calls an *erotics of aporia*: an aesthetic in which the impasse is not the frustration of desire but its origin. And its hero, who must be polytropic in the Odyssean sense to survive, becomes palintropic in the Heraclitean sense in order to understand.

The thesis of this dissertation may therefore be stated as follows. The metroidvania is the aesthetic form in which aporia is made inhabitable. Its worlds are not obstacle courses but architectures of deferred passage, in which every impasse is a promise, every return a re-reading, and every acquisition a metamorphosis. Its deep structure, palintropic form, renders as navigable space the ancient discovery — articulated in Heraclitus, mythologized in Diotima's Eros, systematized in the hermeneutic tradition, and recovered in phenomenology's analyses of the horizon — that desire, knowledge, and selfhood are constituted not by forward motion alone but by return. And in its canonical instances the genre resolves into a single figure, recurring with a regularity that cannot be coincidental: the explorer who, having recollected the world, discovers that what was being recollected was the explorer.

1.7 *The Palintropic Pentad*

Palintropic form is articulated through five movements. They are named here in Greek, partly to mark their descent from the philosophical and dramaturgical traditions that first conceptualized them, and partly because the Greek terms carry semantic charges their English equivalents dissipate. The five are not stages in a linear sequence but phases of a cycle. Every locus of a well-made metroidvania participates in all five at different moments of play, and the cycle recurs at every scale — the single room, the region, the world — so that palintropic form is, in a precise sense, fractal.

Prolepsis (πρόληψις), "a taking-beforehand," names the anticipatory display of the unreachable: the energy tank glimpsed behind an impassable barrier, the ledge visible but beyond the leap, the background landscape in which regions not yet visited are painted at a distance. The term carries a double heritage. In rhetoric it names the anticipation of an objection. In Hellenistic epistemology, above all in Epicurus, it names the "preconception": the general notion, formed from prior experience, that makes inquiry possible at all, and which Epicurean and Stoic philosophers deployed against the paradox posed in Plato's *Meno* — how can one search for what one does not know, since without knowing it one would not recognize it when found? The metroidvania's proleptic display is a prolēpsis in space. It gives the player a preconception of what is to be sought, and so converts the unknown into the not-yet-reached. Chapter Three develops this movement through Husserl's distinction between empty and fulfilled intention and through Ernst Bloch's *Vor-Schein*, the anticipatory illumination in which the not-yet appears in advance of its realization. Its formal analogue in Japanese garden design is *shakkei*, the borrowed scenery by which distant mountains, unreachable from within the garden's bounds, are incorporated into its composition.

Aporia (ἀπορία), "lack of passage," names the productive impasse: the locked door, the gap too narrow, the ledge too high, the wall of spikes, the corridor too dark to traverse. The metroidvania's aporiai are not obstacles in the agonistic sense. The player does not overcome them by effort in the present but suspends them, carrying them in memory until a capacity is acquired. They are the genre's localized Penia, the lacks in which its desire originates. Chapter Four develops the movement through the Gothic castle and its forbidden chambers; through Franz Kafka's parable "Before the Law," in which a doorkeeper informs a dying supplicant that the door was meant for him alone; and through Heidegger's *Holzwege*, the forest paths that break off abruptly in the untrodden and whose meaning only those who work the forest know.

Metamorphosis (μεταμόρφωσις) names the acquisition of capacity as transfiguration. The ability acquired in the metroidvania is not a tool added to an unchanged subject but a modification of the subject's body, and therefore — since the world of an embodied subject is the correlate of that body's possibilities of action — a modification of the world. The Morph Ball does not merely permit Samus to pass through narrow tunnels; it changes what a narrow tunnel *is*, converting a wall into a passage and an absence into an invitation. Jakob von Uexküll's theory of the *Umwelt*, the species-specific world of significance constituted by an organism's perceptual and effective capacities, and Maurice Merleau-Ponty's account of the body schema as a system of motor possibilities, of the "I can," furnish the phenomenology of this movement in Chapter Five. Its mythographer is Ovid, whose *Metamorphoses* announces in its first line a song of forms changed into new bodies. Its darker register is what this study calls *theriomorphic accretion*: the explorer's progressive acquisition of the powers of the monsters it hunts, to the point at which explorer and monster become indistinguishable.

Anagnorisis (ἀναγνώρισις), "recognition," is Aristotle's term in the *Poetics* for the change from ignorance to knowledge which, in the finest tragedies, coincides with reversal (*peripeteia*). The metroidvania produces what may be called *topological anagnorisis*: the moment of return in which a remembered impasse is recognized as a passage, and in which the player experiences, compressed into an instant, the reorganization of the whole map around the newly opened point. Aristotle catalogued the means of recognition — by tokens, by memory, by reasoning — and adduced among his instances the most celebrated recognition in Greek literature, the nurse Eurycleia's identification of the disguised Odysseus by the scar upon his thigh. Every metroidvania return is a recognition by token: the world recognizes the returning hero by the marks its own transformations have left upon her body. Chapter Six develops the movement through the mythic grammar of descent and return — Inanna, Aeneas, Odysseus, Orpheus, Perceval — through Plato's doctrine of *anamnesis*, and through Freud's account of the uncanny as the return of the familiar in estranged form.

Aletheia (ἀλήθεια), "truth," was read by Heidegger, through a contested but generative etymology, as *a-lētheia*, un-concealment: truth as the event in which what was hidden comes forth. The privative prefix negates *lēthē*, which names not only concealment but forgetting — Lethe being the river of oblivion in the underworld. Aletheia is thus at once un-hiding and un-forgetting, and the metroidvania enacts both. Its secrets are concealed in the world, and its protagonists are with remarkable frequency amnesiac or divested of powers once possessed, so that progress is literally recollection. The terminal aletheia of the genre's canonical works takes a consistent form. When the final veil is lifted —

the helmet removed, the father confronted, the abyss of origin reached, the antagonist unmasked — what is disclosed is the self: Samus revealed beneath the armour; Alucard facing the father whose blood he carries; the Knight of *Hollow Knight* descending to the void from which it was born; the scientist of *Axiom Verge* confronting an antagonist who proves to be another iteration of himself. Chapter Seven traces this *reflexive secret* through the veiled image at Sais, where Novalis's novice, lifting the veil of the goddess, beholds — wonder of wonders — himself; and through Farid ud-Din Attar's *Conference of the Birds*, in which the birds who cross seven valleys in search of the Simurgh discover that they, the *si murgh* or thirty birds, are what they sought.

Around these five movements a secondary lexicon will be developed. The *palintrope* is the elementary unit of palintropic form: a locus whose meaning is reconstituted by return. The *stasimon* — in Greek tragedy, the choral ode performed by the chorus standing in the orchestra between episodes — names the save room, the genre's zone of stillness and reflection, where play pauses, the world's threat is suspended, and the player contemplates the map. The *cartographic suspension* names the act of consulting the map, in which the player passes from the bewildered perspective of the maze-walker to the synoptic perspective of the maze-viewer: the double vision that Penelope Reed Doob identified as constitutive of the labyrinth's meaning in classical and medieval thought. *Theriomorphic accretion* names the explorer's assimilation to the monstrous. The *reflexive secret* names the disclosure of the self as the world's final secret. And *exodos* — the closing scene of tragedy, but literally "the way out" — names the escape sequence with which so many of the genre's works conclude, in which the completed labyrinth collapses, explodes, or crumbles behind the departing hero.

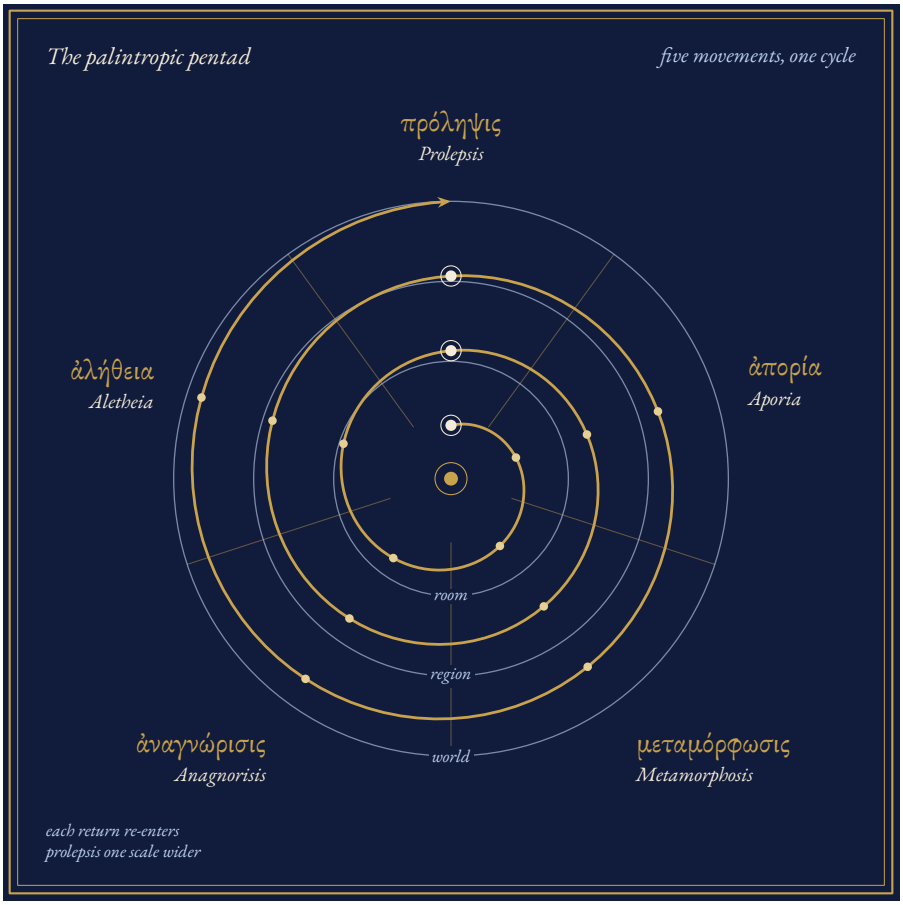


FIGURE 1.1 The five movements form a cycle rather than a sequence: each return re-enters prolepsis at a higher level of understanding, and the cycle turns simultaneously at the scale of the room, the region, and the world.

1.8 *Objections and Delimitations*

Four objections may be anticipated. The first holds that the argument overreads a commercial formula, attributing to industrial convention a philosophical depth no designer intended. The response is threefold. In the first place, the question of intention is beside the point. As Umberto Eco argued in *Interpretation and Overinterpretation* (1992), the legitimate object of interpretation is neither the empirical author's intention (*intentio auctoris*) nor the reader's projection (*intentio lectoris*) but the intention of the work (*intentio operis*), the structure of meaning the work itself sustains and constrains; a reading is overinterpretation when the work refuses it, not when its author failed to foresee it. In the second place, formulas are not the opposite of meaning but its sediment. A

convention that persists across four decades, three generations of designers, and every tier of production persists because it solves a recurring experiential problem, and the persistence of the solution is evidence of the problem's depth. In the third place, the form's designers have repeatedly signalled their awareness of its resonances. Igarashi's script for *Symphony of the Night* paraphrases Malraux. The Game Kitchen built *Blasphemous* from the iconography of the Passion and the penitential processions of its native Seville. Ubisoft Montpellier set *The Lost Crown* upon the Mount Qaf of Persian cosmology. And *Metroid Prime* opens aboard a frigate named *Orpheon*, whose first syllables announce — whether by design or by the unconscious logic of the form — the Orphic descent that follows.

The second objection holds that palintropic form is not specific to the metroidvania, since *Zelda*, *Resident Evil*, the Soulslike, and the immersive simulation all involve return. The objection was anticipated in Section 1.2 through Jakobson's concept of the dominant. These works are palintropic satellites, to which the theory applies in proportion to the dominance of return within them; the metroidvania is distinguished not by possessing return but by organizing everything else around it. The genre is the limit case in which palintropic form becomes legible, but the theory's reach extends beyond it. The same reasoning governs the knowledge-gated works that player discourse has informally dubbed "metroidbrainias" — *Outer Wilds*, Andrew Shouldice's *Tunic* (2022), the deeper strata of *Animal Well* — which are understood here not as departures from the form but as purifications of it: the genre's syntax with its metamorphic movement transposed from the body to the mind.

The third objection charges Eurocentrism: an apparatus of Greek and German philosophy applied to a form originated largely in Japan. Two responses may be made. First, the European semantics of *Castlevania* were themselves a Japanese construction of Europe — a Europe reimagined through Universal and Hammer horror, through the androgynous aesthetics of Ayami Kojima's illustrations, and through what Koichi Iwabuchi has called the "culturally odorless" (*mukokuseki*) character of many Japanese media exports. To read them through European sources is to complete a circuit already in motion. Second, and more substantively, Japanese spatial thought independently theorized palintropic experience. Fumihiko Maki's essay "Japanese City Spaces and the Concept of *Oku*" (1979) described *oku*, the innermost depth approached through successive enfolding layers and never wholly arrived at, as an organizing principle of Japanese urban and sacred space; the approach to a Shinto shrine passes through a sequence of *torii* toward an inner sanctum, each gate a threshold that both admits and defers. The stroll garden (*kaiyū-shiki teien*), whose name denotes a circuit,

organizes its path through *miegakure*, the alternate concealment and revelation of views, so that the walker glimpses a pavilion, loses it, and recovers it transformed from another angle: palintropy in landscape. Arata Isozaki's exhibition *Ma: Space-Time in Japan* (1978) articulated *ma* as an interval in which space and time are not yet separated, a concept apt to the metroidvania's spatialized time; and Jun'ichirō Tanizaki's *In Praise of Shadows* (1933) furnishes an aesthetics of the recessed, the half-lit, and the darkness from which forms emerge that the genre's subterranean palettes everywhere presuppose. These concepts are treated not as supplements to the European apparatus but as co-equal theorizations.

The fourth objection concerns canon bias. The works discussed at length are limit cases in which the form is most legible; minor works are adduced where they illuminate; and the claims advanced are structural and therefore testable against any work in the genre. The study is delimited in four further respects. It treats single-player works. It undertakes industrial and reception sociology only where directly relevant to its argument. It makes no claim to survey a corpus that now runs, on digital storefronts alone, to thousands of titles. And it cites game texts in their English localizations, attending to translation where translation bears on interpretation, as it conspicuously does in the theatrical script of *Symphony of the Night*.

1.9 *The Architecture of This Study*

The dissertation is organized, in deference to its object, as a palintropic structure. Its first chapter is an *eisodos*, an entrance; its last an *exodos*, a way out, which returns to the questions posed at the threshold and re-reads them in the light of the whole. Each chapter closes with a *stasimon*, a brief stationary reflection in which the argument pauses, consolidates, and looks forward. The five central chapters are each devoted to one movement of the pentad, though, as the pentad's cyclical character requires, each anticipates and recapitulates the others.

Chapter Two, "Daedalian Inheritances," establishes the genealogy of multicursal space. It begins with the labyrinth of Knossos and the figure of Daedalus, the architect imprisoned by Minos who escaped not by solving any maze but vertically, on wings of his own manufacture, and who is therefore the mythic patron of every double jump and Space Jump. It proceeds through Penelope Reed Doob's account of the labyrinth's double vision; Eco's typology of the unicursal labyrinth, the multicursal maze, and the rhizomatic net; Borges's infinite interiors, from the Library of Babel and the House of Asterion to the one-to-one map of "On Exactitude in Science"; the cave of Crowther and the secret room of Robinett; and the politics of cartography, from J. B. Harley's deconstruction of the map to Mary Louise Pratt's "monarch-of-all-I-survey" and the god's-eye model of the hedge maze in Kubrick's *The Shining*. It concludes with the Japanese stroll garden as proto-level.

Chapter Three, "Prolepsis," is a phenomenology of the visible unreachable. It reads the unattainable ledge through Husserl's empty intention, Bloch's *Vor-Schein* and his ontology of the Not-Yet, Diotima's Eros, and Meno's paradox, and through Jean-Paul Sartre's appropriation of Kurt Lewin's "hodological space" in his *Sketch for a Theory of the Emotions* (1939), in which the unreachable grapes of Aesop's fable become the paradigm of the "magical" transformation of a world whose paths are blocked. The metroidvania emerges as an anti-Aesopian machine: it refuses the consolation of sour grapes and teaches instead a disciplined hope.

Chapter Four, "Aporia," descends into the Gothic. It reads the castle as Bakhtinian chronotope; Walpole's *Otranto*, Radcliffe's *Udolpho*, and Stoker's *Dracula*, whose Jonathan Harker finds "doors, doors, doors everywhere, and all locked and bolted"; Piranesi's *Carceri* and Thomas De Quincey's opium-visions of them; Escher's impossible stairs; Bluebeard's indelibly bloodied key; Kafka's door meant only for you; Heidegger's *Holzwege*; Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner on the *limen*; and the *Castlevania* lineage from Akamatsu to Igarashi.

Chapter Five, "Metamorphosis," develops a phenomenology of the "I can" from Husserl and Merleau-Ponty, Uexküll's Umwelt, Heidegger's analysis of equipment, and James J. Gibson's affordances. It reads Alice's shrinking before the little door in Wonderland as the archetype of the Morph Ball and Ovid as the genre's mythographer, analyses movement mastery as Caillois's *ilinx* and the sequence break as emancipated play, and traces theriomorphic accretion from H. P. Lovecraft through H. R. Giger's *Necronomicon* and *Alien* to *Metroid*, culminating in the hybrid, cyborg, and dhampir protagonists of the canon and in a postcolonial critique of the explorer who becomes the explored.

Chapter Six, "Anagnorisis," assembles the mythic grammar of return: Inanna's divestiture at the seven gates, read as the inverse of the metroidvania's progressive investiture; the golden bough of the sixth *Aeneid* as the archetypal key item; the *nostos* and *nekyia* of the *Odyssey*; Perceval's failed first visit to the Grail castle and his return, years later, with the question he had not known to ask, as the prototype of knowledge-gating; the cave of the *Republic* and the philosopher's obligatory return; Jung's dream of the many-storeyed house and Freud's involuntary returns as the psychoanalysis of backtracking; and the inverted castle of *Symphony of the Night* as a peripeteia of space.

Chapter Seven, "Aletheia," treats secrecy: Heraclitus's hiding nature and Pierre Hadot's history of its reception in *The Veil of Isis* (2004), with its distinction between Promethean and Orphic attitudes toward nature's secrets; the Easter egg; Georg Simmel's sociology of the secret as a second world beside the manifest one; Malraux's "pile of secrets"; Schiller and Novalis at Sais; and Attar's thirty birds.

Chapter Eight, "Ars Memoriae," reads the metroidvania as memory palace, through Simonides, Cicero, Quintilian, Giulio Camillo, Giordano Bruno, Frances Yates, and Mary Carruthers; as bestiary and *Wunderkammer*; as archive of environmental storytelling; and as a collective palace built by communities of players. It reads the completion percentage through Bloch and Adorno's conversation on the utopian "something's missing" and considers the futures of the form in the roguevania and the metroidbrainia.

Chapter Nine, "Exodos," concludes. It reads the escape sequence as parturition and the genre's recurrent maternal figures — Mother Brain, the Mother of *La-Mulana*, the mothers of Ori and of Hallownest — through an etymological meditation on *metron* (measure), *mētra* (womb), and *mētēr* (mother). It examines the labyrinth that destroys itself upon being known, and it proposes an ethics of return: a palintropic imperative for play, for interpretation, and for life.

STASIMON

I



At the threshold, the argument may pause to recapitulate. The metroidvania's scandal — its elevation of return, the medium's most disparaged operation, to the rank of structural principle — dissolves once the return is understood not as repetition but as recognition. The genre is defined at the level of syntax by the reciprocal determination of space and self, and at the level of its dominant by the return that reconciles the order of encounter with the order of understanding. Its deep structure, palintropic form, is articulated in five movements — prolepsis, aporia, metamorphosis, anagnorisis, aletheia — that recur at every scale of the world. In it the hermeneutic circle becomes walkable, Diotima's Eros becomes architecture, and the Heraclitean identity of the way up and the way down becomes a principle of level design.

The chapters that follow descend. They pass through the labyrinth of Daedalus and the castle of Dracula, the seven gates of the Sumerian underworld and the veiled temple at Sais, the memory palaces of Renaissance hermeticism and the burrow of Kafka's anxious creature. At each stage the argument returns to the works from which it departs — the rain on Crateria, the inverted castle, the abyss beneath Hal-

lownest — and finds them, as the metroidvania teaches its players to find every room to which they return, unchanged and altogether transformed. For the moment, like the player who has entered the first save room of a new world, we stand still. The chorus sings. The map, still almost entirely dark, shows only the room in which we stand and the faint outlines of the doors we cannot yet open.

CHAPTER TWO

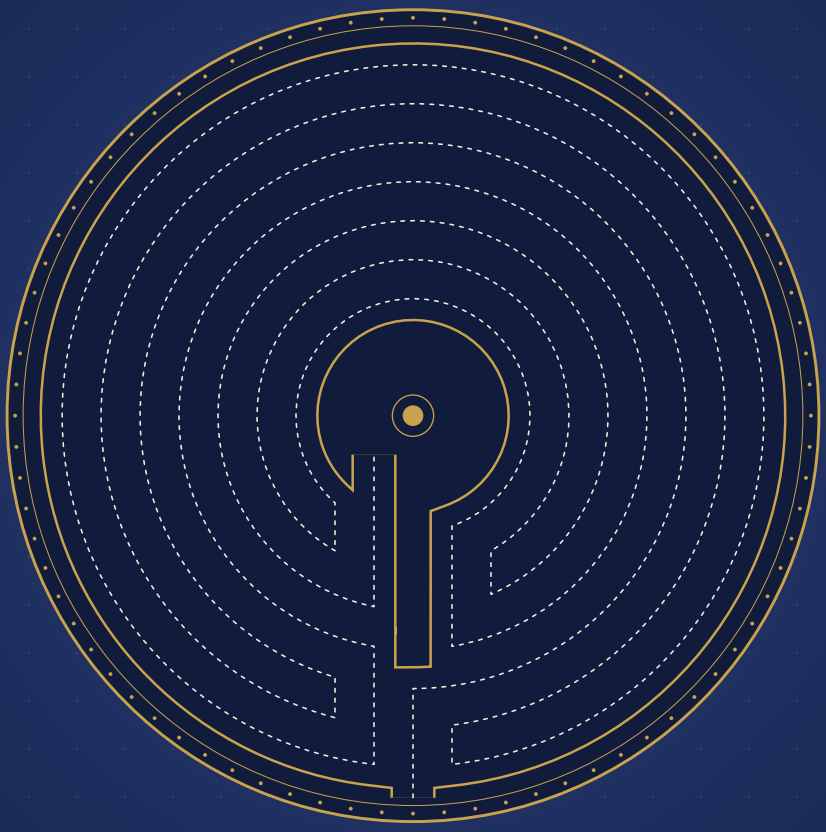
β′

Daedalian

Inheritances

Δαίδαλος

Labyrinth, Map, and the Genealogy of Multicursal Play



... ita Daedalus implet / innumeras errore vias, vixque ipse reverti / ad limen potuit: tanta est fallacia tecti.

... so Daedalus fills the countless ways with wandering, and could himself scarcely find his way back to the threshold, so great was the deceit of the house.

— Ovid, *Metamorphoses* VIII.166–168

La casa es del tamaño del mundo; mejor dicho, es el mundo.

The house is the size of the world; or rather, it is the world.

— Jorge Luis Borges, "La casa de Asterión" (1947)

2.1 *Knossos, Daedalus, and the Double Vision of the Labyrinth*

The oldest written trace of the labyrinth is an offering. Among the Linear B tablets recovered from the palace at Knossos, one (KN Gg 702) records a jar of honey dedicated *da-pu₂-ri-to-jo po-ti-ni-ja*, "to the Mistress of the Labyrinth." Before the labyrinth was a prison, a puzzle, or a metaphor, it was the domain of a goddess; before it housed a monster, it was the house of a Mistress. The etymology of *labyrinthos* remains disputed. The derivation from *labrys*, the double-headed axe ubiquitous in Minoan cult, which would make the labyrinth "the house of the double axe," appealed to the excavators of Knossos and still appeals to the imagination, though philologists regard it as unproven. What the earliest evidence establishes is narrower and more suggestive: that the word preceded the story, that the word belonged to a place of cult, and that the cult was presided over by a feminine sovereignty which classical myth would displace onto the bull-headed son of Pasiphaë. Chapter Nine returns to this displaced Mistress, for the genre this dissertation studies is, it will be argued, haunted by her.

The first datable image of the labyrinth's characteristic design is older still. Scratched on the reverse of a Linear B tablet from Pylos (Cn 1287), around 1200 BCE, is the so-called classical or Cretan labyrinth of seven circuits: the figure that would recur on the coins of Knossos, in Roman mosaic pavements, in the floors of Gothic cathedrals, and in the turf and stone labyrinths of northern Europe, and whose five-thousand-year itinerary Hermann Kern's *Labyrinthe* (1982) documented. Its decisive formal property is that it is unicursal: a single path without branches, winding back and forth upon itself to reach the centre and leading, by the same path, back out. One cannot get lost in it. The labyrinth of image is therefore at odds with the labyrinth of story, which is a place from which one cannot escape. This discrepancy is the point of departure for Penelope Reed Doob's *The Idea of the Labyrinth from Classical Antiquity through the Middle Ages* (1990), which argued that the labyrinth signified, throughout its premodern career, both art and error, order and chaos, according to the position from which it was beheld. Seen from above or from outside — as an image on a coin, a diagram in a manuscript, a pattern on a floor — it is a figure of supreme design, the signature of a master artificer. Seen from within, by the one who walks it, it is a figure of bewilderment, of turnings that seem to bring the walker toward the centre only to carry him away from it. The penitents who traced the eleven circuits of the labyrinth inlaid in the nave of Chartres in the early thirteenth century knew the second; the eye that grasped the same pattern whole, as a diagram,

possessed the first. Doob's analysis turns on precisely this duality of perspective, and it is the first of the Daedalian inheritances the metroidvania receives. The genre is, uniquely among popular forms, a labyrinth that grants its walker both visions in alternation: the view from within, which is play, and the view from above, which is the map.

Daedalus himself, the labyrinth's architect, is a figure of more complexity than the Theseus-centred narration of the myth allows. His name derives from *daidallō*, to work cunningly, and the *daidala* were the intricately wrought objects of archaic craft. He built for Pasiphaë the wooden cow through which she conceived the Minotaur, and for Minos the house in which the Minotaur was hidden. But his earliest appearance in Greek literature associates him not with a prison but with a dance. On the shield of Achilles in the eighteenth book of the *Iliad*, Hephaestus fashions a dancing-floor (*choros*) like the one Daedalus once made in broad Knossos for Ariadne of the lovely hair. Plutarch, in his *Life of Theseus*, reports that Theseus and his companions, having escaped, danced at Delos a dance imitating the windings of the labyrinth, the *geranos* or crane dance. The labyrinth, at its mythic root, may have been choreographic before it was architectural: a pattern of movement before it was a building, a figure inscribed by bodies before it was inscribed in stone. The metroidvania inherits this choreographic substratum. Its mastery is kinetic; its worlds are dance-floors whose figures are learned in the muscles of the hands; and the virtuoso traversals of its experts — wall-jumps chained up vertical shafts, shinesparks launched across whole rooms — are, in the precise Homeric sense, a *choros* performed upon a floor of Daedalian design.

It is Ovid, however, who furnishes the labyrinth's most penetrating image, and it is an image of palintropic play. In the eighth book of the *Metamorphoses*, Daedalus leads the eye into error by the winding of varied ways, and the poet compares the building to the river Maeander, which in the Phrygian fields *ludit* — plays — and with ambiguous gliding flows back and flows forward, and, running into itself, beholds its own waves still to come (*occurrensque sibi venturas aspicit undas*), turning now toward its source and now toward the open sea. The labyrinth, for Ovid, is a river at play that meets itself; and its architect, having filled the countless ways with wandering, could himself scarcely find the way back to the threshold. The convergence with Heraclitus is exact. The Heraclitean river into which one cannot step twice and the Ovidian river that meets its own future are the same river seen from two banks: the first insists that return never finds the same, the second that the wanderer, turning back, encounters what is yet to come. Both describe the metroidvania's characteristic experience, in which the player, retracing a corridor, encounters within it a future — a pas-

sage newly open — that the first traversal could not see. The vocabulary confirms the point. Ovid's *error* is not yet a mistake; it is the noun of *errare*, to wander. And the English *maze* descends from the Middle English *mase*, bewilderment or delusion, cognate with *amaze*: amazement is, etymologically, the condition of being inside a maze. The genre's wonder and its wandering are a single word.

Daedalus's career supplies, finally, the three primordial technologies through which the labyrinth is undone. The first is the thread, given to Ariadne — on Daedalus's own counsel in some versions of the myth — by which Theseus retraced his path: memory externalized as an indexical trace, a line that records not the shape of the space but the itinerary of the one who crossed it. The second is the wing. Imprisoned by Minos, Daedalus escaped not by solving any maze but by leaving it vertically, on wings of wax and feathers, while Icarus, flying too high, fell; the vertical is at once the labyrinth's exit and its peril. The third is less celebrated and more remarkable. In the account preserved in Apollodorus's *Epitome*, Minos, pursuing the fugitive architect to Sicily, carried with him a spiral seashell and promised a reward to whoever could pass a thread through its windings, knowing that only Daedalus could. At the court of Cocalus, Daedalus bored a hole in the shell, tied the thread to an ant, and let the ant draw it through the spiral. Thread, wing, and ant: cartographic memory, vertical transcendence, and miniaturization. These are the genre's three primordial capacities, and every metroidvania arsenal elaborates them. The auto-map is Ariadne's thread rewoven into a plan. The double jump, the Hi-Jump Boots, and the Space Jump are Daedalian wings, with Icarus's fall preserved in every chasm into which a mistimed leap descends. The Morph Ball, the slide, and the insect body of *Hollow Knight*'s Knight are the ant in the shell, the small body that threads the spiral the large body cannot enter. Daedalus is the patron of the form: the architect who builds the labyrinth and invents, one by one, the technologies by which it is unbuilt.

2.2 *Unicursal, Multicursal, Rhizomatic*

Eco's Typology and Its Ludic Afterlife

Doob's opposition of the unicursal and the multicursal was reformulated in the vocabulary of semiotics by Umberto Eco, who distinguished three kinds of labyrinth in *Semiotics and the Philosophy of Language* (1984) and, more informally, in his *Postscript to The Name of the Rose* (1983). The first is the classical labyrinth of Theseus, the unicursal figure of the coins and pavements. It permits no choice and therefore no getting lost: its path leads necessarily to the centre, and from the centre necessarily out. Eco observed, with characteristic wit, that such a labyrinth needs its Minotaur, since without the monster at its heart the story would lack all savour and become a mere stroll; and that it renders Ariadne's thread superfluous, since the classical labyrinth is its own thread. The second is the mannerist maze, the *Irrweg* or path of error, whose structure is that of a tree: a branching system of alternatives, most terminating in dead ends, one leading to the exit. In it one can get lost, and the thread becomes indispensable; it is the model of trial and error, of the search that proceeds by elimination. The third is the net, which Eco, borrowing from Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, also called the rhizome: a structure in which every point can be connected with every other, which has no centre, no periphery, and no exit, and which is potentially unlimited. Eco employed the three types as models of the organization of knowledge. The dictionary, with its hierarchy of definitions, is a Porphyrian tree; the encyclopedia, each of whose entries refers to others without end, is a net; and the space of conjecture, in which detective and scientist alike operate, is a rhizome. In *The Name of the Rose* the library of the abbey is a mannerist maze, solvable by the method William of Baskerville applies to it, while the world in which William reasons toward the truth of the murders is a rhizome, in which his conjectures succeed by accident and fail by design.

Deleuze and Guattari's rhizome, as theorized in the introduction to *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), is governed by principles of connection and heterogeneity, multiplicity, asignifying rupture, and "cartography and decalcomania": the rhizome is a map and not a tracing, open and connectable in all its dimensions, reversible, susceptible to constant modification, and possessed of multiple entryways. Their earlier study of Kafka (1975) opens by asking how one is to enter Kafka's work and answers that it is "a rhizome, a burrow." The reference is to Kafka's late story "The Burrow" (*Der Bau*, 1923–24), in which a creature digs and defends an underground complex, hoarding its provisions in a central chamber it calls its castle keep (*Burgplatz*), obsessed with the vulnerability of its entrance and tormented, at last, by a faint whistling that may be another creature

tunnelling toward it. The burrow is the labyrinth seen from the position of its builder-inhabitant: an architecture of anxiety in which every passage is at once a route of escape and an avenue of invasion. *Hollow Knight*'s Hallownest — a kingdom of insects whose roads, tunnels, and tram lines riddle the earth beneath a forgotten surface town — is the burrow raised to the scale of a civilization, and its Deepnest, a lightless warren of predators and webs, is the nightmare of Kafka's creature made explorable.

Each of Eco's types has a ludic afterlife. The unicursal labyrinth survives as the linear stage — the sequence of castle "blocks" through which the first *Castlevania* conducts Simon Belmont, the corridor through which countless action games conduct their players — in which the player cannot get lost, only delayed, and in which, exactly as Eco predicted, the Minotaur must do the work of interest: challenge displaces exploration. The mannerist maze survives as the dungeon, from the twisty little passages of *Colossal Cave* to the branching, key-locked dungeons of *Zelda*, whose dependency structures are trees with locked branches. The net survives in the open world, from the procedurally generated terrains of survival games to the climb-anything topography of *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* (2017), whose freedom of traversal approaches the condition of Borges's desert, a labyrinth without walls.

The metroidvania belongs to none of Eco's types, and the typology's failure to accommodate it is instructive. I propose that the genre constitutes a fourth type, which I call the *palintropic labyrinth*: a labyrinth whose connectivity is a function of the capacities of its walker, so that its topology changes in the course of being walked. Eco's three labyrinths are static structures whose properties are independent of whoever traverses them. The palintropic labyrinth is a dynamic structure, a graph whose edges are conditional on capacities and whose effective form therefore grows as its walker grows. Four properties follow. First, its dead ends are not errors but deferred passages. In the mannerist maze the dead end signifies that the walker has chosen wrongly and must retreat; in the palintropic labyrinth it is a prolepsis, the inscription of a passage that will open when its corresponding capacity is acquired. What looks like a dead end is a door whose key the walker does not yet carry. Second, its effective connectivity increases monotonically. Every acquired capacity adds edges to the traversable graph and none subtracts them, save at the rare "points of no return" that the genre's conventions treat as exceptions to be announced in advance. Third, it passes through Eco's three types as phases of a single experience. It is encountered first as a mannerist maze, a tree of passages riddled with apparent dead ends. It is traversed along a critical path — the sequence of capacity acquisitions — that frequently proves, in retrospect, almost unicursal: beneath the apparent freedom there was,

very nearly, one way through. And it is completed as a net, in which, every capacity in hand and every shortcut, elevator, tram, and teleporter opened, each region is reachable from every other. The palintropic labyrinth is the labyrinth that evolves through the whole of Eco's typology in the course of a single exploration.

The fourth property is the most consequential: the palintropic labyrinth inverts the relation between connectivity and legibility that obtains in Eco's net. Two axes must be distinguished. On the axis of legibility, addressed by Janet Murray's distinction between the solvable maze and the tangled rhizome, the metroidvania moves, as Chapter One anticipated, from rhizome to maze — from the bewilderment of an apparently centreless tangle to the total legibility of a solved structure. On the axis of connectivity, addressed by Eco's typology, it moves in the opposite direction, from tree to net. The two movements are not contradictory but inversely coupled: the more connected the palintropic labyrinth becomes, the more legible it is. In Eco's net, connectivity breeds conjecture; each new connection multiplies the paths of possible inference, and the net remains for that reason the space of interminable interpretation. In the palintropic labyrinth, connectivity breeds comprehension, because every new connection is anchored in the walker's memory of having been where it leads. The genre achieves this inversion by two means — the finitude of its world, and the map that renders the net surveyable — and the result may be stated in a formula. The palintropic labyrinth is a finite rhizome under memory: the net domesticated by the thread.

The abstraction that makes such description possible has its own genealogy. In 1736 Leonhard Euler resolved the problem of the seven bridges of Königsberg — whether a walk through the city could cross each bridge exactly once — by abstracting the city into land masses and the connections between them, and so founded graph theory under the name Leibniz had proposed for a geometry of position, *geometria situs*. The designer of a metroidvania works within Euler's abstraction. The world is a graph of rooms and passages, the passages labelled with the capacities they require, and design is the arrangement of these labels so that the solution traverses the graph repeatedly, in an order that discloses the world rhythmically; Dormans's graph grammars formalize the practice, and the industry's term "critical path" names its spine. In practice, however, the palintropic labyrinth possesses two graphs. One is the graph its designer intended, in which each passage requires a specified capacity. The other is the graph its physics actually permits, in which a sufficiently skilled body may cross gaps its architect believed impassable. The sequence break is the discovery of edges present in the second graph and absent from the first, and the speedrun, which routes

the shortest walk through the second graph, is the systematic exploration of what may be called the labyrinth's unconscious: the passages its architect built without knowing. Ovid's Daedalus, who could scarcely find his own way back to the threshold, would have understood. No architect wholly knows the labyrinth he builds.

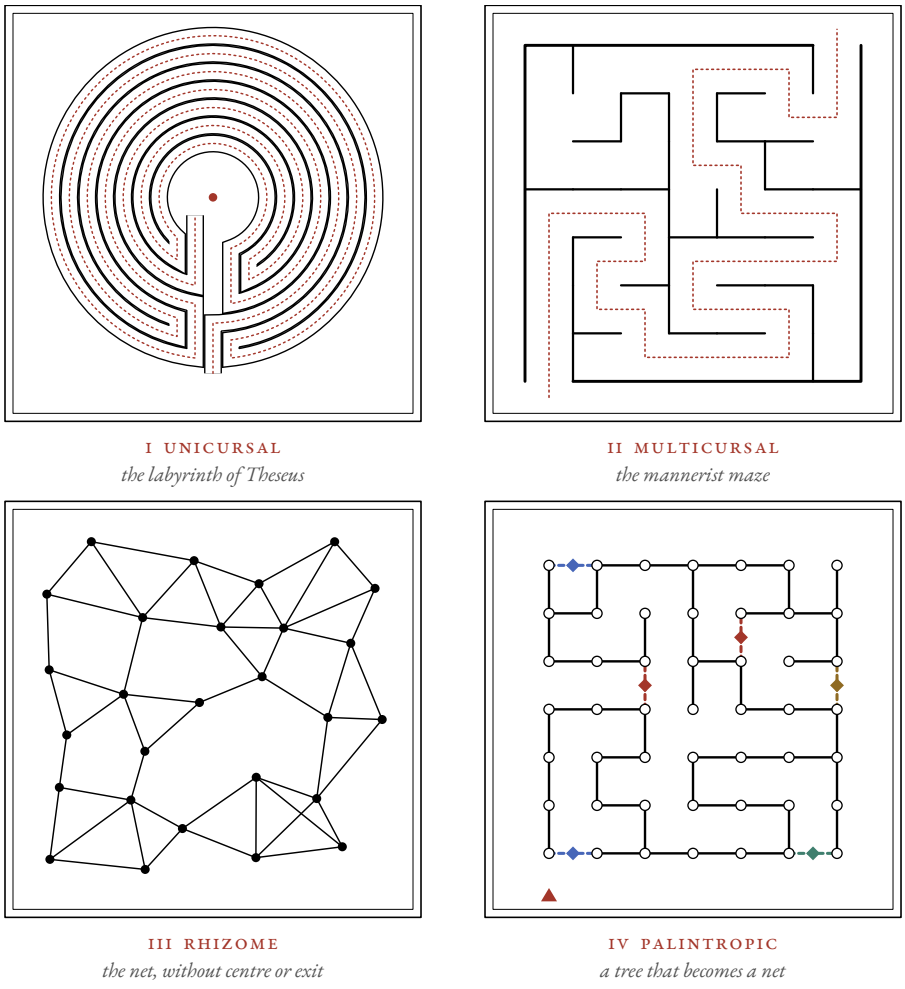


FIGURE 2.1 Eco's three labyrinths are fixed structures. The palintropic labyrinth begins as a tree of open passages (solid) and becomes a net as each acquired capacity opens a gated edge (dashed).

2.3 *Borges and the Infinite Interior*

If Daedalus is the labyrinth's first architect, Jorge Luis Borges is its modern theologian. "The Library of Babel" (1941) presents the universe as an interminable library of hexagonal galleries, containing every possible book of four hundred and ten pages composed from twenty-five orthographic symbols. Its librarians are consumed by superstition and despair: they search for the catalogue of catalogues, venerate a rumoured librarian who has read the book that is the compendium of all the rest, and tear through the galleries in quest of the Vindications that will justify their lives. Against this despair the narrator sets what he calls an elegant hope. The Library, he conjectures, is unlimited and periodic: an eternal traveller crossing it in any direction would find, after centuries, the same volumes repeated in the same disorder — a disorder which, repeated, would become an order, the Order. Borges's consolation is palintropic. Meaning is found not by advancing but by returning; recurrence converts chaos into pattern. The metroidvania is a library of Babel whose periodicity is finite and humane. Its traveller need not wait centuries for the recurrence that redeems the disorder; a few hours of return suffice, and the order the return discloses is not the Order of an absent deity but the order of a memory that has walked the same galleries until they cohered.

"The House of Asterion" (1947) gives the labyrinth's monster its voice. The Minotaur speaks of a house whose doors, infinite in number, stand open day and night; there are no locks and no furniture. Every part of the house recurs many times over, so that any place is another place; there are fourteen — which is to say infinitely many — cisterns, courtyards, troughs, and mangers. Asterion passes his days in games: he races through the stone galleries, hurls himself from terraces, pretends to be pursued, and, best of all, imagines a second Asterion come to visit, whom he guides through the house, announcing their return to an earlier crossing or their emergence into another courtyard. Every nine years nine men enter the house so that he may deliver them from all evil. He awaits a redeemer; and in the story's final lines Theseus reports to Ariadne that the Minotaur scarcely defended himself. Asterion's house is the anti-metroidvania. It is a labyrinth with every door open — without gates, without capacities, and therefore without growth. Its repetitions are iterative, not recursive; its inhabitant can go everywhere and therefore nowhere; and his return to the earlier crossing is return without anagnorisis, the very nightmare of padding against which Chapter One defined the genre. His only relief is the fantasy of a double, and his only hope is death. The locked door of the metroidvania is the mercy Asterion lacked: the gate gives the world a future. And Asterion, the monster at the centre who

speaks of the labyrinth as his home, foreshadows the figure into which, Chapter Five will argue, the metroidvania's explorer is progressively transformed.

"The Two Kings and the Two Labyrinths," first published in 1939 and collected in *El Aleph* (1949), tells of a king of Babylon who built a bewildering labyrinth to mock a visiting Arab king, who escaped only by imploring God. The Arab king returned with an army, conquered Babylon, and abandoned its king in the desert — a labyrinth, he observed, without stairs to climb, doors to force, or walls to impede the way — where the captive died of hunger and thirst. Borges's parable discloses that absolute openness is absolute disorientation: the most terrible labyrinth has no walls. The metroidvania's walls are mercies of the same kind as its gates, granting the walker the dignity of the impasse, the possibility of a reason for being unable to go on. The genre's *exodos* frequently delivers its hero into a desert of exactly the Arab king's kind — the starfield into which Samus's gunship rises as Zebes is consumed, the empty sky above the crumbling castle — as though the labyrinth, once solved, must dissolve into the trackless. The contemporary open world, whose freedom of traversal approaches the wallless condition, offers from the palintropic standpoint not liberation but a different and more diffuse torment.

"The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941) imagines a labyrinth of time: a novel, written by the Chinese sage Ts'ui Pên, in which every alternative is realized and time forks perpetually toward innumerable futures. The metroidvania is its inverse, a garden of converging paths. It offers a choice of order, not of outcome. Every fork is eventually traversed; the multiplicity of possible routes collapses, at completion, into the single map in which all of them are inscribed. Branching narratives, Borges's model, multiply worlds. The metroidvania multiplies passages through a single world, and its freedom is the freedom of sequence rather than of destiny.

"On Exactitude in Science" (1946), a single paragraph attributed to an invented seventeenth-century traveller, records an empire whose cartographers drew a map of the empire at the scale of the empire, coinciding with it point for point; later generations, finding it useless, abandoned it to the rigours of sun and winter, and its tattered ruins survive in the western deserts, sheltering animals and beggars. Jean Baudrillard opened *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) by inverting the fable: in the age of simulation the territory no longer precedes the map, which now precedes and engenders the territory. The metroidvania enacts this precession literally and then refutes it. *Super Metroid*'s Map Stations download the plan of a region before it is explored; in *Hollow Knight* the cartographer Cornifer sells maps of regions the player has never entered. But the precession here is promissory rather than simulacral. The bought map is a prolepsis of the

territory, and the territory always exceeds it: no purchased map discloses the false wall, the breakable floor, the room behind the room, which appear only when walked. The surplus of territory over map, which Baudrillard's thesis denies, is precisely the metroidvania's reward. The completed map, meanwhile, is not Borges's one-to-one chart but a radical abstraction, each room reduced to a cell; and it has its own ruin. A map completed to one hundred per cent is a map whose territory has been used up, abandoned, like the empire's, to the desert winds of the player's departure.

"The Aleph" (1945) locates the point that contains all points in a cellar, beneath the nineteenth step of a staircase in a house condemned to demolition; the narrator must lie on his back in the dark to see it, and in it he beholds every place in the universe from every angle at once. The cartographic suspension partakes of the Aleph: at the press of a button, every visited place is present simultaneously. And the genre, like Borges, locates its revelations of totality in its depths — in the Abyss beneath Hallownest, where the Knight recovers the memory of its origin; in Tourian, beneath the surface of Zebes; in the catacombs beneath the castle. Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) assigned the cellar to the dark, subterranean, irrational forces of the house and the attic to the clarity of reason, and Chapter Six will show that the metroidvania's vertical axis follows Bachelard's psychology of the house with remarkable fidelity.

Borges's heirs extend the infinite interior in directions that illuminate the genre by contrast. Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000) concerns a house that measures a quarter of an inch larger inside than out, within which a dark, cold, shifting hallway opens onto spaces that defy measurement; its expeditions end in catastrophe when their leader, Holloway Roberts, goes mad in the dark and turns upon his companions, so that the explorer becomes the monster the labyrinth was presumed to hold, while the novel's own typography — footnotes within footnotes, struck-through passages concerning a Minotaur — converts the page into a maze. *House of Leaves* is the horror of the anti-palintrope. Its house changes between visits, so that return yields not recognition but estrangement and no map can ever be completed. Its terror clarifies by contrast the condition of the metroidvania's consolations, which is the stability of the world: recognition requires that the room stay put while the self changes, and where both change there is only vertigo. Susanna Clarke's *Piranesi* (2020) inverts Danielewski's dread. Its narrator inhabits a House of endless halls, statues, and tides, catalogues it in journals furnished with indexes, and loves it as kind and beautiful, until the recovery of a forgotten identity — an anamnesis to which Chapter Eight returns — discloses what the House has hidden. Tsutomu Nihei's manga *BLAME!* (1997–2003) presents the infinite interior as runaway

process: a megastructure extended without plan by machines that answer to no one, through whose vertical immensities a solitary wanderer climbs and descends in search of a lost genetic key. The labyrinth without an architect is the labyrinth that cannot be returned to, because it never stops becoming something else.

2.4 *The Cave and the Computer*

Crowther, Robinett, and the Flip-Screen Sublime

The digital labyrinth was born underground. Will Crowther, a programmer at Bolt Beranek and Newman who wrote much of the routing software for the ARPANET's first packet switches, was also an experienced caver, and with Patricia Crowther he surveyed passages in the Flint Ridge cave system of Kentucky for the Cave Research Foundation. Patricia Crowther was a member of the 1972 party that connected Flint Ridge to Mammoth Cave, joining the two into the longest known cave system on earth, and she was famed among cavers for having squeezed through a constriction known as the Tight Spot. The genre's archetypal narrow passage thus has a historical prototype: a crawlway that admitted only the smaller body, through which two worlds were joined into one. After the couple's separation, Crowther wrote, around 1975–76, a text-based simulation of the Bedquilt section of Mammoth Cave, embellished with fantasy elements, partly to amuse his daughters; Don Woods expanded it in 1977, and *Colossal Cave Adventure* became the ancestor of every interactive exploration that followed.

The grammar of *Colossal Cave* already contains much of the metroidvania's. Its world is a graph of described locations joined by compass directions. Its darkness is lethal without a lamp. Its two notorious mazes — one of passages all alike, another of passages all different — compelled players to map them by dropping objects as markers, reinventing the breadcrumbs of Hansel and Gretel and the thread of Ariadne. And on the wall of one of its chambers is written a magic word, XYZZY, which, spoken in the right place, carries the player instantly between two distant points of the cave: at once the first fast-travel system in the history of the medium and its first knowledge-gate, a passage that opens not to a tool but to knowing. The labyrinth of *Colossal Cave* was also a labyrinth of language, since its parser accepted only certain verbs, and the player's search through the cave was doubled by a search through the vocabulary the program would understand. Its successor *Zork*, written at MIT between 1977 and 1979, made darkness into the genre's first lethal aporia: "It is pitch black. You are likely to be eaten by a grue." The light source thereby became the archetypal

key item — the lineage that runs through the lantern of *Zelda* to the Lumafly Lantern without which *Hollow Knight*'s darkest passages cannot be survived.

Warren Robinett's *Adventure* (Atari, 1980) translated Crowther's spaces into images. Each location became a single screen, a framed tableau bounded by its edges. Its three castles, gold, black, and white, were sealed by portcullises that opened only to keys of the corresponding colour: the first colour-coded system of locks and keys, ancestor of *Metroid*'s coloured hatches and the coloured gates of countless successors. A bridge permitted passage through walls, a magnet drew distant objects, and a bat carried objects off at random, introducing into the labyrinth an agent of disorder. Most famously, Atari's policy of not crediting its programmers moved Robinett to conceal in the game a room bearing his name, accessible only by carrying an almost invisible single-pixel dot to a particular wall. When players discovered it, the company chose to embrace such concealed surprises as "Easter eggs." The hidden chamber entered the digital labyrinth as an authorial signature: the place where the maker signs the world, legible only to those who search its walls. Chapter Seven returns to this signature.

The single-screen room made the room the unit of composition, and the etymology of that unit is suggestive. In Italian, *stanza* means a room. In *Stanzas* (*Stanze*, 1977), Giorgio Agamben recalled that the poets of the thirteenth century called the essential nucleus of their canzone a *stanza*, a capacious dwelling or receptacle, because it sheltered the poem's one true object: the phantasm of love, the image of an unattainable beloved. The flip-screen form made each room a stanza in exactly this sense — a framed, bounded, self-sufficient unit, joined to its neighbours by its edges — and the metroidvania inherits the room as its stanza. Its world is a canzone of rooms, and each room, like Agamben's stanza, may shelter a phantasm: an object of desire visible but not yet possessable, which Chapter Three analyses under the name of prolepsis.

The British home-computer scene of the mid-1980s elaborated the flip-screen room into whole architectures. Matthew Smith's *Jet Set Willy* (1984) required its hero to tidy a mansion of some sixty rooms, collecting the debris of a party before his housekeeper would let him go to bed: the house as world, the domestic interior as labyrinth, and the solitary bedroom programmer as auteur. Ultimate Play the Game's *Underwurlde* (1984) organized a cavern-world along a vertical axis; Robert Jaeger's *Montezuma's Revenge* (1984) sent its explorer through the keyed chambers of an Aztec pyramid. In these works the screen's edge acquired a peculiar charge. Each edge was a cut into the unknown; the off-screen was a reservoir of possibility, and the passage from one screen to the next delivered

the small shock of a new tableau. The flip-screen form produced, within the humblest of graphical resources, a sublime of the edge.

Kant's analysis of the mathematical sublime in the *Critique of Judgment* (1790) clarifies the structure of this experience. The imagination can apprehend a magnitude part by part indefinitely, but it can comprehend in a single intuition only so much; when a magnitude exceeds that maximum, the imagination's failure brings to feeling reason's idea of totality, and with it the subject's vocation beyond the sensible. Edmund Burke had earlier located the sources of the sublime in obscurity, privation, vastness, and infinity — in darkness, vacuity, solitude, and silence. The metroidvania stages both accounts with precision. The cavern that exceeds the screen, the vertical shaft whose summit is invisible, the abyss whose depth must be inferred from the time it takes to fall: these are failures of comprehension at the frame's edge. And the map restores comprehension by reason's construction, presenting the totality the imagination could not grasp as a schema of cells. The genre alternates between the sublime and its rational resolution, between the vertigo of play and the composure of the map. This is the Kantian form of Doob's double vision.

Japanese computer culture developed in parallel a different emphasis, in which the body's capacities, rather than the room's frame, organized the world. In Nihon Falcom's *Xanadu* (1985) and Yoshio Kiya's *Dragon Slayer IV: Drasle Family* (1987), a family of adventurers — its pet monster included — divided between its members the capacities required to traverse a single subterranean world, so that the explorer was in effect a distributed body; Konami's *Knightmare II: The Maze of Galious* (1987) assigned its castle's accessibility between two heroes of differing capacities. *Metroid* synthesized these traditions in 1986. Its areas scrolled continuously, but each along a single axis at a time, horizontal corridor or vertical shaft, and the doors between them marked the seams at which the engine changed axis. The genre's emblematic threshold is thus, in part, a fossil of its hardware: a technical seam that became a semantic unit, the door, and then a mythic one, the gate. Media archaeology could hardly ask for a clearer instance of a material constraint sedimenting into a form. And because the game provided no map, its players reconstituted the labyrinth's double vision by hand, on graph paper, square by square: Ariadne in pencil, as Chapter One called her, spinning the thread that the genre would soon learn to spin for itself.

2.5 *The Map and the Territory*

Cartography, Power, and the View from Above

Alfred Korzybski's dictum that the map is not the territory (1933) acquires in the metroidvania an unexpected corollary: the map is not the territory, but it is the self. The genre's cartographic interfaces have a history of their own. *Metroid* and *Metroid II: Return of Samus* (1991) provided none. *Super Metroid* introduced the automatic map consulted in the pause screen and the Map Station that downloads a region's plan in advance. *Symphony of the Night* attached to its map a percentage of completion that, once the inverted castle is discovered, famously exceeds one hundred, reaching a maximum of 200.6 per cent — the map as a metric of exhaustiveness that mocks the very idea of totality. *Metroid Prime* rendered its map as a three-dimensional hologram turned in the hand like Daedalus's model of his own building. *Hollow Knight* made cartography an economy and a discipline: its maps must be bought from the wandering cartographer Cornifer, who is found by following the sound of his humming; they are inscribed into the player's map only when the Knight rests at a bench, quill in hand; and the Knight's own position appears on the map only if the player equips the Wayward Compass, a charm that occupies one of a scarce number of notches — self-location as a resource with an opportunity cost. *Ori and the Blind Forest* (2015) restores ruined map stones with recovered fragments; *Prince of Persia: The Lost Crown* lets the player pin screenshots, "memory shards," to the map, an archive of glimpsed but unreachable places; *Animal Well* accepts the player's own stamped marks. Across these variations a single principle holds. The metroidvania's map records not the world but the subject's knowledge of the world. Its blanks are the player's ignorance made visible, Iser's *Leerstellen* literalized in a grid, and its completion is an autobiography rendered in plan.

Michel de Certeau's distinction between maps and tours, elaborated in *The Practice of Everyday Life* (1980), sharpens the point. Drawing on Charlotte Linde and William Labov's study of New Yorkers describing their apartments, overwhelmingly as itineraries ("you turn right and come into the living room") rather than as plans, de Certeau observed that the history of cartography was the progressive erasure of the tours from which maps were made. Medieval maps still carried the marks of journeys — the stages of a pilgrimage, the footprints of a migration — whereas the modern map presents a tableau from which the practices that produced it have vanished. The metroidvania's map reverses this history. It is composed of tours: every cell exists because the player walked there, so that the map is a sedimented itinerary, a map that remembers its walkers. De Certeau's essay "Walking in the City" opens on the summit of the World Trade

Center, whose spectator, lifted out of the city's grasp, enjoys the pleasure of seeing the whole — an Icarus, in de Certeau's own image, who can ignore the devices of Daedalus in the endless labyrinths below. The cartographic suspension grants the player this Icarian elevation, but only by suspending time: the map is consulted in paused play, and when play resumes the player is Theseus again. The god's-eye view is in the metroidvania a *stasimon*, not a mode of action. This is the genre's quiet critique of the panoptic: the view from above is available only to one who has stopped moving.

The map is also an instrument of power, and the genre's pleasure in the blank space has a genealogy it cannot disown. Joseph Conrad's Marlow, in *Heart of Darkness* (1899), recalls the cartographic desire of his boyhood: "At that time there were many blank spaces on the earth, and when I saw one that looked particularly inviting on a map (but they all look that) I would put my finger on it and say, When I grow up I will go there." By the time he went, the blank space at the heart of Africa had been filled with rivers and lakes and names; "it had ceased to be a blank space of delightful mystery," he says, and "had become a place of darkness." J. B. Harley's "Deconstructing the Map" (1989) read maps as rhetorical texts whose apparent neutrality conceals the interests of the powers that commission them and whose silences are as eloquent as their inscriptions. Mary Louise Pratt's *Imperial Eyes* (1992) identified in Victorian exploration writing — Richard Burton at Lake Tanganyika, John Hanning Speke at the lake he named for his queen — a recurrent scene she called, after William Cowper's verses on the castaway Alexander Selkirk, the "monarch-of-all-I-survey": the explorer on an eminence, aestheticizing the landscape below, loading it with meaning, and asserting, in the act of beholding it, a relation of mastery. Fuller and Jenkins's comparison of Nintendo's spatial games with New World travel writing belongs to the same critique. The metroidvania inherits Marlow's boyhood. Its blanks invite; its completion percentage measures a conquest; and its explorer is frequently an agent of empire, as Samus, bounty hunter in the service of a Galactic Federation, is sent in *Metroid II* to exterminate a species while a counter of survivors diminishes on her display. The childlike pleasure of filling the map is inseparable from the imaginary of the blank space. Yet, as Chapter Five argues, the metroidvania's maps are finally maps of a self, and its explorer, in the canonical works, is transformed into the explored. Marlow's place of darkness proves, in the genre, to be the explorer's own interior.

A countertradition of cartography sought to map not territory but experience. Guy Debord's "Theory of the Dérive" (1956) proposed drifting through the city in response to its ambiances, and his psychogeographic map *The Naked City* (1957), subtitled as an illustration of the hypothesis of "turntables" (*plaques*

tournantes) in psychogeography, cut a map of Paris into fragments — "unities of ambiance" — and reconnected them with red arrows marking the spontaneous turns of drifting walkers. The metroidvania's map is a psychogeographic map. Its regions are unities of ambiance, each defined by palette, music, and the ecology of its creatures; its elevators, trams, and hub rooms are turntables. Kevin Lynch's *The Image of the City* (1960), with its analysis of urban legibility in terms of paths, edges, districts, nodes, and landmarks, describes the vocabulary through which the genre's designers make their worlds imageable: the colossal statue, the fountain at the heart of a rain-soaked city, the clock tower visible from every corridor of a castle. The genre codifies psychogeography while subordinating the dérive's purposelessness to a telos. But its longest optional regions invite something like a drift within the telos, an errancy in Ovid's sense that is neither lost nor yet directed.

The maze has also been, for more than a century, an instrument of experimental psychology, and its laboratory history illuminates the genre's cognitive substrate. The first rat maze, built by Willard Small around 1900, was modelled on the hedge maze at Hampton Court: the garden labyrinth entered the laboratory directly. Edward Tolman's "Cognitive Maps in Rats and Men" (1948) argued, against the behaviourism of his day, that animals construct internal maps of their environment; his experiments with Charles Honzik on "latent learning" (1930) showed that rats permitted to explore a maze without reward learned its layout as thoroughly as rewarded rats, a knowledge that remained invisible until food was introduced and then manifested at once. Exploration without reward builds a map that a later motive activates. The metroidvania's prolepsis is latent learning made aesthetic: the player who wanders a region whose secrets cannot yet be reached builds the map that a future capacity will activate. Neuroscience has since located such maps in the brain. John O'Keefe identified place cells in the hippocampus in 1971, and with Lynn Nadel proposed *The Hippocampus as a Cognitive Map* (1978); May-Britt and Edvard Moser identified grid cells in 2005, and the three shared the Nobel Prize in 2014. Matthew Wilson and Bruce McNaughton showed in 1994 that sequences of place-cell activity recorded during waking exploration are replayed during subsequent sleep, a mechanism of memory consolidation. *Hollow Knight*'s benches, at which alone the day's paths are inscribed into the map, model this consolidation with an exactness its designers need not have intended. Experience becomes map only at rest. The bench is the hippocampus of Hallownest, and the stasimon the place where the paths of the day are written.

Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980) supplies the definitive cinematic meditation on the labyrinth's double vision, and its moral is the genre's own. Kubrick

replaced the topiary animals of Stephen King's novel with a hedge maze, and in one celebrated sequence Jack Torrance peers down at a scale model of the maze in the hotel lobby while the camera's descent toward the model dissolves into an aerial view of his wife and son walking in the real maze outside: the god's-eye view as the madman's. At the film's climax Danny, pursued through the snow-bound maze by his father, walks backward in his own footprints, steps off the trail, and hides; Jack follows the false track and freezes to death in the labyrinth he had surveyed from above. The child who retraces his own steps escapes; the father who possessed the overview dies within the maze. The view from above is necessary but insufficient. Salvation lies in the walker's *mētis*, the cunning capacity to return upon one's own path, and the metroidvania, which grants both visions, reserves its deepest rewards for the second.

2.6 *Shakkei and Miegakure*

The Japanese Garden as Proto-Level

Two traditions of garden design embody the labyrinth's double vision in opposed forms. The formal garden that André Le Nôtre laid out at Versailles from the 1660s is composed along an axis issuing from the palace, so that from the king's windows its parterres, basins, and avenues present themselves to a single sovereign gaze: the absolutist garden, the monarch-of-all-I-survey materialized in clipped hedges and water. The Japanese stroll garden (*kaiyū-shiki teien*, literally the "circuit-style" garden), perfected by the imperial and daimyō households of the Edo period — the Katsura Imperial Villa in Kyoto, Kenroku-en in Kanazawa, Kōraku-en in Okayama, Rikugi-en in Edo, laid out in 1702 to evoke eighty-eight scenes from celebrated poems — refuses the total view. It is composed for a walker rather than a viewer, unfolding as a sequence of scenes along a circuit, and there is no point within it from which the whole may be grasped. Versailles is a designed spectacle of space for an eye; the stroll garden is a designed experience of space in time for a body. The metroidvania holds both, the stroll in its play and Versailles in its map, but its deepest affinities lie with the stroll garden, whose techniques constitute something very like a proto-level-design.

The first of these techniques is *miegakure* (見え隠れ), "seen-and-hidden": the practice by which a feature — a pavilion, a waterfall, a stone lantern, a bridge — is glimpsed through foliage or across water, lost behind a hill or a bend in the path, and recovered later from another angle and in another light. Anticipation is cultivated and withheld; the garden is never present all at once, and each of its scenes is charged with the memory of earlier glimpses and the promise of later ones. The dry landscape garden of Ryōan-ji in Kyoto carries the principle to its limit. It is commonly observed that from no single point on its viewing veranda can all fifteen of its stones be seen at once; one is always withheld. The total view is not merely unavailable but structurally impossible. The metroidvania practises miegakure with a precision its designers have rarely needed to theorize: the energy tank glimpsed behind glass, the door seen across a chasm that cannot be crossed, the chamber visible from below whose entrance lies elsewhere. Each is a choreographed glimpse, and Ryōan-ji's withheld fifteenth stone has its counterpart in the one item that the player whose map reads ninety-nine per cent has never found, a condition Chapter Eight examines under the name Bloch and Adorno gave it.

The second technique is *shakkei* (借景), "borrowed scenery": the incorporation into a garden's composition of a landscape that lies beyond its bounds, framed by clipped hedges and the trunks of trees. The garden of Entsū-ji in

northern Kyoto frames the distant cone of Mount Hiei; the pond garden of Tenryū-ji borrows the wooded slopes of Arashiyama. The borrowed mountain can be seen but never reached from within the garden, and its presence is a debt the garden can never repay. The metroidvania's parallax backgrounds borrow in exactly this manner, painting at a distance the regions the player cannot yet reach — a far city, a colossal tree, a smoking mountain at the edge of the world. But here the borrowing is a loan rather than a gift. The genre repays its borrowed scenery, delivering the player, hours later, into the very landscape that once formed its background, and the moment of arrival carries the specific satisfaction of a debt discharged. The metroidvania is a garden that repays its borrowed scenery.

The third principle belongs to architecture and urban form. In "Japanese City Spaces and the Concept of *Oku*" (1979), Fumihiko Maki described *oku*, the innermost, as the organizing depth of Japanese space: not a centre in the Western sense, a point of convergence and display, but a recessive interior approached through successive enfolding layers and never wholly arrived at. The approach (*sandō*) to a Shinto shrine passes beneath a sequence of *torii*, each a threshold that both admits and defers, toward a sanctuary that may itself be closed. At Ise, the innermost precinct is withheld from the public altogether; the *oku* is present as an inaccessibility. And Ise embodies a temporality as palintropic as its space. In the ritual of *shikinen sengū*, its sanctuaries are rebuilt every twenty years on an adjacent site in identical form — the sixty-second rebuilding was completed in 2013 — so that the shrine is at once the same and not the same, Heraclitus's river rendered in cypress. The metroidvania's regions approach their own *oku* through layered gates; their sanctums remain closed until late in play; and their worlds, re-entered, prove identical and new.

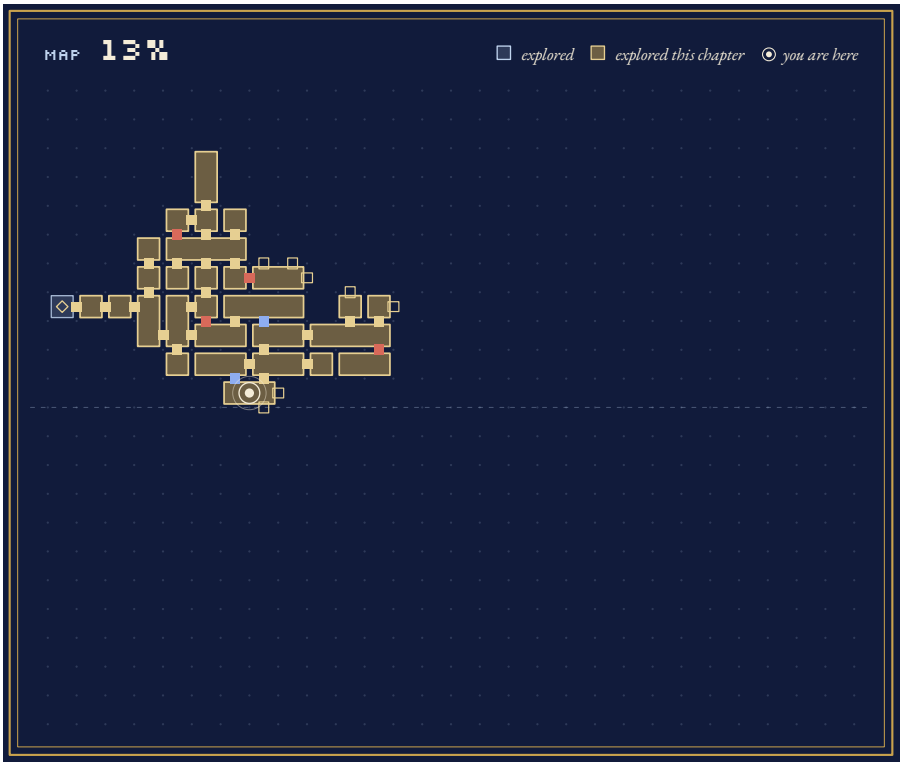
The fourth figure is a threshold. The tea house of the *wabi* tradition associated with Sen no Rikyū in the sixteenth century is entered through the *nijiriguchi*, the "crawl-in entrance," an opening of roughly two feet square through which the guest must stoop and crawl, having first left his sword on a rack outside; the tradition reads the gesture as a teaching of humility and of equality before the tea. The house is approached through the *roji*, the "dewy path," a garden whose passage prepares the guest for what lies within. The *nijiriguchi* unites in a single architectural gesture the two operations the metroidvania most characteristically demands at its thresholds: the contraction of the body, which the Morph Ball tunnel requires, and the surrender of power, which Chapter Six will read in the Sumerian Inanna's divestiture at the gates of the underworld. Space here is initiation, and the threshold is a discipline of the body.

The fifth figure is dramaturgical. Zeami Motokiyo (c. 1363–c. 1443) perfected the dream play, *mugen nō*, whose canonical structure is palintropic. A travelling monk, the *waki*, arrives at a place celebrated in poetry or legend and meets a local person who recounts the place's story with uncanny intimacy before vanishing. In the second act the same figure returns in its true form, as the ghost of the story's protagonist, and re-enacts its passion before dawn. The ghost enters along the *hashigakari*, the bridgeway that joins the stage to the "mirror room" behind the curtain and so stages, in the architecture of the theatre itself, the passage between worlds. The meaning of the place is disclosed only in the second visitation: a first encounter in disguise, a return in truth. Zeami's rhythmic principle of *jo-ha-kyū* — introduction, breaking, rapid culmination — governed in his theory not only the whole programme but each play, each scene, and each gesture, in a recurrence across scales that anticipates the fractal character of the palintropic pentad. The metroidvania's revisited rooms frequently release their ghosts in Zeami's manner. *Hollow Knight*'s Dream Nail, which permits the Knight to read the thoughts of the living and the dead and to enter the dreams of sleepers, converts every return into a potential second act, in which the place's resident speaks at last in its true voice.

These correspondences are analogical rather than genealogical. No claim is made here that the designers of *Metroid* consciously adapted the theory of the stroll garden or the dramaturgy of Nō. But a culture's spatial sensibility is not chosen by its designers; it is inhabited by them. One anecdote, often retold, suggests how intimately the genre's founding culture joined exploration to return. Shigeru Miyamoto, growing up in the countryside of Sonobe near Kyoto, is said to have discovered a cave in the hills and to have returned, after some hesitation, with a lantern: the archetypal key item, the light source, in the childhood of the medium's most celebrated designer, and the archetypal act, the return. The Japanese tradition had long cultivated an art of sequenced revelation, layered depth, constricted threshold, borrowed distance, impossible totality, and revelatory return. The form that emerged from Nintendo's Kyoto offices and their rivals in 1986 was born into a culture in which space was already understood palintropically.

STASIMON

II



The metroidvania's ancestor is the labyrinth, but not any single one of the labyrinth's historical forms. From Knossos it inherits the double vision Doob traced — order beheld from above, bewilderment suffered within — and grants its walker both in alternation. From Daedalus it inherits the three primordial technologies of the thread, the wing, and the ant; from Homer and Plutarch, the choreographic substratum of a labyrinth that was a dance before it was a building; from Ovid, the image of a river that plays and meets its own future. Against Eco's three static labyrinths it constitutes a fourth, the palintropic labyrinth, which evolves through all three in the course of being walked and inverts the relation between connectivity and legibility: a finite rhizome under memory. Borges supplies its limit cases — the periodic library whose repeated disorder becomes order, the lockless house of Asterion whose iteration is the nightmare of padding, the wallless desert, the garden of forking paths that the genre inverts into a garden of converging ones. The cave of the Crowthers and the castles of Robinett bequeath the narrow passage, the knowledge-gate, the colour-coded lock, and the signed secret room; the flip-screen bequeaths the room as stanza and the sub-

lime of the edge. The map is revealed as a map of the self, a sedimented tour, an instrument of imperial desire, and a figure of memory consolidated at rest. And the Japanese garden discloses, in miegakure *and* shakkei*,* oku *and* nijiriguchi*, the rebuilt shrine and the returning ghost, a culture in which the palintropic was already an art.*

What these inheritances share is the figure with which the next chapter begins: the thing that can be seen and not reached. The ledge beyond the leap, the glimpse through foliage, the borrowed mountain, the stone invisible from every point on the veranda, the blank on the map beneath a boy's poised finger — these are the phantasms that Agamben's stanza shelters. The chorus, standing, turns its attention to them. It is time to ask what kind of object the visible unreachable is, and why it should be desired.

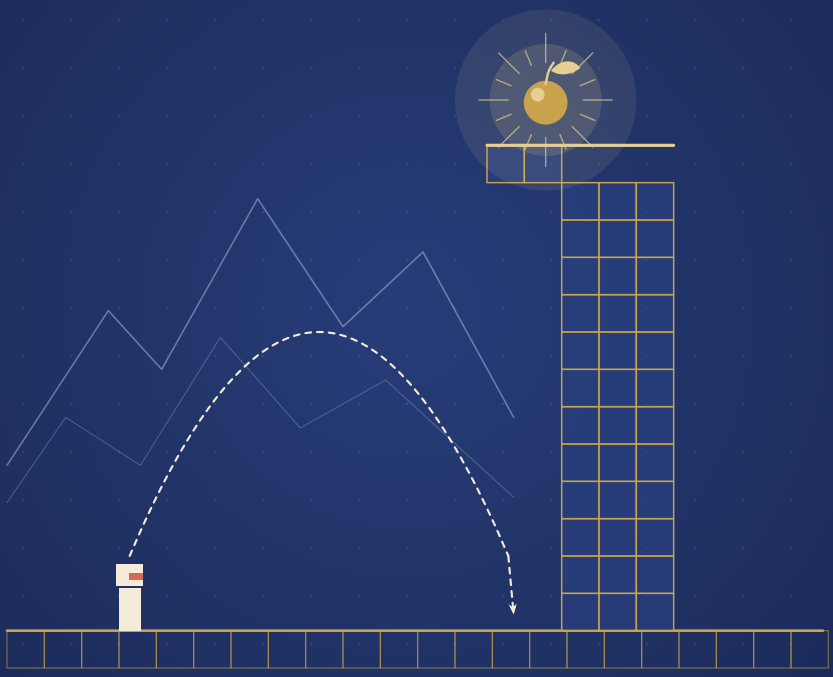
CHAPTER THREE

γ'

Prolepsis

πρόληψις

The Visible Unreachable



Mais comme il n'y pouvait atteindre: / « Ils sont trop verts, dit-il, et bons pour des goujats. » / Fit-il pas mieux que de se plaindre?

But since he could not reach them: "They are too green," he said, "and fit for louts." Did he not do better than to complain?

— Jean de La Fontaine, "Le Renard et les Raisins," *Fables* III.11 (1668)

θηρευτὴς δεινός, ἀεί τινας πλέκων μηχανάς.

A formidable hunter, forever weaving some contrivance.

— Diotima on Eros, in Plato, *Symposium* 203d

3.1 *The Ledge*

Anatomy of a Promise

Every metroidvania contains, usually within its first minutes, a scene so common that its strangeness is easily missed. The player is shown something she cannot have. A ledge rises just above the apex of the avatar's leap, and on it, sometimes, an object glints. A corridor continues beyond a gap too wide to cross. A cache gleams behind a lattice of blocks that no weapon in the present arsenal will break. A door is visible across a chasm, or beneath a lake of acid, or at the end of a passage too low for the body to enter. None of these is a puzzle in the usual sense, since nothing the player can do now will solve it. And none is an ornament, since the genre's conventions guarantee that what is shown will, in time, be reached. The visible unreachable is the genre's most characteristic object, and it is the object of the movement this dissertation calls prolepsis.

The proleptic display has an anatomy, and its components can be distinguished. The first is *visibility*. The unreachable is framed, lit, and placed within the field of view with a deliberation that marks it as significant; often it is also audible, as when the trapped grubs of *Hollow Knight* can be heard crying for rescue from chambers the Knight cannot yet enter, or when Cornifer's humming announces a cartographer somewhere beyond the next impasse. Prolepsis is not exclusively optical; there is an acoustic prolepsis, in which sound reaches where the body cannot. The second component is *calibrated distance*. The unreachable is near enough to tempt and far enough to forbid, and the most effective instances place it only slightly beyond present capacity: the ledge a few pixels above the apex of the highest jump, the gap a body's length wider than the longest dash. The near-miss is pedagogical. The leap that almost succeeds measures, with a precision no tutorial could equal, the size of the capacity that is lacking.

The third component is *the legibility of the obstacle*. The genre's impasses are not opaque; they announce, by their form, the kind of capacity that will dissolve them, and in doing so they constitute a semiotics of the gate that runs the whole range of Charles Sanders Peirce's typology of signs. Some gates are icons, resembling their keys: the ball-sized tunnel at floor level is the negative image of the Morph Ball, its form the mould of the form that will fill it. Some are indices, physically connected to what they signify: the height of a ledge indexes the vertical capacity it demands, as the shimmer of superheated air indexes the protection that will permit its crossing and the weight of deep water the suit that will permit movement within it. Some are symbols, conventional and learned: the colour of a hatch in the *Metroid* series signifies the ordnance that opens it

only by a code the player must acquire. To read a metroidvania's world is to read its gates as signs of their keys, and the player who has learned the genre's semiotics perceives every impasse as a sentence with a missing word.

The fourth component is *mnemonic inscription*. The unreachable must be remembered if it is to be returned to, and the genre secures this memory by two means: the player's own retention, which the Zeigarnik effect of the interrupted task reinforces, and the map, which in later works marks glimpsed but uncollected items with icons, so that the cartographic interface becomes an archive of deferred desire. The fifth component, the condition of all the others, is *the contract of deferral*. In a letter of 1889, Anton Chekhov advised a fellow writer that one should not place a loaded rifle on the stage if no one intends to fire it, and the principle has since been generalized into a law of narrative economy. The metroidvania transposes Chekhov's rifle into space: every visible ledge must be reachable before the credits roll. The genre's conventions make this a contract, and violations — decorative spaces that prove permanently inaccessible, items glimpsed and never obtainable — are felt by players not as design choices but as betrayals.

The temporality of the proleptic object is the future anterior. The ledge is apprehended as a place I *will have reached*. Gérard Genette's *Narrative Discourse* (1972), developed through an analysis of Proust's *In Search of Lost Time*, gave narratology its terms for the anachronies of the story: *prolepsis*, the narration of an event before its turn, and *analepsis*, the return to an event already past. The metroidvania spatializes Genette's categories. Its glimpsed and unreachable places are prolepses rendered in architecture, flash-forwards inscribed in the level; its returns are analepses, in which the player, re-entering a room visited hours before, re-encounters the earlier visit within the present one. The genre's architecture is its narrative discourse, and its order of rooms, like Proust's order of episodes, is a calculated play of anticipation and recollection. Proust's novel, which ends with the narrator's recognition of a vocation that had been his all along, is perhaps the great palintropic narrative of modern literature, and Chapter Six will return to it.

The proleptic display is, finally, a promise, and the promise has a logic. J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) distinguished from statements, which describe, the performative utterances by which something is done in the saying — among which the promise is paradigmatic — and catalogued the "infelicities" by which performatives fail. The placement of an unreachable object is a performative in Austin's sense: an act by which the world binds itself to a future, felicitous if kept and infelicitous, a misfire or an abuse, if not. Friedrich Nietzsche, opening the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality*

(1887), asked whether the paradoxical task nature had set itself in the case of the human being was precisely to breed an animal with the right to make promises, and he located the origin of such an animal in a memory of the will engraved by pain. The metroidvania reverses the terms of Nietzsche's genealogy. Here it is the world that promises, and the player who must hold the world to its word; the memory required is not burned in by punishment but cultivated by desire.

Giorgio Agamben's *Stanzas*, whose account of the room as receptacle of a phantasm Chapter Two invoked, defines melancholy, in one of its most striking pages, as the imaginative capacity to make an unobtainable object appear as if lost: the melancholic mourns what was never possessed, and thereby possesses it in the mode of loss. The proleptic object is melancholy's inverse. It is an unobtainable object made to appear not as lost but as promised; it is possessed not in the mode of mourning but in the mode of expectation. The genre converts the phantasm of melancholy into the phantasm of hope, and the room that, for the poets Agamben studied, sheltered the image of a beloved forever out of reach shelters, in the metroidvania, the image of a ledge that will be reached. The sections that follow analyse this conversion phenomenologically, ontologically, erotically, epistemologically, and ethically.

3.2 *Empty Intention and Fulfilment*

The phenomenological analysis of prolepsis begins from a distinction Edmund Husserl drew in the Sixth of his *Logical Investigations* (1900–01). Every act of consciousness intends an object, but intentions differ in their mode of givenness. Some are *empty*, or signitive: they mean their object without its being given, as when I speak of a city I have never seen. Others are *fulfilled*: the object meant is given in intuition, as when I stand in the city's square. Knowledge, on Husserl's account, is the synthesis of fulfilment (*Erfüllungssynthese*) in which an empty intention and a corresponding intuition coincide, an identification in which the object is experienced as "itself there." When the coincidence is complete, the experience is *evidence* (*Evidenz*), the lived experience of truth. Fulfilment admits of degrees, and intention may also be *disappointed* (*Enttäuschung*), when the intuition that arrives conflicts with what was meant.

Husserl's later work generalized the distinction into a theory of the horizon. Every perception, he argued in *Ideas I* (1913) and subsequently in the *Cartesian Meditations* (1931) and *Experience and Judgment* (1939), is surrounded by a horizon of co-intended but unfulfilled possibilities: an inner horizon of the object's unseen aspects, the back of the house whose front I see, and an outer horizon of the world in which the object stands. These horizons are not blank. They are structured by familiarity and by what Husserl called typicality: I anticipate the back of a house *as* the back of a house, with a determinate range of possible appearances. Perception is a continuous play of anticipation and fulfilment in which every fulfilment opens new horizons. The metroidvania makes this structure explicit and spatial. The blanks of its map are the outer horizon of the explored world, rendered as a visible absence; the glimpsed ledge is the inner horizon of the room, its unreached aspect, held present to the eye.

Husserl's lectures on *Thing and Space* (1907) added a crucial refinement. Perception, he argued, is correlated with kinaesthetic systems: appearances are motivated by bodily movements in a conditional structure — *if* I move my eyes or my body thus, *then* the appearance will unfold thus — so that the visual field is organized by the movements the body could make. The metroidvania's world is a vast system of such conditionals whose antecedents are capacities the subject does not yet possess. If I could leap higher, then that ledge; if I could become small, then that passage; if I could withstand heat, then that cavern. The gate is a perceptual conditional with a counterfactual antecedent. What the genre does, with a precision no other medium has matched, is decouple the optical horizon from the kinaesthetic. The unreachable ledge is visually fulfilled and kinaesthetically empty: given to sight and withheld from movement. The resulting expe-

rience has a specific phenomenological texture, which may be called the *motor empty intention* — not "I cannot" but "I cannot yet" — and whose relation to Merleau-Ponty's account of motor intentionality Chapter Five develops.

In everyday life the arc from empty intention to fulfilment is short and therefore invisible. I reach for the cup and the reach is fulfilled; intentionality withdraws into the success of action and is never noticed as such. The metroidvania stretches this arc across hours of play, and in stretching it renders it perceptible as a structure. It suspends fulfilment as Husserl's *epochē* suspends the natural attitude's belief in the existence of the world, and with an analogous result: what had been transparent becomes thematic. The genre performs, as a matter of design, an *epochē of fulfilment* — a phenomenological reduction carried out by architecture, in which the player, unable to reach, becomes aware of reaching. This is perhaps the deepest sense in which the metroidvania is a philosophical form. It does not illustrate the phenomenology of intention; it brackets the ordinary consummation of intention so that intention itself appears.

The return completes the analysis. When the player comes back with the capacity the ledge required, the synthesis of fulfilment occurs with the force of evidence: the coincidence of what was meant hours earlier with what is now given. The experience is rarely confined to the ledge itself. Because the newly acquired capacity answers not one empty intention but many, its acquisition precipitates a cascade of fulfilments across the remembered world, and the player's mental map reorganizes around them; this is the phenomenological ground of the topological anagnorisis Chapter Six analyses. Nor is fulfilment ever total. For Husserl, the adequate givenness of an external object is an ideal, an "idea in the Kantian sense" toward which perception tends without arriving, because every fulfilment opens new horizons. The metroidvania enacts this principle at every scale: the ledge reached discloses, from its new vantage, another ledge beyond it. The genre also knows disappointment. A newly acquired leap that still falls short of a remembered height is a frustrated intention, a correction of the horizon that teaches the player something about the typicality of gates — that this impasse belonged to a different family of capacities than had been assumed — and well-made works deploy such disappointments deliberately, as instruments of calibration.

Wolfgang Iser imported Husserl's analyses of retention and protention into the theory of reading. In *The Act of Reading* (1976), the reader occupies a "wandering viewpoint" that moves through the text, retaining what has been read and anticipating what is to come, so that each sentence modifies the expectations raised by earlier ones and retrospectively alters the meaning of what preceded it; the reader assembles from this movement a coherent object through what Iser

called consistency-building. The metroidvania player's wandering viewpoint is literal: a body moving through structured space, retaining rooms and anticipating ledges, assembling from the movement a coherent world whose consistency is the completed map. The genre is reception theory made walkable, and Iser's blanks, as Chapter One observed, are its map's blank cells.

Husserl's phenomenology describes how the unreachable is intended. It does not say what the unreachable *is*. The visible ledge is, on Husserl's account, simply there, a determinate object given in a determinate mode. But the metroidvania insists on something more: that the ledge belongs to a world not yet finished for the one who sees it, a world whose being includes its not-yet. For an ontology adequate to this insistence the argument must turn from the phenomenology of consciousness to the philosophy of hope.

3.3 *Vor-Schein*

Bloch and the Ontology of the Not-Yet

Ernst Bloch (1885–1977) is the philosopher of the visible unreachable. His *Spirit of Utopia* (1918) and, above all, *The Principle of Hope* (*Das Prinzip Hoffnung*), written in American exile between 1938 and 1947 and published in three volumes in East Berlin between 1954 and 1959, constitute an encyclopedia of anticipation: a survey of every form in which human beings have reached beyond the present toward something better — daydreams and fairy tales, travel and the circus, fashion and architecture, medicine, music, and religion. Its organizing category is the Not-Yet (*Noch-Nicht*), and it is the only major philosophical system of the twentieth century whose central object is precisely what the metroidvania displays: the not-yet-reached, present in advance of its attainment.

Bloch distinguished two dimensions of the Not-Yet. Subjectively, there is the Not-Yet-Conscious (*Noch-Nicht-Bewusstes*), the preconscious of what is coming, the dawning of ideas and wishes that have not yet acquired articulate form. Bloch set it explicitly against Freud's unconscious, which he characterized as a No-Longer-Conscious (*Nicht-Mehr-Bewusstes*), the repository of a repressed past; psychoanalysis, on his account, looked only backward, toward the cellar of the psyche, and neglected its forward-facing attic. Objectively, there is the Not-Yet-Become (*Noch-Nicht-Gewordenes*), the unfinished and processual character of reality itself, in which possibility is not a mere logical category but an ontological one, the "objectively-real possible." Bloch condensed this ontology into a logical formula: *S is not yet P*. The subject has not yet attained its predicate; the world is in process toward an identity it has not yet reached. He called the leading edge of this process the Front, named the genuinely new that emerges at it the *Novum*, and observed that the present itself is the most obscure of times. In what he called the darkness of the lived moment, the immediate now is opaque to itself and becomes visible only in anticipation or retrospect.

The metroidvania's avatar is Bloch's formula incarnate. *S is not yet P*: the subject whose predicates — its leap, its armour, its capacity to become small or to withstand the abyss — lie scattered across a world, not yet attained. The genre's world is Not-Yet-Become for its subject, not in itself (the data of the level are fixed) but in its significance for the one who explores it, a distinction Chapter Five develops through Uexküll's concept of the *Umwelt*. Every gate marks a Front. And the genre's map, examined in this light, discloses a remarkable structure. It contains two modalities of absence and two of presence: the explored regions, which are the No-Longer of the player's past traversals, and the glimpsed but unreached regions, which are the Not-Yet of the player's anticipations. The

map unifies Freud's No-Longer-Conscious and Bloch's Not-Yet-Conscious in a single diagram of the not-present. It also verifies Bloch's darkness of the lived moment with almost uncanny precision. During play, the room one occupies is the least surveyable of all, navigated from within, without overview; the rooms one has left and the rooms one anticipates are the ones the map makes clear.

Bloch's aesthetic category for the presence of the not-yet in the present is *Vor-Schein*, anticipatory illumination or pre-appearance. Art's beautiful semblance (*Schein*) becomes, in his account, a pre-semblance (*Vor-Schein*) of a better state realizable but not yet realized: the artwork shows forth in advance what the world might become. The visible unreachable is Vor-Schein in the strictest sense — a showing-forth, within the present, of what is not yet attained and is shown precisely as attainable. Bloch, moreover, sought the utopian surplus of human longing not only in high art but in what he called colportage, the popular adventure fiction, fairground spectacle, and dime-novel romance he analysed in *Heritage of Our Times* (1935), and in the fairy tale, whose cunning youngest sons and resourceful tailors outwit giants by wit and courage and so carry, on his reading, a political promise of the small prevailing over the powerful. Unlike Theodor Adorno, who regarded mass culture as administered regression, Bloch read popular forms for their wish-images. A popular game genre is exactly the kind of object his method was built to read, and the metroidvania — whose small, cunning, initially powerless protagonist outwits a world of giants by acquiring, piece by piece, the means to pass — is a fairy tale in Bloch's sense.

Bloch distinguished abstract utopia, wishful thinking without mediation, from concrete utopia, a hope that recognizes the real tendencies and latencies of the world and works through them, and he called the hope proper to concrete utopia *docta spes*, educated hope. The metroidvania's prolepsis is a training in concrete utopia. The better place is visible, and the way to it is real, but it must be found, and it is mediated by exploration, struggle, and return. The genre refuses at once the despair that would declare the ledge impossible and the wishful thinking that would have it reached by wishing. It is a school of *docta spes*, a pedagogy of hope with a route.

The Principle of Hope ends with a sentence that has become one of the most quoted in German philosophy. When human beings have grasped themselves and established what is theirs without alienation, Bloch writes, there arises in the world "etwas, das allen in die Kindheit scheint und worin noch niemand war: Heimat" — something that shines into everyone's childhood and in which no one has yet been: home. The metroidvania possesses exactly this double temporality. It shines into childhood, as the genre's persistent eight-bit iconography and its players' memories of graph-paper maps attest; and it points toward a place

in which no one has yet been, the unexplored region and the completed world. Its canonical works frequently close by returning the hero to an origin: the gunship waiting on the surface of Zebes, the Spirit Tree from which Ori fell, the forlorn town of Dirtmouth above the ruins of Hallownest. The place of origin, revisited at the end, is a place never yet inhabited, because the one who returns is not the one who left. The genre's ending is Bloch's *Heimat* in miniature: a home reached only by leaving it and coming back.

Stendhal's formula that beauty is only the promise of happiness (*la beauté n'est que la promesse du bonheur*) was taken up by Adorno in his *Aesthetic Theory* (1970), with a crucial inflection: art keeps faith with happiness only by breaking its promise, since an artwork that delivered the happiness it promised would collapse into affirmation of the world as it is. The metroidvania keeps its promises — every ledge is reached — and an Adornian critic might accordingly convict it of regressive consolation. The objection is serious, and the genre's answer is structural. Its fulfilments are local, and each produces new not-yets; the ledge reached discloses another, so that fulfilment renews desire rather than extinguishing it. And at the moment when every promise has been kept — at one hundred per cent, the map complete — the genre characteristically destroys its world: the planet explodes, the castle crumbles, the labyrinth collapses behind the departing hero. The metroidvania thus preserves, in its own idiom, Adorno's insight that total fulfilment threatens the promise, by staging total fulfilment as the end of the world. Chapter Nine returns to this apocalyptic consummation.

3.4 *The Erotics of the Ledge*

Diotima, Sappho, Poros, and Penia

The lyric tradition of the West possesses an image of the visible unreachable older than any labyrinth's story, and it is an image of desire. A fragment of Sappho, preserved by the late-antique rhetorician Syrianus and thought to come from a wedding song (fr. 105a), compares its subject to an apple:

> οἷον τὸ γλυκύμαλον ἐρεύθεται ἄκρῳ ἐπ' ὔσδῳ, / ἄκρον ἐπ' ἀκροτάτῳ, λελάθοντο δὲ μαλοδρόπηες· / οὐ μὰν ἐκλελάθοντ', ἀλλ' οὐκ ἐδύναντ' ἐπίκεσθαι.
>
> *As the sweet apple reddens at the tip of the bough, topmost on the topmost, and the apple-pickers forgot it — no, they did not forget it: they could not reach it.*

The fragment turns on a self-correction, and the correction is philosophically exact. The pickers did not *forget* the apple (the verb is *lanthanomai*, whose root gives *lēthē*, oblivion, and so, by privation, *alētheia*); they *could not reach* it. Sappho distinguishes, in a single line, between two ways in which an object may remain ungathered: by oblivion, and by unreachability. The visible unreachable is precisely the second. It is not lost to memory but held by it, present to the eye and absent to the hand, and its desirability is constituted by that conjunction. Anne Carson's *Eros the Bittersweet* (1986), which reads this fragment at length, argued that eros is structurally a lack and that its activation requires three terms: the lover, the beloved, and that which comes between them. The obstacle is not an accident of desire but one of its constituents. The metroidvania reproduces Carson's triangle with diagrammatic clarity. Player and object are joined by a gap, the measured shortfall of the leap, and the gap is what makes the object an object of desire at all. The genre's ledges are Sappho's apples, and its gates are the topmost bough.

Plato gave this structure a mythic genealogy. In the *Symposium* (203b–e), Diotima recounts that at the feast celebrating the birth of Aphrodite, Poros — Resource, Expedient, etymologically the passage or ford, and himself the son of Mētis — drank deep of nectar and fell asleep in the garden of Zeus. Penia, Poverty, came begging at the door, and, "plotting on account of her own *aporia* to have a child by Poros," lay down beside him and conceived Eros. The myth's engine is literally aporia seeking poros: lack, conscious of its lack, scheming to unite with passage. From this union Eros inherits a double nature. Like his mother he is always poor, hard, squalid, barefoot and homeless, sleeping on the bare ground under the open sky, "at doors and in the roads" (*epi thurais kai en hodois*). Like his father he is a schemer after the beautiful and the good, brave

and intense, "a formidable hunter, forever weaving some contrivance," desirous of understanding and resourceful (*porimos*), a lover of wisdom all his life. He is neither immortal nor mortal: on the same day he flourishes when his resources prosper, and dies, and comes back to life again through his father's nature, while whatever he gains is always slipping away. He is never without resource and never rich, but always between — the *metaxu* of wisdom and ignorance that Diotima identifies as the condition of the philosopher.

The correspondence between Diotima's Eros and the metroidvania's protagonist is closer than analogy usually permits. The avatar begins poor, stripped of capacities, and acquires them as resources one by one. It is a dweller at thresholds and on paths, sleeping, as it were, at the doors of the world, and its places of rest — save rooms, benches, shrines — are characteristically set beside the gates it cannot yet open. It is, in the canonical instances, literally a hunter: Samus Aran is a bounty hunter, and *Hollow Knight* assigns its Knight a Hunter's Journal in which each creature slain is recorded. It weaves contrivances, combining capacities to reach what no single capacity would. And, most strikingly, it dies and comes back to life on the same day through the nature of its resources: the genre's mechanics of death and return, in which the avatar falls and revives at the last threshold of rest, often having lost what it was carrying — *Hollow Knight*'s Knight leaves its gathered wealth with a shade of its former self, which must be sought and defeated to recover it — enact with uncanny literalness Diotima's Eros, who perishes and is reborn through his father's resourcefulness while what he gains slips away.

The myth also clarifies the agency of the gate. In Diotima's account it is Penia, not Poros, who acts. Lack schemes; resource sleeps. The metroidvania's gates are Penia's schemes: placed by design, they plot to unite with the player's resources in order to beget desire. Sarah Kofman, tracing *poros* and *aporia* across Greek thought in *Comment s'en sortir?*, observed that the paradigm of aporia is the open sea, the *pontos* on which no path is marked and every route must be invented, and that *poros* names first the ford or strait that permits a crossing; the Bosporus, the "cow's ford," took its name, in the legend Aeschylus recounts in *Prometheus Bound*, from the crossing of Io, transformed into a heifer — a passage achieved through metamorphosis, which Chapter Five makes the genre's law. Detienne and Vernant showed that *mētis*, Poros's mother in Plato's genealogy, is the intelligence proper to such a world: the cunning of the hunter and the fisherman, the pilot and the weaver of snares, of Athena and Hephaestus, of Daedalus and of polytropic Odysseus, an intelligence that finds passage where none is marked. The genealogy Diotima supplies — Mētis begets Poros; Poros, with Penia, begets Eros — is a theory of the metroidvania's design in miniature.

Cunning begets passage; passage, joined with lack, begets desire. The designer's *mētis* produces the poroi; the gate's aporia receives them; and the player's eros is born between.

Roland Barthes's *A Lover's Discourse* (1977) devotes one of its fragments to waiting and suggests that the lover's very identity is to be the one who waits, as the beloved is the one who never does. The metroidvania's player waits across hours, keeping faith with an unreached ledge. But the genre transforms the lover's waiting from passivity into quest: the player does not wait by the telephone but walks, and the waiting is the walking. Jacques Lacan's distinction between the object of desire and its object-cause, the *objet petit a* that is never identical with any object obtained, illuminates the genre's peculiar economy of reward. The item seized at the end of a long detour is rarely what was desired; desire, having caused the detour, passes on at once to the next visible unreachable, and the item functions less as an object than as a cause.

This is the erotics of aporia. The impasse is the origin of desire; fulfilment is always partial; and desire renews itself in the view from each newly reached ledge, from which another is invariably visible. Diotima's own account of erotic education, the ascent she describes in the *Symposium* (210a–212a) from the love of one beautiful body to the love of all bodies, of souls, of laws and institutions, of the branches of knowledge, and at last of the Beautiful itself, proceeds "as if by steps," a ladder of love whose rungs are left behind as the lover rises. The metroidvania's capacities form such a ladder, with one decisive difference. Each new rung returns the lover to the first body and shows it otherwise. The genre corrects Diotima's ladder in the direction of Heraclitus: its ascent includes descents, its upward way and its downward way are one, and the ladder of love becomes a spiral staircase.

3.5 *Meno's Paradox Dissolved*

In Plato's *Meno* (80d–e), the young Thessalian aristocrat, numbed by Socrates' questioning as by the sting of a torpedo-fish, counters with a dilemma that has haunted epistemology ever since. How will you search for something when you do not know at all what it is? Which of the things you do not know will you set before yourself as the object of your search? And if you should happen upon it, how will you know that this is the thing you did not know? Socrates restates the dilemma as what he calls an eristic argument: one cannot search for what one knows, since knowing it one has no need to search, nor for what one does not know, since one would not know what to search for. The paradox concerns the very possibility of inquiry, and every serious theory of learning must answer it.

Socrates answers with a myth and a demonstration. The myth holds that the soul is immortal, has been born many times, and has seen all things, so that what we call learning is in truth recollection, *anamnēsis*. The demonstration is conducted with an uneducated slave boy and a square drawn in the sand (82b–85b). Asked how to construct a square of double the area, the boy first proposes doubling the side, and finds that he has quadrupled the area; he then proposes a side one and a half times as long, and finds that this too fails. He falls into aporia and admits he does not know. Socrates pauses to observe that the boy, numbed as Meno had been numbed, is now better off than before: having discovered his ignorance, he will search gladly (84a–c). With further questions and further lines in the sand, the boy recognizes the solution. The double square is the square built on the diagonal — a line that had lain within the figure from the first, cutting across it, invisible to an inquirer who sought the answer by extending the sides outward. The diagonal, moreover, is incommensurable with the side, a magnitude no rational measure of the original figure could name. The episode is the metroidvania's experience in miniature: a visible goal, a sequence of failed approaches that are so many dead ends, a productive aporia, and a solution found not by extension but by a passage across, present in the figure all along.

Later philosophy offered other answers, and they converge on the concept this chapter has named. Epicurus, as Diogenes Laertius reports, held that every inquiry presupposes a *prolēpsis*, a preconception or general notion formed from repeated perception, without which one could neither name nor seek nor judge; and both Epicurean and Stoic philosophers, according to later testimony, deployed such preconceptions against the paradox of the *Meno*. Aristotle opened the *Posterior Analytics* by declaring that all teaching and all intellectual learning proceed from pre-existing knowledge, and resolved the paradox by distinguishing knowledge of a universal from knowledge of the particulars that fall under

it: one may know that every triangle has angles equal to two right angles without yet knowing that the figure inscribed in this semicircle is a triangle. Michael Polanyi's *The Tacit Dimension* (1966) took the *Meno* as its point of departure and argued that, were all knowledge explicit, the paradox would be unanswerable, since one could not even recognize a problem; that we do recognize problems and pursue them shows that "we can know more than we can tell," and that the inquirer is guided by a tacit foreknowledge of a hidden coherence not yet made explicit.

The metroidvania dissolves the paradox by splitting the object of inquiry in two. The ledge is known: it is seen, located, and remembered. The way to it is unknown. Inquiry is possible because its terminus is given in advance as a preconception in space, while what remains to be discovered is the means. And when the means are discovered, they are recognized as means through recollection. The moment a new capacity is acquired, the player recalls — often in a single flood — the impasses it answers. The thing found tells the finder what was being sought. This dissolves the paradox's second horn, the question of how one could recognize the object of one's search: one recognizes the capacity because the remembered impasses recognize it. The genre thus enacts a bidirectional anamnesis. From ledge to capacity runs the recollection of the goal, which makes the search possible; from capacity to ledge runs the recollection of the impasse, which makes the finding intelligible. Socratic recollection of eternal forms becomes the player's recollection of the world's aporiai, and the slave boy's productive numbness becomes the genre's productive impasse.

The genre literalizes the Platonic myth as well as the Socratic method. In a striking number of its canonical works the protagonist begins by losing capacities already possessed. At the threshold of Dracula's castle in *Symphony of the Night*, Death strips Alucard of his equipment. In *Metroid Prime*, an explosion aboard the frigate Orpheon disables most of Samus's suit. In *Metroid Fusion* she is infected and stripped of her armour; in *Metroid Dread* she wakes from defeat with her abilities lost. *Hollow Knight*'s Knight is a vessel returning to a kingdom whose memory it has lost; Ori is severed in infancy from the tree that bore it; *Axiom Verge*'s Trace wakes in an alien world after a fatal laboratory accident. The capacities such heroes recover are, in the strict sense, recollected: they belonged to the hero before the fall into the world, and the world returns them by stages. Learning is recollection, and the opening divestiture is the forgetting that makes recollection necessary. Chapter Six develops this structure through the Sumerian myth of Inanna, whose descent through the seven gates of the underworld inverts it.

John Bunyan's *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678) supplies a Protestant parable of the same discovery. Captured by Giant Despair and imprisoned in the dungeon of Doubting Castle, Christian and his companion Hopeful languish until Christian cries out: "What a fool, quoth he, am I, thus to lie in a stinking dungeon, when I may as well walk at liberty! I have a key in my bosom called Promise, that will, I am persuaded, open any lock in Doubting Castle." The key was in his possession throughout; its name is the very name this chapter has given the proleptic display; and the escape is an act of recollection rather than acquisition. The knowledge-gated works examined in Chapter Six make Bunyan's realization their entire structure. In *Tunic*, the player learns from scattered pages of an in-game manual of capacities that had been available from the first moment of play, and the world opens not because the body has changed but because the player has remembered what the body could always do. Meno's paradox, which Plato answered with a myth of prior lives, the metroidvania answers with an architecture: a world in which inquiry is possible because its objects are shown before they are understood, and in which every discovery is a recognition.

3.6 *Against Sour Grapes*

Lewin, Köhler, Sartre, and the Anti-Aesopian Machine

In the Aesopic fable a hungry fox sees clusters of grapes hanging from a vine, leaps for them, fails, and departs, remarking that they were unripe anyway; the moral appended in the Greek collections observes that some people, unable to achieve their ends through their own incapacity, blame circumstances instead. La Fontaine's version, which supplies this chapter's first epigraph, closes with an ironic question that seems to endorse the fox: did he not do better than to complain? The fable names an operation so universal that its phrase became proverbial: the devaluation of the unattainable. Leon Festinger's *A Theory of Cognitive Dissonance* (1957) supplied a mechanism, the reduction of the discomfort produced by holding a desire one cannot satisfy. Jon Elster's *Sour Grapes* (1983) supplied a critique. "Adaptive preference formation," the unconscious adjustment of wants to possibilities, undermines the autonomy of preferences and with it the assumption that satisfying preferences is a reliable measure of well-being; Amartya Sen and Martha Nussbaum extended the critique into the theory of justice, observing that the deprived may learn not to want what they cannot have, so that their contentment conceals their deprivation. The fox is the patron of adaptive preference.

The modern psychology of the unreachable goal begins with Kurt Lewin's topological psychology, which represented the individual's "life space" as a field of regions separated by boundaries and barriers, in which objects carry valences — *Aufforderungscharakter*, the "demand" or "invitation" character that J. J. Gibson would later acknowledge as a precursor of his affordances. In 1934 Lewin introduced the concept of "hodological space," a geometry of paths in which distance and direction are defined not by straight lines but by the preferred route to a goal, so that a barrier deflects the path into a detour. Lewin's Berlin students produced findings that bear directly on the genre. Bluma Zeigarnik's demonstration of the superior retention of interrupted tasks has already been cited. Maria Ovsiankina (1928) showed that interrupted tasks tend to be spontaneously resumed when opportunity allows — the psychological basis of the return. And Ferdinand Hoppe (1930) showed that success raises a subject's level of aspiration while failure lowers it. The metroidvania calibrates aspiration through the near-miss and through the reliable keeping of its promises, and so raises the level of aspiration where the fox's world lowers it.

Wolfgang Köhler, director from 1913 to 1920 of the Prussian Academy's anthropoid research station on Tenerife, recorded in *The Mentality of Apes* (*Intelligenzprüfungen an Anthropoiden*, 1917) a series of experiments in which chim-

panzees confronted fruit out of reach — bananas suspended from the roof of an enclosure or laid on the ground beyond the bars. The celebrated Sultan fitted two short sticks together to rake in fruit that neither stick could reach alone; others stacked boxes to climb toward suspended bananas. Köhler argued that such solutions appeared suddenly, as restructurings of the whole perceptual field, which he called insight (*Einsicht*), rather than through blind trial and error. He also devised "detour problems" (*Umwegaufgaben*), in which food was placed behind a barrier so that the animal had first to move away from it in order to reach it. Hens tended to press fruitlessly against the barrier in the direction of the food; dogs and apes could take the detour, turning their backs on the goal in order to arrive at it. Köhler's experiments are the scientific archetype of the genre's two constitutive situations: the fruit out of reach that a combined capacity will reach, and the detour that requires moving away from the goal in order to attain it. The metroidvania's entire structure is a detour problem. To reach the ledge, one must leave it, explore elsewhere, acquire what it requires, and return. The genre trains, on a scale of hours, the intelligence Köhler regarded as the mark of insight: the capacity for the *Umweg*, the backward step that is the way forward.

Jean-Paul Sartre's *Sketch for a Theory of the Emotions* (1939) adopted Lewin's hodological map and drew from it a theory of the emotions. The world of our desires and needs, Sartre wrote, appears as furrowed with strict and narrow paths leading to determinate ends: a world of instruments and of demands. When the paths become too difficult, or when no path appears, we can no longer live in a world so urgent and so hard; yet we must act. And so we try to change the world — to live it as though the relations between things and their potentialities were governed not by deterministic processes but by magic. Emotion is this magical transformation of the world. Sartre's first example is the fable's: unable to reach the grapes, I shrug, mutter that they are too green, and so confer greenness upon them in a magical act, since I cannot change the path. His others follow the same logic. Passive fear faints before the wild beast, annihilating the object by annihilating consciousness of it; sadness reduces a demanding world to affective neutrality; joy seizes its object magically, all at once. For Sartre the emotions are a degradation of consciousness, a fall into the magical: when the instrumental world is blocked, consciousness changes the world by changing itself.

Three answers to the unreachable may thus be distinguished, and Figure 3.1 sets them side by side. The first is the Aesopian: the revaluation of the object, which leaves the world unchanged and the subject diminished by the loss of a desire. The second is the Sartrean: the magical transformation of the world through emotion, which leaves the world unchanged and the subject's con-

sciousness degraded. The third is the palintropic: the preservation of the object's value, the deferral of the attempt, the detour, the acquisition of a capacity, and the return. The metroidvania is, in this precise sense, an *anti-Aesopian machine*. It refuses the fox's revaluation by guaranteeing, through its contract of deferral, that the grapes are ripe and will be reached. And it refuses Sartre's magic by offering instead a real transformation. Here the dialectic takes a remarkable turn. The acquired capacity accomplishes exactly what emotion only pretends to accomplish: it transforms the hodological map of the world, so that walls become doors and the unreachable becomes the reached. What emotion achieves magically and falsely, the capacity achieves really. The metroidvania satisfies the wish for magic without the degradation of consciousness; it is magic made true, the world re-enchanted by competence. Bloch would call this concrete utopia, Köhler insight, Lewin the restructuring of the life space.

The pedagogy has an ethical and political content that should not be overstated but should not be dismissed. A culture that trains its members to devalue the unattainable reproduces deprivation by making it invisible to those who suffer it; this is the burden of the critique of adaptive preferences. The metroidvania's training runs the other way. It keeps the unreachable desirable, teaches that the impasse is provisional, and rewards fidelity to unmet desire. In a popular form consumed by millions, this is a modest but genuine counter-training against adaptive resignation. Yet the pedagogy carries its own pathology. A world in which every impasse is provisional, every gate keyed, and every ledge promised is what the social psychologist Melvin Lerner called, in *The Belief in a Just World* (1980), a just world: a world in which effort is reliably rewarded and outcomes are deserved. The metroidvania is a just world *par excellence*, and its pedagogy of hope is inseparable from an ideology of the designed world, in which every obstacle has been placed by an intelligence that guarantees its solution. Real worlds keep no such contracts. Some grapes are out of reach for good, and some ledges are decorations. The ethics of return that Chapter Nine proposes must accordingly include an ethics of renunciation, and must ask whether the genre's hope, educated as it is, has been educated by a teacher too kind to be true.

For the present, the analysis of prolepsis may be summarized in the figure that follows.

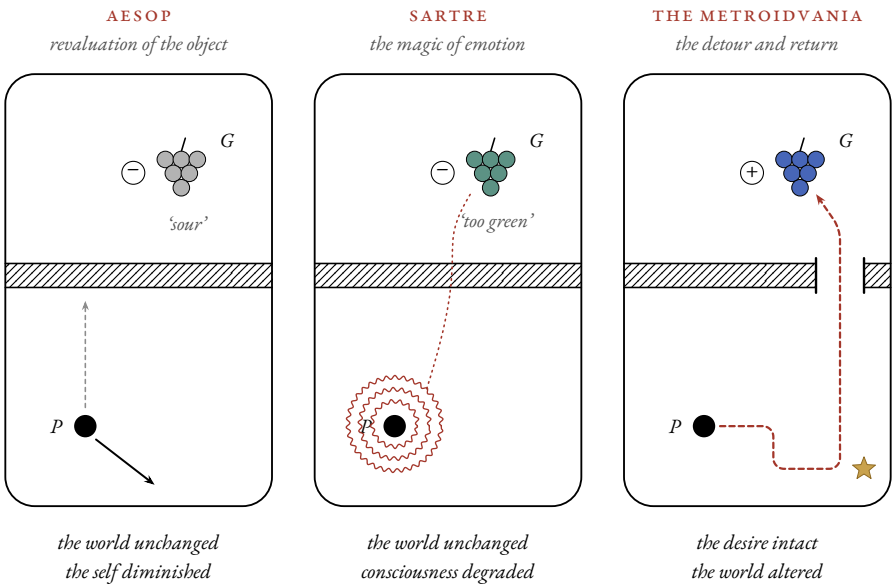
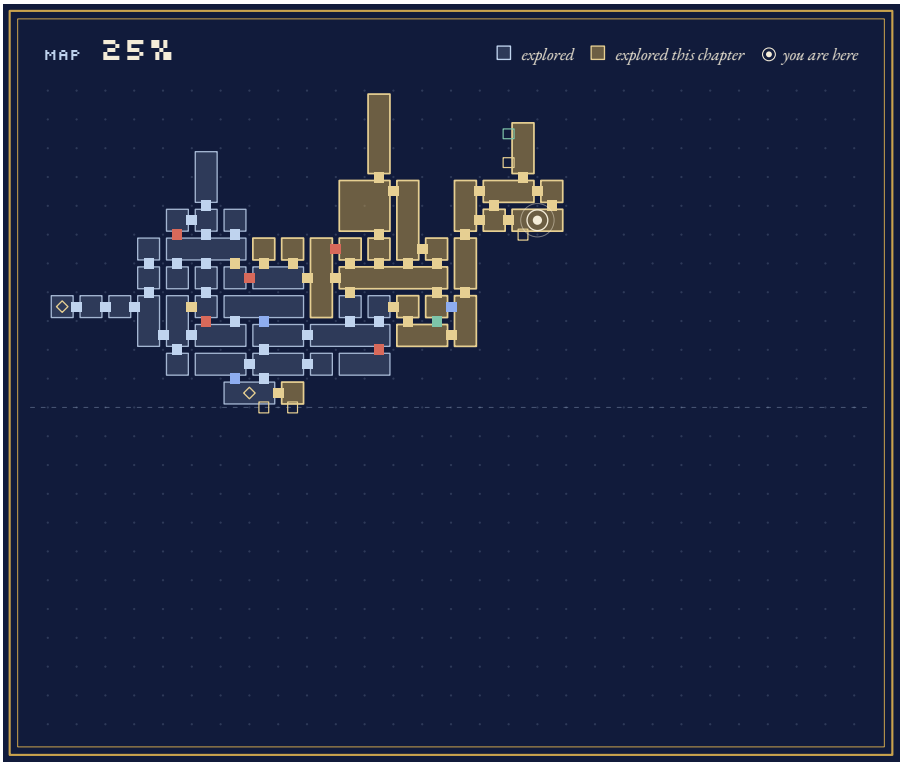


FIGURE 3.1 The fox and the emotion leave the world as it was and alter only the one who wanted; the palintropic detour leaves the desire intact and alters the world.

STASIMON

III



The visible unreachable has been examined from five sides. Anatomically, it is composed of visibility, calibrated distance, a legible obstacle whose semiotics runs the whole of Peirce's typology, a mnemonic inscription, and a contract of deferral that transposes Chekhov's rifle into space; its tense is the future anterior, its narrative figure Genette's prolepsis, its speech act the promise, and its affect the inverse of Agamben's melancholy — an unobtainable object made to appear not as lost but as promised. Phenomenologically, it is Husserl's empty intention given a peculiar form: visually fulfilled and kinaesthetically empty, an "I cannot yet," whose prolonged suspension constitutes an epochē *of fulfilment, a reduction carried out by architecture. Ontologically, it is Bloch's Not-Yet: the subject that is not yet its predicate, the world not yet become for the one who explores it, the* Vor-Schein *of a better place, the school of* docta spes*, and the* Heimat *that shines into childhood and in which no one has yet been. Erotically, it is Sappho's apple, not forgotten but unreached, and Diotima's Eros, sleeping at doors and on roads, dying and reviving through the resourcefulness of his father, a hunter forever weaving contrivances; its genealogy runs from Mētis to*

Poros, and from Poros and Penia to desire, and its ladder of love is a spiral staircase. Epistemologically, it dissolves Meno's paradox by splitting the what of inquiry from its how, and it enacts a recollection that runs in both directions, from ledge to capacity and from capacity to ledge, until Bunyan's prisoner discovers the key called Promise in his own bosom. Ethically, it constitutes an anti-Aesopian machine, which refuses both the fox's revaluation and Sartre's magic, trains the capacity for Köhler's detour, and makes magic true — at the price of a just-world optimism that the conclusion of this study will have to weigh.

The ledge has been regarded from below, as an object. The next chapter turns to what stands between the subject and it: the wall, the gate, the locked door, the darkness that cannot be crossed. It turns, that is, from the promise to the impasse, from prolepsis to aporia, and in doing so it descends from the open air of the lyric into the corridors of the Gothic castle, where doors are everywhere and every one of them is locked.

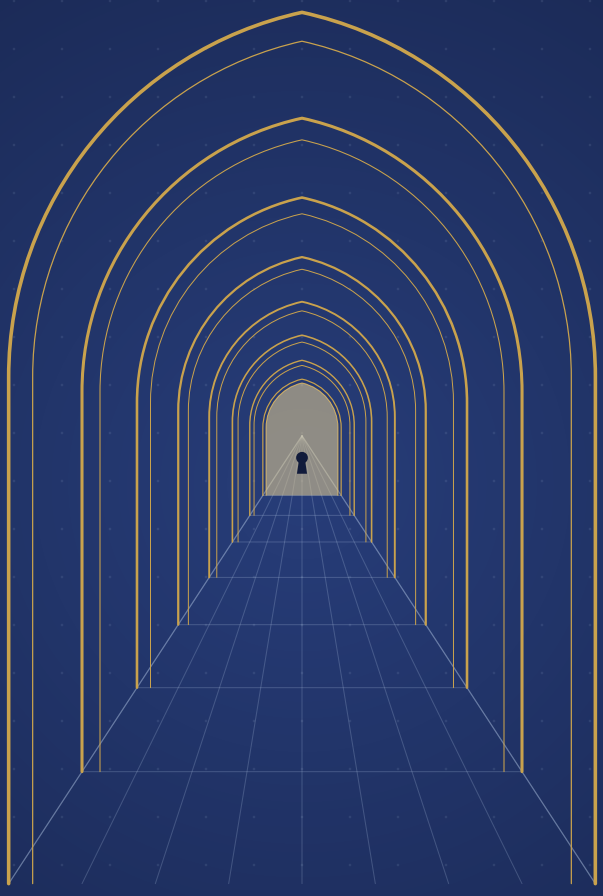
CHAPTER FOUR

δ΄

Aporia

ἀπορία

Doors, Doors, Doors Everywhere



... doors, doors, doors everywhere, and all locked and bolted. In no place save from the windows in the castle walls is there an available exit. The castle is a veritable prison, and I am a prisoner!

— Jonathan Harker's journal, in Bram Stoker, *Dracula* (1897), chapter 2

Hier konnte niemand sonst Einlaß erhalten, denn dieser Eingang war nur für dich bestimmt. Ich gehe jetzt und schließe ihn.

No one else could be admitted here, for this entrance was meant only for you. I am going now to shut it.

— Franz Kafka, "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915)

4.1 *The Gothic Castle as Chronotope*

The primal scene of the metroidvania was written in 1897. Jonathan Harker, a young English solicitor sent to Transylvania to conclude a property transaction, explores the castle of his client and discovers that its doors are locked and bolted on every side; the castle, he records in his journal, is a veritable prison, and he is a prisoner. What follows in the opening chapters of Bram Stoker's *Dracula* is an exploration narrated as a log. Harker finds the Count in his library studying an English railway guide and a map of England marked with circles, so that the monster is revealed as a cartographer planning an invasion. He discovers an unlocked wing, once the apartments of the castle's ladies, where three vampire women come upon him in the moonlight. He descends to a ruined chapel and its vaults, where the Count lies in a great box of earth. And he watches from a window as the Count emerges from another window and crawls down the castle wall face downward over the abyss, as a lizard moves along a wall. In the end Harker escapes by the same means: he resolves to scale the wall farther than he has yet attempted, and leaves the castle by the monster's own mode of locomotion. A locked world, an exploration recorded in writing, a forbidden wing, a descent to the crypt, and an escape by acquiring the capacity of the monster — the structure is the metroidvania's, and its final term is the subject of Chapter Five.

Mikhail Bakhtin's essay "Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel," written in 1937–38 and published in 1975, supplies the concept through which the Gothic castle's significance for the genre can be grasped. The chronotope, literally "time-space," names the intrinsic connectedness of temporal and spatial relations as they are artistically expressed in literature: in the chronotope, time thickens and becomes visible, while space becomes charged with the movements of time and history. Among Bakhtin's examples is the castle of the English Gothic novel, which he described as saturated through and through with time — specifically the time of the historical past, legible in its architecture, its furnishings, its weapons, its gallery of ancestral portraits and its family archives, in the human relationships of dynastic primacy and hereditary right that it houses, and in the legends that animate its every corner. The metroidvania's castles and ruins are chronotopes in exactly Bakhtin's sense. The ruins of Hallownest narrate the fall of a kingdom; the temples of the Chozo narrate the passing of a civilization; Dracula's castle, which in the lore of its series rises anew with each return of its master, narrates centuries of recurrence. Henry Jenkins's embedded narrative is the Bakhtinian castle rendered interactive: time sedimented in space, recovered by the one who walks there.

Bakhtin identified other chronotopes that bear on the genre. The chronotope of the threshold, most fully developed in Dostoevsky — the staircase, the front hall, the corridor, the landing — is the chronotope of crisis and of the break in a life, of decisions taken and turning points crossed, in which time falls out of the steady flow of biography. The chronotope of the road is the chronotope of encounter. And the earliest chronotope Bakhtin analysed, the "adventure time" of the Greek romance, is a time that leaves no trace: the lovers of Heliodorus and Achilles Tatius pass through shipwrecks, captivities, and trials and marry at the end as young and unchanged as they began. The metroidvania composes the first three into a single chronotope — the sedimented past of the castle, the crisis of the threshold at every gate, and the encounters of the road with the genre's fellow wanderers, from Maria and the Librarian of *Symphony of the Night* to Quirrel, Cornifer, and the indefatigable Zote of *Hollow Knight* — and it repudiates the fourth. Its time is not adventure time but accretive time. Every adventure leaves a trace upon the hero's body in the form of a capacity, and the hero who leaves the labyrinth is not the hero who entered it.

The Gothic castle was born, as a literary chronotope, with Horace Walpole's *The Castle of Otranto* (1764), and its founding text already contains a remarkable portion of the genre's grammar. Its castle is honeycombed with subterranean passages, through one of which the heroine Isabella flees by a trap door toward the sanctuary of a neighbouring church. A gigantic helmet falls from the sky into its courtyard; a portrait sighs and steps from its frame; and the armoured body of the castle's murdered rightful lord, Alfonso, appears in fragments of colossal size — a foot and a leg in a gallery, a sword borne by a hundred men, a hand upon a banister — until, at the novel's climax, the walls are thrown down and the form of Alfonso, dilated to an immense magnitude, rises among the ruins. The castle assembles a body from scattered parts and collapses when the body is complete. Both movements recur in the genre: the gathering of a scattered body as a structure of progress, which *Castlevania II* made literal in its quest for the relics of Dracula, and the collapse of the completed structure, which is the genre's exodos.

Ann Radcliffe's *The Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794) imprisoned its heroine, Emily St. Aubert, in a castle in the Apennines whose corridors, turrets, and locked apartments she explores in a state of heightened apprehension, and placed in one of its chambers a black veil, behind which Emily glimpses something so dreadful that she faints. Only at the novel's end is the object behind the veil revealed as a waxen *memento mori*, an effigy of a decaying corpse: Radcliffe's "explained supernatural," in which the veil is lifted and the terror receives a rational account. In a posthumously published essay, "On the Supernatural in

Poetry" (1826), Radcliffe distinguished terror, which expands the soul and awakens its faculties through obscurity, from horror, which contracts, freezes, and nearly annihilates them; her veiled chamber is a machine of terror in this sense, and Chapter Seven returns to its veil. Matthew Lewis's *The Monk* (1796), by contrast, descended into the sepulchres beneath a convent and buried its victims alive.

Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *The Coherence of Gothic Conventions* (1980) argued that the Gothic's apparently miscellaneous conventions — live burial, the unspeakable, doubles, secret passages, interrupted manuscripts — share a single spatial topology: a self massively blocked off from something to which it ought normally to have access, whether its past, its family, its true nature, or the world outside, together with the sudden and violent permeability of the barrier that blocks it. The metroidvania's gates are Sedgwick's barriers, and the moment at which a capacity renders them permeable is the Gothic's breach rendered as reward. Anne Williams's *Art of Darkness: A Poetics of Gothic* (1995) read the Gothic castle as the house of the patriarchal family, the Law of the Father given architectural form, through whose corridors the heroine of the "female Gothic" searches for the secret the house conceals — frequently the fate of a buried mother. *Symphony of the Night* is the father's house explored by the son, and its final confrontation turns, as Chapter Nine will show, on the memory of the mother whose death set the father's war in motion.

Mervyn Peake's *Titus Groan* (1946) and *Gormenghast* (1950) carried the Gothic castle to the scale of a world. Gormenghast is so vast that whole regions of it lie forgotten; its life is governed by a ritual so ancient and exhaustive that each day repeats the last, in an iteration as merciless as Asterion's. The kitchen boy Steerpike escapes from its bowels by climbing across its roofs and mastering the topology of its exterior, and so insinuates himself into its hierarchy; the young Earl Titus, at the end of the second novel, rides out of the castle altogether. Peake's castle is the Gothic chronotope as total environment, and its two escapes — the upward climb that converts topographical mastery into power, and the final departure that breaks the iteration of ritual — are the metroidvania's two great movements, ascent and exodus, in their novelistic form.

4.2 *Piranesi's Prisons and the Impossible Interior*

If the Gothic novel supplied the castle as chronotope, the visual archetype of its interior was supplied by an architect who built almost nothing. Giovanni Battista Piranesi (1720–1778), Venetian by birth and Roman by vocation, made his reputation with etched views of ancient and modern Rome, but his most enduring work is the series of *Carceri d'invenzione*, the "imaginary prisons," first issued around 1749–50 as fourteen plates and reissued in 1761 in a darkened and densified second state, with two new plates added. The *Carceri* present vast vaulted interiors traversed by staircases that ascend toward nothing, by bridges and galleries crossing at elevations no plan could reconcile, by ropes, chains, pulleys, wheels, and instruments of uncertain and sinister purpose, among which minute figures wander, lost in the immensity. Their perspectives do not cohere: the eye that attempts to reconstruct a ground plan from them fails, because their space is composed of fragments that obey different systems. They are labyrinths of verticality whose logic defeats the view from above.

Thomas De Quincey's *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821) fixed their meaning for the Romantic imagination in a celebrated passage recalling a description of the plates by Coleridge. "Creeping along the sides of the walls," De Quincey writes, "you perceived a staircase; and upon it, groping his way upwards, was Piranesi himself: follow the stairs a little further, and you perceive it come to a sudden abrupt termination, without any balustrade, and allowing no step onwards to him who had reached the extremity, except into the depths below." But raise the eye, and a still more aerial flight of stairs appears, and on it Piranesi again, "busy on his aspiring labours"; and again, higher still, "until the unfinished stairs and Piranesi both are lost in the upper gloom of the hall." De Quincey added that his own opium dreams of architecture proceeded "with the same power of endless growth and self-reproduction."

The passage reads as an uncanny description of the metroidvania's vertical aporia and of the avatar's relation to it. The staircase that ends abruptly at an abyss is the ledge beyond the leap; the figure who reappears, higher, on another flight is the avatar returning with a capacity it lacked; and "aspiring labours" is as good a name as any for the genre's repeated attempts upon a height. De Quincey's architecture of endless growth and self-reproduction anticipates, moreover, the runaway megastructures of Nihei's *BLAME!* and the self-altering house of Danielewski's novel, which Chapter Two examined as the infinite interior's horror. Later readers of the *Carceri* have drawn out what De Quincey's reverie implies. Marguerite Yourcenar's essay "The Dark Brain of Piranesi" (1962) read the prisons as dreams of space whose true subject is the mind's

own captivity. Sergei Eisenstein, in an essay on Piranesi written in 1946–47, analysed a plate of the *Carceri* as an explosion of space, its forms streaming beyond their limits in a "fluidity" he compared to cinematic montage and to ecstasy. And Manfredo Tafuri, in *The Sphere and the Labyrinth* (1980), made Piranesi "the wicked architect" with whom modern architecture's crisis begins: the loss of the centre, the dissolution of the organic whole into colliding fragments, the labyrinth as the condition of the modern metropolis.

The metroidvania restores the centre that, on Tafuri's account, Piranesi lost. Its labyrinth is always mappable, its fragments always composable into a plan. But it preserves the *Carceri* as local experience: the vertical shaft whose summit is lost in gloom, the gallery from which no exit is visible, the chain-hung chapel in which minute figures ascend toward a light they cannot reach. It is no accident that the genre's Gothic exemplars, from the clock towers and cathedral naves of *Castlevania* to the reliquaries and cathedral rooftops of *Blasphemous*, compose their verticals in a Piranesian idiom, nor that the genre's insect necropolis, *Hollow Knight*, sets beneath an endless rain a City of Tears whose spires and galleries recede into darkness above and below.

M. C. Escher carried the impossible interior from the sublime to the paradoxical. *House of Stairs* (1951) multiplied staircases in an interior without floor or ceiling; *Relativity* (1953) inhabited a single hall with three systems of gravity, so that figures ascend stairs on which others, at right angles, descend, each population oblivious to the others' up and down; *Belvedere* (1958) built an impossible tower; and *Ascending and Descending* (1960), based on the impossible staircase published by Lionel and Roger Penrose in 1958, set a procession of monks forever climbing and a second forever descending the same closed loop of stairs. In Escher's loop the Heraclitean identity of the way up and the way down becomes an illusion of endlessness, an ascent that never arrives because it is also a descent. Jim Henson's *Labyrinth* staged its climax in a set modelled on *Relativity*, and *Symphony of the Night* realized the conceit at the scale of an entire world: its inverted castle reproduces the first room for room with up and down exchanged, a lived *Relativity* to which Chapter Six returns as a peripeteia of space.

Games after Escher have pressed the impossible interior further. Polytron's *Fez* (2012) presented a two-dimensional world that the player rotates through four views of a three-dimensional one, so that passages impossible in one projection become possible in another; its invented alphabet and numerical ciphers, decoded collectively by its players, made it an early knowledge-gated work of the kind Chapter Six examines. Alexander Bruce's *Antichamber* (2013) built non-Euclidean corridors that alter when the player turns back, so that return yields not recognition but transformation — the anti-palintrope of Danielewski's

house made playable — and yet even *Antichamber* provides a wall-map of visited rooms from which the player may return instantly to any of them, conceding to the palintropic sensibility its need for a fixed point.

The impossible interior is the metroidvania's limit case. A genre whose consolations depend on the stability of the world and on its mappability cannot be wholly Piranesian or Escherian. It deploys impossibility locally, as shock within global consistency: the shaft that vanishes into gloom, the castle that turns upside down, the glitch that tears the fabric of the world in *Axiom Verge*. The *Carceri* stand to the metroidvania as the sublime stands to the beautiful in Burke's aesthetics, necessary moments of excess within an order that contains them. Aporia here is not a locked door but a failure of space itself to cohere, an architectural aporia; and the player's characteristic response to it is the genre's characteristic response to every aporia, which is to map it anyway.

4.3 *Bluebeard's Key and the Forbidden Chamber*

Charles Perrault's "La Barbe bleue," published among the *Histoires ou contes du temps passé* (1697), is the European tradition's canonical tale of the locked door. A wealthy man with a blue beard, whose previous wives have vanished, marries a young woman and, departing on a journey, gives her the keys to every room and coffer in his house, together with a small key to a little room at the end of the long gallery on the ground floor, which she is forbidden on pain of his wrath to enter. Curiosity overcomes her. She opens the room and finds its floor clotted with blood and the bodies of the former wives hanging on its walls; in her terror she drops the key into the blood. The key is enchanted, *fée*, and the stain cannot be removed: scoured from one side, it reappears on the other. Bluebeard returns, reads the key as testimony, and condemns her. From the top of the tower her sister Anne scans the horizon for the brothers who are coming to save them — "Anne, ma sœur Anne, ne vois-tu rien venir?" — and they arrive in time to kill him. Perrault appended two morals: one on the high cost of curiosity, and a second, ironic one assuring his readers that husbands are no longer so terrible.

The tale belongs to a widespread folk type, and its variants sharpen its relevance to the genre. In the Grimms' "Fitcher's Bird" (1812), a sorcerer entrusts each of three sisters in turn with an egg and a key; the forbidden room is a basin of blood and dismembered bodies, and the egg, dropped into the basin, is indelibly stained and betrays the first two sisters. The third sets the egg aside before entering, finds her sisters' bodies in pieces, gathers and reassembles their limbs until they revive, and finally escapes the sorcerer's house disguised as a marvellous bird, having rolled herself in honey and then in feathers. The tale compresses into a few pages two of the genre's deep structures — the reassembly of a scattered body, which runs from Osiris through *Otranto* to *Simon's Quest*, and passage by metamorphosis, which Chapter Five makes the genre's law. The English "Mr. Fox," as Joseph Jacobs printed it in *English Fairy Tales* (1890), inscribes the logic of the forbidden chamber over its doors. Lady Mary, exploring her suitor's house, reads over its portal and its doorways "Be bold, be bold, but not too bold, / Lest that your heart's blood should run cold"; Edmund Spenser had set the same inscriptions over the doors of the House of Busirane in *The Faerie Queene* (III.xi.54), where Britomart reads "Be bold" above every door and, above an iron door at the room's end, "Be not too bold." The threshold speaks, and what it speaks is a calibration of curiosity.

Across the myths of the West the forbidden chamber has one moral, and it is punitive. Pandora opens the jar; Eve eats the fruit; Psyche, forbidden to look upon her husband, lights a lamp in the night, and a drop of hot oil wakes Cupid,

who flees; and when, at the end of her penitential trials, she descends to the underworld to fetch a box of Proserpina's beauty, she opens it against command and falls into a deathlike sleep. Orpheus looks back. Curiosity is punished, and the punishment marks the curious: the key that bleeds is knowledge that stains the knower, an indelible evidence of having seen.

The metroidvania inverts this moral without abolishing its forms. In the genre there are no forbidden chambers, only chambers not yet permitted. It secularizes the forbidden into the deferred: the prohibition becomes a timetable, and the key, rather than staining the hand that holds it, empowers it. Curiosity is not punished but rewarded; the false wall, the unpromising corridor, the room behind the room repay the player who strikes, probes, and returns, and the genre's devotees measure one another precisely by their curiosity, recorded in the percentages of their maps. Over every door of the metroidvania the inscription reads not "Be not too bold" but "Not yet bold enough." The Gothic dread at the threshold persists, but it is transferred from transgression to difficulty. The genre's most formidable optional regions — the inverted castle that most players of *Symphony of the Night* never found, the punishing gauntlets of *Hollow Knight*'s White Palace and the trials appended to it — are forbidden chambers of a new kind, guarded not by a husband's wrath but by the demand for mastery, and they warn the curious, as Busirane's iron door warned Britomart, of the cost of entering unprepared.

The modern revisions of the Bluebeard story move in the genre's direction. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979), told by the bride herself, makes the stain of the key a mark upon her own forehead that no cosmetic will conceal, and sends to her rescue not her brothers but her mother, galloping to the castle with a revolver: the mark becomes the sign of an experience to be owned rather than a shame to be hidden, and the knowledge it records becomes the condition of survival. Feminist criticism had meanwhile read the Gothic's forbidden spaces as the places where the house conceals a woman. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) took its title from the woman confined on the third storey of Thornfield Hall in *Jane Eyre* (1847), the furious double whom the house's master keeps locked away and whose existence the house is built to deny. Chapter Nine will argue that the metroidvania's architecture conceals a woman in exactly this sense, and that its deepest chambers are frequently maternal.

By accident or by the logic of the form, Koji Igarashi's crowdfunded return to the genre bears a title, *Bloodstained: Ritual of the Night* (2019), that recalls Bluebeard's indelible key. Its heroine, Miriam, is an orphan whose body has been engraved by alchemists with crystals that permit her to absorb the shards of the

demons she defeats and to wield their powers, at the risk of being crystallized altogether. The stain becomes power; the mark becomes capacity; and the price of the transformation is the slow alienation of the body that bears it. In a single figure the genre transvalues Bluebeard's key, converting the indelible evidence of forbidden knowledge into the engine of progress, and preserving, in the threat of crystallization, the memory of what such knowledge once cost.

4.4 *Before the Law*

Kafka and the Door Meant Only for You

Franz Kafka's parable "Before the Law" ("Vor dem Gesetz"), written in 1914 and published the following year, is the twentieth century's most concentrated meditation on the closed door, and it is, among other things, a story about a gate that will not open for a player who will not leave. Before the Law stands a doorkeeper. A man from the country comes and asks to be admitted. The doorkeeper says that he cannot admit him now. The man asks whether he may be admitted later. "It is possible," says the doorkeeper, "but not now." The gate stands open, as always, and the man stoops to peer inside; the doorkeeper laughs and tells him to try, if he is so tempted, despite the prohibition — but warns that he himself is powerful, and only the lowest of the doorkeepers, and that from hall to hall stand doorkeepers each more powerful than the last, the third of whom even he cannot bear to look upon. The man decides to wait. He sits on a stool beside the door for days and years. He bribes the doorkeeper with everything he has, and the doorkeeper accepts each gift, remarking that he does so only so that the man will not think he has neglected anything. He studies the doorkeeper until he knows even the fleas in his fur collar, and begs the fleas to help him. He grows old; his eyes dim; and in the darkness he perceives a radiance that streams inextinguishably from the door of the Law. Dying, he asks why, in all these years, no one but himself has come seeking admittance. The doorkeeper roars into his failing ear the words that serve as this chapter's epigraph: no one else could be admitted here, for this entrance was meant only for you; I am going now to shut it.

Kafka embedded the parable in *The Trial*, published posthumously in 1925, where a prison chaplain recounts it to Josef K. in a darkened cathedral, and the two dispute its meaning — whether the doorkeeper deceived the man, whether the man was in truth free and the doorkeeper bound, whether the doorkeeper was even subordinate to the man — until the chaplain observes that the text is unalterable and the opinions are often only an expression of despair over it.

The parable is a labyrinth of exegesis, and its commentaries are themselves doorkeepers. Jacques Derrida's "Before the Law" (delivered in 1982 and published in 1985) observed that what bars the man is no physical barrier, since the door stands open, but a deferral: "not now" (*jetzt aber nicht*). The law's inaccessibility is the condition of its being law; it withholds itself, and its withholding is its authority. Derrida stressed also the singularity of the entrance — meant for this man alone — and read the parable as an allegory of literature, every text standing before the law of its own singular reading. Giorgio Agamben, in *Homo Sacer* (1995), read the open door as the paradigm of the sovereign ban, a law "in force without significance" that applies to the man precisely by excluding him; and, against the tradition of tragic readings, he proposed that the man's interminable patience accomplished something after all, since it compelled the doorkeeper to close the door and so brought the law's empty force to an end.

The metroidvania is a counter-parable to "Before the Law," and its inversions are three. The first concerns the singularity of the door. In Kafka, the revelation that the entrance was meant only for the man is the parable's final, tragic irony: the one door made for him was the one he never passed. In the metroidvania it is the ontological condition of the single-player world. Every door in such a world is meant only for you; the world is a set of thresholds cut to the measure of a single body's capacities, and no one else will ever stand before them. But you will pass them all. The second inversion concerns the "not now." The metroidvania's gate also says *jetzt aber nicht*. The fatal error of Kafka's man is to wait before the door, to make his life a vigil at the threshold, bribing and pleading and studying the fleas. The genre's player does not wait. She goes away — Köhler's detour, the *Umweg* — and returns with what the door requires. The metroidvania teaches the lesson the man from the country never learned: one does not enter the law by waiting before it; one enters by leaving it and coming back. The third inversion concerns the radiance. Kafka's man perceives the light streaming from the door only at the end, when his eyes are failing and nothing remains to him but death; it is the *Vor-Schein* granted too late, a glory that mocks. The metroidvania grants its radiance at the beginning, as prolepsis, so that the light behind the door guides rather than taunts.

Kafka's hierarchy of doorkeepers has its counterpart in the genre's bosses, who are guardians of thresholds arranged in escalating power. In *Hollow Knight* the wanderer Hornet bars the way through the overgrown passages of Greenpath, and the Mothwing Cloak, whose dash opens the next order of passages, lies beyond her; in *Super Metroid* the four great guardians of Zebes — Kraid, Phantoon, Draygon, and Ridley — are commemorated by four statues that seal the way to Tourian until all four have fallen. And the sequence culminates, as

Kafka's does, in a final guardian whose aspect is unbearable. The resonance in *Hollow Knight* is striking enough to record, though it is analogical rather than genealogical: the last antagonist of its hidden ending is the Radiance, a forgotten god of blinding light sealed within the dreams of the kingdom, so that behind the last door of the game, as before the door of Kafka's Law, there is a radiance. The genre and the parable agree on this much: the final thing behind the final door is light.

Kafka's unfinished novel *The Castle* (1926) extends the parable into a whole world. Its protagonist, K., is a land surveyor — a *Landvermesser*, a maker of measurements and maps — summoned to a village beneath a castle that he can never reach. On his first morning he sets out along the village street toward the castle hill, only to find that the street approaches it and then, as if deliberately, turns aside; the castle's officials, its bureaucratic chambers, and its messages constitute a labyrinth whose centre recedes as it is approached. K. is a surveyor who can never survey, the failed cartographer of modern literature. The metroidvania's player is K. redeemed: the surveyor whose survey is completed, whose map is filled, whose road at last arrives. The short prose piece "An Imperial Message" (1919) imagines the reverse predicament: a messenger dispatched by a dying emperor who cannot get out of the innermost palace, fighting his way through chambers, staircases, courtyards, and further palaces for millennia, while the one to whom the message is addressed sits at his window at evening and dreams it to himself. The infinite interior that forbids exit is redeemed in the genre's *exodos*, in which the messenger, at last, gets out.

Kafka is the great poet of aporia as condition; the metroidvania is the great machine of aporia as stage. It takes Kafka's doors and gives them keys. In doing so it neither refutes Kafka nor trivializes him. It imagines a world in which the door of the law, meant only for you, is also a door you will pass through, and it is fair to ask, as Chapter Three asked of the just world, whether such an imagination is a utopia or an ideology. The genre's answer, insofar as a form can answer, is that the imagination is a discipline: it trains its subject to treat the closed door not as fate but as a question, and to answer the question not by waiting but by going elsewhere to learn.

4.5 *Holzwege*

The Dead End as Clearing

In 1950 Martin Heidegger gathered six essays, among them "The Origin of the Work of Art," under a title that he glossed in a brief prefatory note. *Holz*, he observed, is an old name for forest. In the forest there are paths, mostly overgrown, that come to an abrupt stop in the untrodden. They are called *Holzwege*. Each goes its own way, but in the same forest; it often seems as though one were like another, but it only seems so. Woodcutters and foresters know these paths; they know what it means to be on a *Holzweg*. The German idiom *auf dem Holzweg sein* means to be on the wrong track, and Heidegger's title plays upon the double sense of the word: the path that appears to lead nowhere, and the working path that leads to the place where timber has been felled — a clearing.

The clearing, *die Lichtung*, became one of the central figures of Heidegger's later thought. In "The Origin of the Work of Art" (1935–36) he wrote that in the midst of beings as a whole an open place occurs, a clearing in which beings can first show themselves; in "The End of Philosophy and the Task of Thinking" (1964) he traced the word to the verb *lichten*, to make light and open, as one opens a forest to the sky. His thought was, throughout, a philosophy of paths. *The Field Path* (1949), *On the Way to Language* (1959), and *Pathmarks* (1967) carry the figure in their titles, and the motto he chose for the collected edition of his writings, shortly before his death, was "Ways, not works" (*Wege — nicht Werke*). Method, *meta-hodos*, is in this tradition the way that follows after; and the *Holzweg* is the path whose apparent failure conceals its purpose.

The metroidvania's apparent dead ends are *Holzwege*. They seem to stop in the untrodden, and the experienced player — the woodcutter of the genre's forest — knows what it means to be on one. The dead end may conceal a passage: a false wall, a breakable floor, a ceiling that yields to the right blow, so that the end of the path is a veil over its continuation. It may defer a passage: an aporia awaiting its capacity, so that the dead end is a prolepsis whose key lies elsewhere. Or it may be a clearing in the strict sense, a place where something has been gathered for whoever comes — a cache, an inscription, a vista over regions not yet reached. Design practice has codified the principle that a dead end must reward the one who reaches it; a dead end without reward is felt as a betrayal, a *Holzweg* in the colloquial sense, proof that one has been on the wrong track. The genre's craft consists in making every *Holzweg* a clearing, and its pedagogy in making every player a woodcutter, one who has learned to read the abrupt end of a path as a sign of what it conceals. This knowledge is *mētis* in Detienne and Vernant's

sense: not the knowledge of a map but the knowledge of a forest, acquired by walking it.

The philosophical tradition knows its own *Holzwege*. Several of Plato's early dialogues — the *Laches* on courage, the *Euthyphro* on piety, the *Charmides* on temperance, the *Lysis* on friendship — end without the definition they sought, in an acknowledged aporia. The inquiry stops in the untrodden. But the reader departs from them not empty-handed but provoked, with the question sharpened and the false answers cleared away; the aporetic dialogue is a path whose end is the beginning of the reader's own inquiry, and its clearing is the reader's continued thought. In the *Theaetetus* (155d), Socrates tells the young mathematician that wonder is the very mark of the philosopher, and that philosophy has no other beginning. The labyrinth's amazement, which Chapter Two traced to the bewilderment of the maze, is here placed at the origin of philosophy itself, and the aporia that the dialogue produces is its instrument.

The Chan Buddhist tradition built an entire pedagogy upon the productive impasse. *The Gateless Gate* (*Wumenguan*, 1228), compiled by the master Wumen Huikai, gathers forty-eight *kōans*, and its prefatory verse may be rendered: the great Way has no gate; a thousand roads lead to it; pass through this barrier, and you walk alone between heaven and earth. The word translated "barrier," *guan* (Japanese *kan*), names a frontier pass or checkpoint, and each *kōan* is such a barrier: an impasse set before the student's mind that cannot be passed by argument but only by a transformation of the one who confronts it. The first case, in which the master Zhaozhou answers the question whether a dog has Buddha-nature with the single syllable *wu* (Japanese *mu*), was called the barrier of the school. And the gate, once passed, proves to have been no gate at all. The metroidvania's gates are *kōans* in this structural sense. They are impassable to the subject as it is and passable to the subject as it becomes, and once passed they cease to be gates: on return, the barrier against which the player once struggled is a mere corridor, crossed without a thought. The genre's world is, in the end, a gateless gate.

The Japanese Ways (*michi*, 道) of the traditional arts — the way of tea, of flowers, of the brush, of the sword — cultivate mastery through the repeated performance of fixed forms (*kata*), returned to again and again with deepening understanding. Their pedagogy is often summarized in three stages, *shu-ha-ri*: to keep the form, to break the form, to leave the form behind. The scheme describes with uncanny aptness the trajectory of the genre's most devoted players. They first learn the intended route through the world (*shu*); they then break it, discovering the sequence breaks by which the designer's order may be violated (*ha*); and at last they pass beyond the form altogether into the speedrun, in which

the world is traversed by a path its architect never imagined (*ri*). The dead end, the aporetic dialogue, the *kōan*, and the broken *kata* share a single lesson, which is the lesson of this chapter: in a palintropic world the end of a path is never only an end. It is the forest's way of hiding a clearing.

4.6 *Thresholds and Liminality*

The anthropology of the threshold begins with Arnold van Gennep's *The Rites of Passage* (*Les Rites de passage*, 1909), which discerned beneath the ceremonies that accompany birth, initiation, marriage, and death a common tripartite structure: rites of separation, which detach the subject from a prior condition; rites of transition, or margin, during which the subject is suspended between conditions; and rites of incorporation, which install the subject in a new one. Van Gennep called the three phases preliminal, liminal, and postliminal, after the Latin *limen*, threshold, and he derived the whole schema from what he called the territorial passage: the crossing of frontiers, neutral zones, portals, and doors. For van Gennep the door of an ordinary dwelling is the boundary between the foreign world and the domestic; the threshold is a sacred zone; and to cross it is to unite oneself with a new world. The passage through physical space is the model for every passage between social states.

Victor Turner, in "Betwixt and Between" (collected in *The Forest of Symbols*, 1967) and *The Ritual Process* (1969), concentrated upon the middle phase. The liminal persona, he argued, is neither here nor there, betwixt and between the positions assigned by law, custom, and convention. Neophytes in the liminal phase are characteristically stripped of status, property, and insignia; they are humble, passive, and ambiguous; and liminality is likened, in the symbolic vocabularies Turner surveyed, to death, to being in the womb, to invisibility, to darkness, to bisexuality, to the wilderness, and to an eclipse of the sun or moon. Among those who share the liminal condition there arises what Turner called *communitas*, an egalitarian bond that suspends the hierarchies of ordinary life; and the liminal phase as a whole is a realm of pure possibility, in which new configurations of ideas and relations may arise.

The metroidvania is organized by van Gennep's schema at two scales. At the scale of the single threshold, every gate traversed is a miniature rite of passage. There is a separation, as the player leaves the explored for the unexplored. There is a margin, materialized in the genre's characteristic transitional spaces: the hatch whose opening suspends the action for a beat, the darkened instant of a screen transition, the long elevator descents of *Super Metroid* through which

the music of one region fades before the next begins, the tram, the corridor of nothing. And there is an incorporation, as the player arrives in a new region with its own palette, music, and ecology — in *Hollow Knight*, with its name inscribed across the screen in a small ceremony of naming. At the scale of the whole work, the game itself is a rite of passage. Its opening separates the hero from a prior condition and characteristically strips it of insignia, as the neophyte is stripped; its long middle holds the hero in a liminality in which it is neither weak nor strong, neither native to the world nor alien to it; and its ending incorporates a transformed hero into a new condition. Turner's catalogue of liminal symbols reads, moreover, like an inventory of the genre's imagination. Its heroes die and revive continually; its deepest places are, as Chapter Nine argues, wombs; they become invisible, as Samus does beneath the Phantom Cloak of *Metroid Dread* and Alucard in his form of mist; they descend into darkness, as the Knight descends into the Abyss beneath Hallownest; they are androgynous, as Kojima's Alucard is and as Samus, armoured and unsexed until the end of her first adventure, was; they wander in wildernesses of overgrowth; and the hero of *Aria of Sorrow* is drawn into Dracula's castle during an eclipse of the sun. The wanderers the genre's heroes meet on the road — fellow explorers, cartographers, scholars, and fools, met at thresholds and then again elsewhere — constitute a *communitas* of the lost.

The Roman tradition gave the threshold a god. Janus, whose name is cognate with *ianua*, door, presided over doors, gates, passages, and beginnings, and was represented with two faces, one looking back and one looking forward; his month, January, turns the year; the doors of his temple in the Forum stood open in war and closed in peace. Janus is the palintropic god *par excellence*, and the metroidvania's thresholds are Janus-faced in exactly his manner, facing at once the No-Longer of the explored and the Not-Yet of the unexplored. The Christian tradition gave the threshold a calendar. The Holy Door of St Peter's Basilica is walled up between jubilees and opened only in Holy Years, as it was on Christmas Eve 2024 for the Jubilee of 2025: a door deferred by a timetable, whose "not now" is not a refusal but a date, and which offers the closest analogue in sacred architecture to the metroidvania's timetable of passage. The Game Kitchen's *Blasphemous*, saturated with the iconography of Iberian Catholicism, makes its places of rest kneelers, *prie-dieux* at which the Penitent One prays to restore himself, so that the genre's stasimon is performed as devotion and the threshold of rest becomes a threshold of prayer.

The genre's thresholds can be classified by the kind of aporia they present, the mode in which they signify their key (in Peirce's terms, as Section 3.1 proposed),

and the capacity that dissolves them. Table 4.1 summarizes this grammar of gates, with representative instances.

TABLE 4.1 *A grammar of gates.*

APORIA	CAPACITY THAT DISSOLVES IT	REPRESENTATIVE INSTANCES
 Height: the ledge, the shaft *sign: index*	Vertical capacity: high jump, double jump, wall-cling, flight	*Super Metroid*'s Hi-Jump Boots and Space Jump; *Symphony of the Night*'s Leap Stone and bat form; *Hollow Knight*'s Mantis Claw and Monarch Wings
 Gap: the chasm, the void *sign: index*	Horizontal capacity: dash, grapple	*Hollow Knight*'s Mothwing Cloak; *Super Metroid*'s Grapple Beam
 Narrowness: the crawlway, the grate *sign: icon*	Miniaturization: the rolled or dissolved body	*Metroid*'s Morph Ball; *Symphony of the Night*'s mist form
 Hostile medium: heat, deep water, acid *sign: index*	Protection: suits and charms	*Super Metroid*'s Varia and Gravity Suits; *Hollow Knight*'s Isma's Tear
 Darkness *sign: index*	Light and sight	*Zork*'s lamp; *Hollow Knight*'s Lumafly Lantern; *Metroid Prime*'s Thermal Visor
 Material barrier: rock, hatch, shell *sign: icon or symbol*	Force: bombs, missiles, power bombs	*Metroid*'s colour-coded hatches; *Super Metroid*'s bomb blocks
 Illusion: the false wall, the hidden controller *sign: none: concealment*	Insight: true sight	*Super Metroid*'s X-Ray Scope; *Symphony of the Night*'s Holy Glasses
 Convention: the sealed gate *sign: symbol*	Keys, relics, deeds	*Adventure*'s coloured castle keys; *Super Metroid*'s four statues before Tourian
 Knowledge: the word, the code, the pattern *sign: symbol*	Understanding	*Colossal Cave*'s XYZZY; *La-Mulana*'s tablets; *Outer Wilds*; *Tunic*

The grammar runs from the body to the mind. Its first six rows concern capacities of the body — to rise, to cross, to shrink, to endure, to see in the dark, to break — and correspond to what Chapter Five analyses as the phenomenology of the "I can." Its last three concern capacities of perception and understanding: to see through illusion, to know the convention, to grasp the word. At this frontier the genre turns from metamorphosis toward recognition and disclosure,

and the knowledge-gated works that Chapter Six examines under the heading of Perceval's second visit are those in which the whole grammar has been transposed into its final rows.

4.7 *The Castlevania Lineage*

From Akamatsu to Igarashi

Akumajō Dracula — "Demon Castle Dracula" — appeared on the Famicom Disk System in 1986 and, as *Castlevania*, in North America the following year. Directed by Hitoshi Akamatsu, it sent Simon Belmont through the gates of Dracula's castle armed with a whip, the Vampire Killer, and with secondary weapons — dagger, axe, holy water, cross, stopwatch — powered by hearts released from the candles he struck along the way, so that the castle itself was a reliquary of the resources needed to destroy its master. Its six stages carried Simon from the entrance hall to the clock tower and Dracula's keep, and its ending showed the castle crumbling as he watched. Its bestiary was a museum of Western horror — bats and Medusa heads, the Mummy, Frankenstein's creature attended by a hunchbacked servant, Death with his scythe, Dracula himself — and its closing credits parodied the casts of the Universal and Hammer films from which these figures came. The first *Castlevania* was a Japanese curation of the European Gothic, a Europe assembled from cinema and reimagined as a stage set, culturally odorless in Iwabuchi's sense precisely because it was so thoroughly an image of images.

The series turned toward exploration almost at once. The MSX2 *Vampire Killer* (1986) organized its castle as a puzzle of keys and chests, with a merchant hidden in its walls. *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest* (1987) opened onto a Transylvanian countryside of towns and mansions, a cycle in which the coming of night — announced by the text "What a horrible night to have a curse" — made the world more dangerous, and a quest to recover the scattered relics of Dracula's body. Its villagers frequently lied, and its English localization compounded their obscurity, so that progress at certain points depended on acts no reasonable inference could discover: at Deborah Cliff, for instance, the player must kneel with a red crystal to summon the whirlwind that carries Simon onward. *Simon's Quest* was the first knowledge-gated action-adventure of the console era, and players depended on the enthusiast magazines to pass its gates; translation itself had become a labyrinth. *Castlevania III: Dracula's Curse* (1989) introduced branching routes through its world and companions with distinct capacities, among them Alucard, son of Dracula, able to take the form of a bat; and *Dracula X: Rondo*

of Blood (1993), for the PC Engine's CD-ROM format, hid alternative routes and exits throughout its stages and introduced Richter Belmont and the young Maria Renard.

Symphony of the Night (1997) begins where *Rondo of Blood* ended, with Richter's final battle against Dracula: its prologue is its predecessor's conclusion, the series turning back upon itself. Four years later, the castle reappears, and Alucard, the dhampir son of Dracula and the human woman Lisa, wakes from a self-imposed sleep to enter it; at its threshold Death strips him of his equipment. The castle he explores is the most intricate the series had built, with a librarian who keeps a shop among his shelves, a Maria in search of the vanished Richter, and, at its summit, Richter himself enthroned as its false lord. Alucard can see the truth of Richter's condition only through the Holy Glasses: worn, they reveal the orb by which the dark priest Shaft controls him. A player who defeats Richter without them reaches an abrupt and premature ending. A player who destroys the orb instead finds the castle inverted — a second castle, the first reproduced upside down — and within it Alucard gathers, from the guardians of its regions, five relics of Dracula's body: rib, heart, eye, tooth, and ring. The inverted castle thus re-performs, in reverse, the relic-hunt of *Simon's Quest*, the series returning to its own earlier quest as the world returns to itself upside down. Its map, completed in both orientations, reaches the celebrated figure of 200.6 per cent.

The protagonist's name condenses the whole design. "Alucard" is "Dracula" spelled backward, a reversal first used for the vampire of Universal's *Son of Dracula* (1943), played by Lon Chaney Jr. In *Symphony of the Night* the reversal names a son who is his father read backward, and the inverted castle is the father's house read backward in turn: the son traverses the paternal world twice, forward and reversed, and the hero is, onomastically, the monster's palindrome. The figure had a Japanese precedent in Hideyuki Kikuchi's *Vampire Hunter D* (1983), whose illustrations by Yoshitaka Amano established the melancholy, aristocratic beauty of a dhampir who hunts his own father's kind, and whose kinship with Ayami Kojima's androgynous Alucard is evident. The script's most famous line, Dracula's paraphrase of Malraux on man as a miserable little pile of secrets, announces the theory of the secret self that Chapter Seven develops. *Symphony of the Night* thus condenses the genre into a single work: the castle as chronotope; the forbidden half concealed behind an obscure secret; the hero as the monster's son; the world palintropically inverted; and the scattered body regathered.

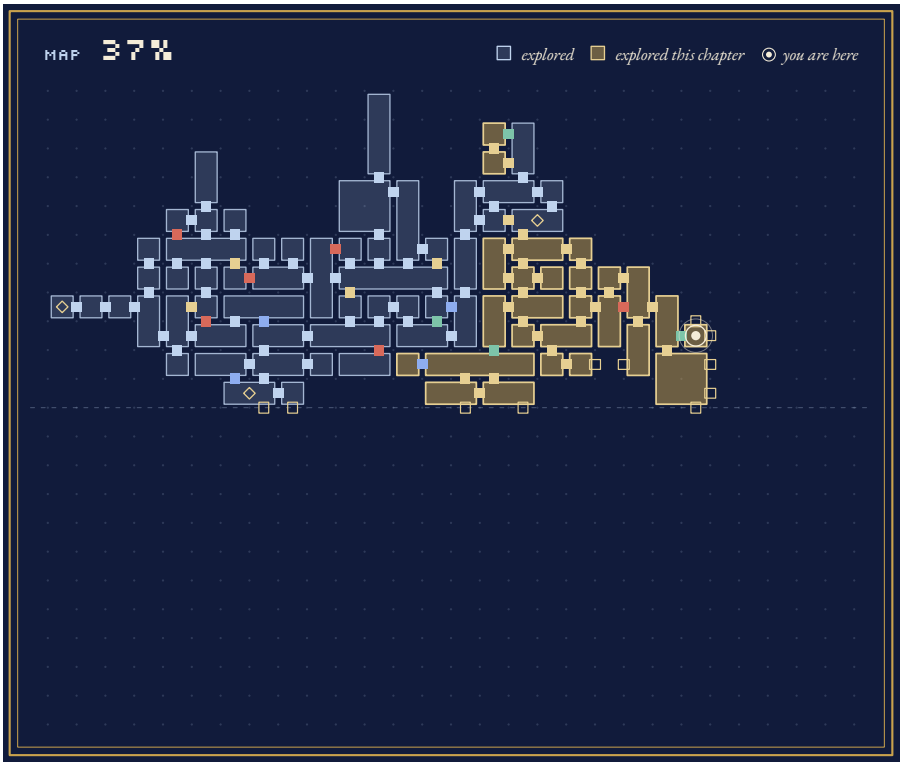
The handheld entries Igarashi produced over the following decade consolidated the template and varied its terms. *Harmony of Dissonance* (2002) superimposed two versions of its castle, between which its hero passes, as a doubled

world. *Aria of Sorrow* (2003) set its story in 2035: Soma Cruz, an exchange student in Japan, is drawn into Dracula's castle within a solar eclipse, absorbs the souls of the monsters he destroys in order to wield their powers, and discovers at last that he is Dracula's reincarnation — the most explicit instance in the genre of the explorer's becoming the monster, which Chapter Five names theriomorphic accretion. *Dawn of Sorrow* (2005) followed Soma's resistance to that destiny; *Portrait of Ruin* (2006) opened painted worlds within the castle's portraits; *Order of Ecclesia* (2008) gave its heroine, Shanoa, powers inscribed as glyphs upon her body. After Igarashi's departure from Konami in 2014, his crowdfunded *Bloodstained: Ritual of the Night* carried the idiom forward under another name, with the crystalline curse that Section 4.3 read as Bluebeard's stain transvalued.

The lineage has had a characteristically palintropic afterlife. Konami has returned its own history to circulation in compilations of the handheld entries, the *Castlevania Advance Collection* (2021) and the *Castlevania Dominus Collection* (2024), and the series has been reborn in another medium in the animated *Castlevania* (2017–2021) and *Castlevania: Nocturne* (2023–), as though the franchise, like the castle at its centre, must rise again in each new age. The lineage's contribution to the genre is the castle as the paradigmatic architecture of aporia: a chronotope that returns, organized by locked doors and hidden rooms, furnished as a museum of monsters, and explored at last by the monster's own son, who bears the monster's name reversed.

STASIMON

IV



Aporia has been examined in its Gothic home. Harker's journal supplied the primal scene: a locked world, an exploration recorded in writing, a forbidden wing, a crypt, and an escape by the monster's own mode of locomotion. Bakhtin's chronotope disclosed the castle as time sedimented in space, the threshold as the chronotope of crisis, and the genre's time as accretive rather than adventurous, a time that leaves its traces on the hero's body. Walpole's castle assembled a giant from scattered parts and collapsed when the body was complete; Radcliffe's veil concealed a memento of death; Sedgwick's Gothic self was blocked from what it ought to reach; Williams's castle was the father's house; Peake's Gormenghast iterated its rituals until its heir rode out. Piranesi's staircases ended in the abyss while their climber reappeared higher, and Escher's looped until ascent and descent were one; the impossible interior proved to be the genre's limit case, deployed as local shock within a global order that the player maps anyway. Bluebeard's indelible key was transvalued: in the metroidvania there are no forbidden chambers, only chambers not yet permitted, and the stain becomes capacity. Kafka's door, meant only for the one who stands before it, was inverted by

the detour, and his surveyor who could never survey was redeemed by a map that is completed. Heidegger's Holzwege *led to clearings; the gateless gate of the Chan masters proved to be a barrier that, once passed, was never there; and the arts'* shu-ha-ri *described the player's passage from the intended route to the sequence break and beyond. Van Gennep and Turner showed every gate to be a rite of passage and the whole game to be one; Janus looked both ways, and the Holy Door opened on its date. The grammar of gates in Table 4.1 ran from the body to the mind. And the* Castlevania *lineage culminated in a hero who is the monster's son and bears the monster's name reversed.*

Aporia ends where metamorphosis begins. The gate yields not to the force of will but to a change in the one who stands before it. Harker leaves the castle by crawling down its wall as the Count did; Soma Cruz passes Dracula's castle by absorbing the souls of its monsters until he discovers he is their master; Alucard traverses his father's house forward and backward because he is his father's palindrome. The next chapter turns to that change: to the phenomenology of the body's "I can," to the expansion of the world that every new capacity brings, and to the inheritance by which the explorer, capacity by capacity, becomes the monster it came to hunt.

CHAPTER FIVE

ε'

Metamorphosis

μεταμόρφωσις

The Phenomenology of the "I Can" and the Monster's Inheritance



In nova fert animus mutatas dicere formas / corpora.
My mind moves me to tell of forms changed into new bodies.
— Ovid, *Metamorphoses* I.1–2

La conscience est originairement non pas un « je pense que » mais un « je peux ».
Consciousness is originally not an "I think that" but an "I can."
— Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phénoménologie de la perception* (1945)

5.1 *The Body Schema and the Feathered Hat*

In the second volume of his *Ideas*, drafted between 1912 and 1928 and published only in 1952, Husserl described the lived body (*Leib*) as the zero-point of orientation, the "here" from which every "there" is measured, and as the organ of the will, the bearer of an "I can" (*Ich kann*). The things of the perceived world, on this account, are given as correlates of the body's possible movements: as within reach or beyond it, as approachable, graspable, climbable, or not. The "I can" is not an inference drawn from the world but a lived horizon within which the world appears, and Chapter Three has already shown how the metroidvania decouples this horizon from the visual one, so that the unreachable ledge is seen but not "can"-ed.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) made the "I can" the foundation of a philosophy of embodiment. Consciousness, he wrote in the sentence that serves as this chapter's second epigraph, is originally not an "I think that" but an "I can." Beneath representational intentionality lies motor intentionality, the body's pre-reflective directedness toward the world, which grasps its objects in the mode of action before it represents them in the mode of thought. The body schema (*schéma corporel*) is not a mental image of the body but the dynamic organization of the body's possible actions, a way of being in the world; and the whole of conscious life is sustained by an "intentional arc" that projects around us our past, our future, our human setting, and our physical and ideological situation, and which, in illness, goes slack.

Merleau-Ponty's examples have become canonical. A woman wearing a hat with a tall feather keeps the feather clear of the things that might break it without calculation, because she feels where the feather is as she feels where her hand

is. A driver sees, without measuring, whether his car will pass through a narrow opening. For the blind man, the stick ceases to be an object and becomes an organ: he perceives not the stick in his hand but the world at its tip. An organist, given an hour's practice on an unfamiliar instrument, makes its stops and pedals the dimensions of his own body. Habit, Merleau-Ponty concluded, is the dilation of our being in the world through the incorporation of new instruments. His counter-example was a patient, known in the literature as Schneider, whose wartime brain injury had been studied by the psychologist Adhémar Gelb and the neurologist Kurt Goldstein. Schneider could perform concrete, habitual movements — he could reach for his handkerchief or swat a mosquito — but could not perform abstract movements on command, such as pointing to a part of his body when asked. His intentional arc had gone slack; his world had shrunk to the immediately actual.

The metroidvania's abilities are feathers in hats. Each is a dilation of the body schema, and each passes through the stages Merleau-Ponty described. At the moment of acquisition the new capacity is explicit, an object of attention, and the genre characteristically follows it with a short sequence of rooms that require it — the shaft that demands the new leap, the corridor that demands the new dash — in which the player rehearses the capacity consciously. These are rites of incorporation in van Gennep's sense, miniature initiations by which a capacity is taken into the body. Within an hour the capacity has withdrawn into habit. The player no longer computes whether a gap can be crossed; she perceives it as crossable or not, the gap's width having become a felt quantity measured in dashes, as the width of a doorway is measured, for the woman in Merleau-Ponty's example, in feathers. And the world re-forms around the dilated schema. Distances shrink, heights lower, the impassable becomes the merely inconvenient, and regions once arduous become thoroughfares.

The genre's embodiment is, moreover, doubled. The avatar possesses a body schema whose dilations the game grants, capacity by capacity; the player possesses a body schema whose dilations she earns, skill by skill, in the muscles of her hands. Gordon Calleja's concept of incorporation, the player's sense of being located in a game's space as an embodied agent; Brendan Keogh's account in *A Play of Bodies* of play as a cybernetic circuit joining the player's body, the hardware, and the audiovisual avatar; and Steve Swink's analysis of "game feel" as the virtual sensation of real-time control in a simulated space all describe aspects of this coupling. The controller is the blind man's stick, and the player perceives at the avatar's edges as he perceived at the stick's tip. The metroidvania's progression therefore runs on two tracks at once: acquisition, in which the avatar's schema dilates, and mastery, in which the player's does. The sequence

break, examined below, is the point at which the second outruns the first. And the genre's opening divestiture, read in this light, returns its avatar to something like Schneider's condition — a world contracted to the immediately actual, an intentional arc gone slack — from which play restores, capacity by capacity, the arc's full span, until the whole world lies within the compass of an "I can."

5.2 *Umwelt and the Tick*

The Baltic German biologist Jakob von Uexküll (1864–1944) opened his *A Foray into the Worlds of Animals and Humans* (*Streifzüge durch die Umwelten von Tieren und Menschen*, 1934), illustrated by Georg Kriszat, with the tick. Eyeless, the female tick climbs by means of a light sense diffused through her skin to the tip of a twig and waits. Three signs alone matter to her. The odour of butyric acid, emanating from the skin glands of a passing mammal, is the signal to let go and drop. The warmth and touch of the body she lands upon direct her to a hairless patch of skin. The temperature of blood tells her to bore and drink. The rest of the world does not exist for her, and she may wait for it a very long time: Uexküll reported a tick kept alive without food for eighteen years at the zoological institute in Rostock. From such cases Uexküll, who had set out his principles in *Theoretical Biology* (1920), built the concept of the *Umwelt*, the world of significance proper to each organism. Every animal is bound into its surroundings by a "functional circle" (*Funktionskreis*), in which the features it can perceive (its *Merkwelt*) and the features it can act upon (its *Wirkwelt*) close upon one another; and every animal moves within its Umwelt as within a soap bubble that encloses it and excludes all else. The same oak tree, in Uexküll's most famous illustration, is many worlds: timber for the forester, a frightening face in the bark for a little girl, a roof for the fox that dens among its roots, a shelter for the owl in its branches, a climbing frame for the squirrel, a landscape of furrows for the ant, a larder for the bark beetle's larvae.

Uexküll gave this relativity a further, temporal turn. The significance of an object, he observed, varies not only from species to species but within a single animal according to its condition, and he called these variations "tones." A hermit crab that lacks a sea anemone on its shell treats an anemone as a protector and plants it there: the anemone has a protection-tone. A crab that has lost its shell tries to crawl into the anemone: the same anemone now has a dwelling-tone. A hungry crab eats it: it has an eating-tone. The object remains what it is; its meaning for the animal is a function of the animal's state. Uexküll added the concept of the search image (*Suchbild*), by which an animal's present need

overwrites what it sees, so that the sought object appears where it is not and the unsought disappears where it is.

The metroidvania's avatar is an organism whose Umwelt is not fixed by its species but expands by acquisition. The level, as data, never changes; the world it constitutes for the avatar changes with every capacity. This may be called *Umweltwandel*, transformation of the Umwelt, and it is the deepest sense of the genre's metamorphosis: to acquire a capacity is to acquire a world. The ledge has a barrier-tone until the leap is lengthened, and thereafter a path-tone. A pool of deep water has an obstacle-tone until the Gravity Suit permits free movement within it, and thereafter a passage-tone. A long corridor has a distance-tone until *Metroid Dread*'s Speed Booster converts it into a run-up. And an enemy has a threat-tone until, in *Ori and the Blind Forest*, the ability called Bash permits Ori to launch itself off foes and their projectiles, so that hostile creatures become springboards and the world's aggression becomes the medium of the avatar's flight. Figure 5.1 draws the principle schematically: a single room, unchanged, offers three different worlds to three different bodies.

Uexküll's concept passed into philosophy by two routes, and the metroidvania takes sides between them. Heidegger's lecture course of 1929–30, *The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics*, built upon Uexküll a notorious triad: the stone is worldless, the animal is poor in world (*weltarm*), and the human being is world-forming (*weltbildend*). The animal, on Heidegger's account, is captivated (*benommen*) within a ring of disinhibitors that open it to certain stimuli and close it to everything else, and it can never encounter beings as such. Giorgio Agamben's *The Open: Man and Animal* (2002) read this triad as an instance of the "anthropological machine" by which Western thought produces the human by excluding the animal within it. Gilles Deleuze, by contrast, took Uexküll's tick as the exemplary body of an ethology, in his *Spinoza: Practical Philosophy* and with Guattari in *A Thousand Plateaus*: a body defined not by its form, its organs, or its species but by the affects of which it is capable — three, in the tick's case — and so an answer to Spinoza's challenge, in the third part of the *Ethics*, that no one has yet determined what a body can do (*nemo hucusque determinavit, quid Corpus possit*).

The metroidvania is a laboratory of Spinoza's question. It begins with a body of few affects, an avatar reduced at the outset to something like the tick's poverty, and determines, capacity by capacity, what that body can do. In doing so it refutes Heidegger's hierarchy in its own terms. Its avatar begins poor in world and becomes rich, but not by ascending from animal captivity to human world-formation: it becomes rich in world by becoming more animal, by accreting the capacities of the beasts and monsters that inhabit its world, as Section 5.6 shows.

The genre's richest worlds belong not to the human as Heidegger conceived it but to hybrids. Its designers, meanwhile, are composers of multiple Umwelten within a single space. The finest rooms of the genre are written for several bodies at once: a vertical shaft that is first a barrier, then a thoroughfare, and finally, for the expert, a launch; a cavern whose waters are first a wall and then a road. Like Uexküll's oak, such a room is many worlds, and the player inhabits them in succession, each revealed by the body she has become.

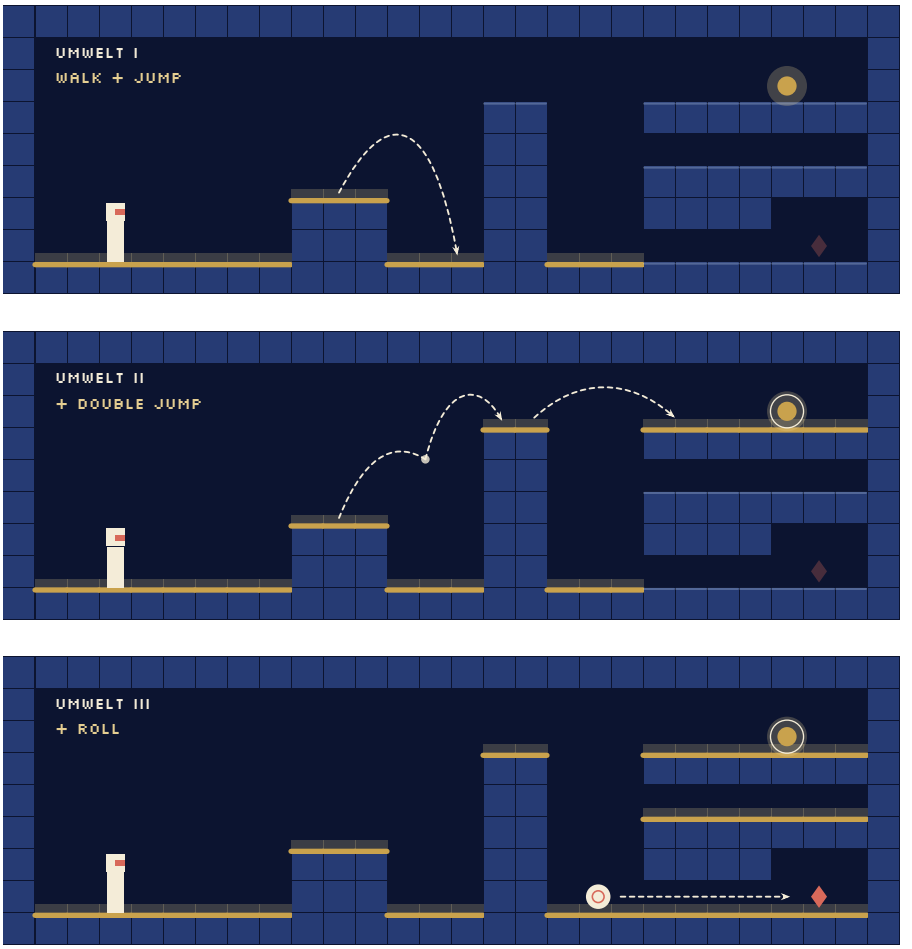


FIGURE 5.1 The same room offered to three bodies. Nothing in the level changes between the panels; what changes is the set of surfaces the body can reach, and with it the world the room constitutes.

5.3 *Equipment, Affordance, and World-Disclosure*

The analysis of equipment in *Being and Time* (§§15–18) supplies a further phenomenology of the capacity. Heidegger argued that the things we deal with in everyday life are encountered not primarily as present-at-hand objects of contemplation but as equipment (*Zeug*), ready-to-hand (*zuhanden*) within a referential totality: the hammer refers to the nails, the nails to the board, the board to the house, the house to shelter, and shelter to the for-the-sake-of-which of human existence. Ready-to-hand equipment withdraws in use; the one who hammers attends not to the hammer but to the work. The world as such becomes visible, Heidegger argued in §16, only when this withdrawal is disturbed, and he distinguished three modes of disturbance. Equipment becomes *conspicuous* when it is damaged or unusable; it becomes *obtrusive* when something needed is missing, and the more urgently we need what is missing, the more obtrusive it becomes; and something becomes *obstinate* when it stands in the way. In these breakdowns the referential totality that had been implicit lights up: the world announces itself in the disturbance of its references.

The metroidvania is a machine for producing Heidegger's breakdowns as disclosures. The gate is obstinacy, the thing that stands in the way; the missing capacity is obtrusiveness, the absence that grows more insistent the more urgently it is needed; the beam that glances harmlessly off an armoured foe is conspicuousness, the tool that fails. In each breakdown the world's network of references lights up, and the player perceives the world as a totality of relations indexed to capacities — this ledge in order to be reached by that boot, this pool in order to be crossed in that suit, this wall in order to be broken by that bomb. The map, on this reading, is the referential totality externalized. And once a capacity has been acquired, it withdraws into readiness-to-hand as Merleau-Ponty's habit predicts: the dash disappears into the crossing, and the world it opens is inhabited rather than noticed, until the next breakdown discloses it again.

James J. Gibson's *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception* (1979) gave the relation between body and world a name that has since entered the vocabulary of design. The affordances of the environment, Gibson wrote, are what it offers the animal, what it provides or furnishes, for good or ill. A surface that is horizontal, flat, extended, and rigid affords support; a surface of knee height affords sitting to an adult human but not to a child. Affordances are relative to the animal and yet perceived directly, and they cut across the dichotomy of subjective and objective. Gibson acknowledged as precursors Kurt Koffka's "demand character" and Lewin's *Aufforderungscharakter*, which Chapter Three encountered in Lewin's hodology. The psychologist William Warren gave the concept

experimental precision in a study of stair climbing (1984), which showed that observers judge a stair climbable according to the ratio of its riser height to their own leg length, with a critical value near 0.88: affordances are perceived in body-scaled units. The metroidvania manipulates the scaling constant. Each vertical capacity alters the avatar's effective leg length, and the player, after a few minutes with a new leap, perceives the climbability of ledges directly, without calculation, because the denominator of the ratio has grown.

Donald Norman's *The Design of Everyday Things* (1988; revised 2013) distinguished from affordances the signals that communicate where action is possible, which in the revised edition he called signifiers. The legible gates analysed in Section 3.1 are signifiers of a peculiar kind: they signify affordances that are not yet available. The metroidvania's world is saturated with such latent affordances, Gibsonian affordances indexed to bodies the avatar does not yet possess, and these may be called *proleptic affordances*. Prolepsis, in this ecological vocabulary, is the perception of latent affordances: the player sees the ledge as standable by a future body, the narrow passage as passable by a body yet to be acquired. The genre's world is a proleptic ecology, an environment whose offerings are addressed to the self that the explorer will become.

Heidegger's later essay "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) supplies the necessary critical counterweight. Modern technology, Heidegger argued, is a mode of revealing he called *Gestell*, enframing, which reveals nature as *Bestand*, standing-reserve: the Rhine, dammed into a hydroelectric plant, appears no longer as a river but as a supplier of water pressure. He contrasted this challenging-forth with *poiēsis*, the bringing-forth exemplified by the old wooden bridge that lets the river be a river. The metroidvania's equipment can be read in both registers. As *Gestell*, its capacities reveal the world as standing-reserve — a stock of energy tanks and missile expansions, currencies and souls, to be harvested by an explorer who is also an extractor. As *poiēsis*, its capacities let things show themselves as what they are: a lantern lets darkness be seen as darkness; *Hollow Knight*'s Dream Nail lets the dead speak in their own voices. The tension between enframing and bringing-forth, which Chapter Seven will reformulate through Pierre Hadot's distinction between Promethean and Orphic attitudes toward nature's secrets, runs through the genre's equipment, and the colonial critique of Section 5.7 takes up its first term.

5.4 *Alice's Door and the Morph Ball*

Ovidian Metamorphosis

The most exact literary archetype of the metroidvania's characteristic puzzle was published in 1865. At the bottom of the rabbit hole, Lewis Carroll's Alice finds herself in "a long, low hall" where "there were doors all round the hall, but they were all locked." On a three-legged table of solid glass lies a tiny golden key; it fits none of the doors, but behind a low curtain she discovers a little door about fifteen inches high, and the key opens it onto a passage leading to "the loveliest garden you ever saw." She longs to get out of the dark hall and wander among its bright flowers and cool fountains, "but she could not even get her head through the doorway." A bottle labelled DRINK ME shrinks her to ten inches — but she has left the key on the table, now far above her, and the glass leg is too slippery to climb. A cake marked EAT ME makes her grow to more than nine feet; she has the key again, but now she is too large. The scene contains, in a few pages, the whole grammar of the genre: a hall of locked doors that recalls Harker's castle; a key; a visible garden beyond a passage too small for the body, which is prolepsis; and a bodily transformation that must be coordinated with the possession of the key, which is metamorphosis out of phase with acquisition. The puzzle is a puzzle of sequence. Alice's door is the archetype of the Morph Ball tunnel.

The transformations precipitate a crisis of identity. "Who in the world am I?" Alice asks, after her first changes. "Ah, that's the great puzzle!" Only when the Caterpillar shows her a mushroom whose one side makes her grow and whose other side makes her shrink does she acquire control over her metamorphoses, and with that capacity mastered she returns, chapters later, to the long hall, takes the golden key, nibbles herself to the right size, and walks at last into the garden. The capacity mastered, the return to the impasse, the passage achieved: Alice's itinerary through Wonderland is palintropic in exactly the genre's sense. Its sequel, *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871), adds the genre's other law. In the Garden of Live Flowers, every path by which Alice tries to reach a hill brings her back to the house, until a Rose advises her to walk the other way; walking away from the Red Queen, she finds herself face to face with her. In Looking-Glass Land one reaches things by walking away from them, and Köhler's detour becomes a law of nature. The looking-glass landscape is laid out as a chessboard, and Alice, entering it as a white pawn, crosses it square by square until, on the eighth, she is crowned a queen. Promotion by traversal — the weakest piece becoming the most powerful by crossing the board — is the metroidvania's arc inscribed in the oldest of games.

Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, completed around 8 CE, is the genre's mythography. Its some two hundred and fifty transformations include Lycaon, the impious king turned into a wolf, the first werewolf of European literature; Io, the heifer whose crossing named the Bosporus; Daphne, escaping Apollo into the laurel; Actaeon, the hunter who glimpses the goddess bathing and is changed into a stag and torn apart by his own hounds — the hunter become the hunted, a reversal the genre stages whenever its bounty hunter is herself pursued, as Samus is by the relentless robotic sentinels of *Metroid Dread*; Narcissus, whose recognition of himself in the pool, *iste ego sum*, "I am he," is a reflexive anagnorisis to which Chapter Seven returns; Arachne, Cadmus, Philomela; and Daedalus and Icarus, rising on their wings. In the fifteenth book, the poem's cosmology is placed in the mouth of Pythagoras, and it is Heraclitean. *Omnia mutantur, nihil interit*: all things change, nothing perishes; the spirit wanders from body to body; *cuncta fluunt*, all things flow, and time itself flows like a river, wave driving wave. The metroidvania is an Ovidian form in exactly this sense. Its hero's forms change, its world's forms change in response, nothing perishes — death is followed by return — and all things flow.

The genre's Ovidian bodies are numerous. In Westone's *Wonder Boy III: The Dragon's Trap* (1989), the hero is cursed at the outset by a mechanical dragon into the form of a lizard-man and passes through a succession of further curses — a mouse-man who clings to chequered walls, a piranha-man who swims, a lion-man, a hawk-man who flies — each form opening regions closed to the others, while the quest as a whole seeks the restoration of human form: transformation as curse and as capacity at once, and the journey as an anamnesis of the body. Alucard in *Symphony of the Night* takes the forms of bat, mist, and wolf, the metamorphic repertoire Stoker had given Dracula, who appears in the novel as wolf, as bat, and as mist and dust drifting in the moonlight; the son inherits his father's shapes, and the inheritance is the subject of the next section but one. *Hollow Knight*'s Knight acquires its capacities as the relics of other bodies: the Mothwing Cloak lies beyond the place where it first meets Hornet; the Mantis Claw is the mark of the mantis tribe; the Monarch Wings are taken from the remains of a fallen vessel like itself; Isma's Tear is found in the grove of a dead knight; the Shade Cloak is drawn from the Abyss in which the Knight was born. The Knight is an empty vessel filled, form by form, with the forms of others: the hollow one as Ovidian receptacle.

The Morph Ball itself invites a mythic gloss, offered here in the analogical register. In Aristophanes' speech in the *Symposium* (189e–190a), the primeval human beings were round, with four arms, four legs, and two faces, and when they wished to move fast they went rolling over and over like tumblers turning

cartwheels; their strength was so great that they assaulted the gods, and Zeus, to weaken them, split them in two, so that love is the longing of each half for its lost other. Samus, curling into a sphere, assumes the form of the complete, pre-divided being of Aristophanes' myth: compact, mobile, rolling through passages the upright body cannot enter, and dangerous in that form, since it is as a sphere that she lays her bombs. Chapter Nine will offer a second reading of the curled body, as the fetal posture of a creature not yet born.

Ovidian metamorphosis in the genre thus runs in two directions. Outward, each new form opens new passages and constitutes a new world. Inward, each new form deepens Alice's puzzle. The more shapes the hero takes, the more urgent becomes the question of who, beneath them, it is; and the answer the genre gives, in its canonical instances, is the burden of the remaining sections of this chapter and of Chapter Seven.

5.5 *Ilinx*

Movement, Mastery, and the Sequence Break

Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) distinguished four fundamental categories of play: *agôn*, competition; *alea*, chance; *mimicry*, simulation; and *ilinx*, vertigo. Games of *ilinx*, Caillois wrote, attempt momentarily to destroy the stability of perception and to inflict "a voluptuous panic upon an otherwise lucid mind": the child spinning until the world reels, the whirling dervish, the swing, the fairground ride, the descent on skis, the tightrope. He crossed his four categories with a second axis running from *paidia*, free and turbulent improvisation, to *ludus*, the discipline of rules and of deliberately cultivated difficulty. The metroidvania's movement systems are *ilinx* disciplined by *ludus*. The vertigo of acceleration under the Speed Booster, of wall-jumps chained up a vertical shaft, of a shinespark launched across a room, of Ori ricocheting through a storm of projectiles by successive applications of Bash, of the Knight's downward strikes bouncing it across fields of spikes — these are pleasures of vertigo mastered, in which *ilinx* and *agôn* fuse. Steve Swink's account of game feel and Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi's psychology of *Flow* (1990), with its balance of challenge and skill and its merging of action and awareness, describe their phenomenology from two sides; Caillois names their genus.

The genre's movement is also a form of knowledge, and in its paradigmatic text that knowledge is transmitted by creatures. *Super Metroid* never explains its wall jump in words. In a shaft deep in Brinstar, small simian creatures called Etecoons leap from wall to wall above Samus, and she can learn the technique — and, if she has not already mastered it, escape the shaft — only by watching and imitating them; elsewhere the ostrich-like Dachora demonstrates the shinespark. The knowledge of movement passes by mimesis from the world's native fauna to the explorer, who learns to move as the planet's animals move. At the game's end, during the timed escape from the dying planet, the player may turn aside to the chamber where these creatures are trapped and blast open the wall that holds them; if she does, a tiny ship is glimpsed fleeing the explosion in the closing sequence. Nothing else rewards the detour. It is an act of gratitude toward the teachers, inscribed in the margin of the escape, and Chapter Nine will return to it as the genre's purest ethical gesture.

Beyond the techniques its designers taught, the genre's movement systems have yielded techniques its designers did not teach and, in some cases, did not foresee. *Super Metroid*'s players discovered how to carry running speed into the Morph Ball by entering it mid-stride, how to climb indefinitely by timed successions of bomb blasts, and how to restore energy at the brink of death

through an undocumented input sequence; *Hollow Knight*'s players learned to chain downward strikes into extended aerial traversals; the communities around *Metroid Prime* named and catalogued dozens of such techniques. The body's knowledge, cultivated by thousands of hours of practice, outruns the grammar the designer wrote, and the community's name for this surplus is simply "tech."

Its most consequential application is the sequence break: the attainment of a region or capacity earlier than the intended order permits, by technique, by glitch, or by an overlooked route. The practice flourished in the *Metroid* community and became a subculture around *Metroid Prime* (2002), whose players catalogued and named its breaks and whose developers, by the community's account, closed some of them in later releases. Speed had been institutionalized in the genre from the first. The original *Metroid* rewarded completion within an hour with its most revealing ending, and *Super Metroid* reserved its best ending for completion within three hours, so that the genre's founding works contained, avant la lettre, the incentives of the speedrun — incentives whose gendered character Section 5.7 examines. The speedrunning culture that grew from these seeds has elaborated categories — completion by any means ("any%"), completion with every item ("100%"), completion with as few items as possible ("low%") — and has carried the genre's founding texts into charity marathons such as Games Done Quick, held since 2010, where *Super Metroid* has long been a fixture.

Bernard Suits defined game-playing as the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles. The speedrun is a second-order game built upon the first: it adds new self-imposed constraints and new categories of rule to a game whose obstacles were already unnecessary. The sequence break, within it, overcomes obstacles that the designer meant to be necessary by means the designer did not sanction; it is play against the designer's law. Espen Aarseth has called such practices "transgressive play" (2007), play that refuses the role of the implied player even as it testifies to a game's openness to that refusal. In the terms of Chapter Four, the sequence breaker is the anti-type of Kafka's man from the country: she does not wait before the door of the law but finds another way in. In the terms of the Japanese arts, she has passed from *shu* to *ha*, from keeping the form to breaking it, and the speedrun is her *ri*.

The sequence break explores what Chapter Two called the labyrinth's unconscious, the graph that physics permits beneath the graph the designer intended. Its two great categories define the poles of the genre's metamorphosis. The hundred-per-cent run seeks total accretion, every capacity and every expansion, the body maximally transformed. The low-percentage run, which completes the game with the fewest capacities the world will permit, is an ascetic counter-practice, a *via negativa* of metamorphosis: it seeks the minimum Umwelt suf-

ficient for the whole world, and shows how little transformation the passage strictly requires. Between these poles lies the spectrum of the genre's possible bodies.

The sequence break is also the strongest evidence that the genre's metamorphosis is double. If the player's skill can substitute for the avatar's capacity, then the player's own body has become a key; the transformation that matters has occurred not in the avatar but in the hands that guide it. The next substitution is already implicit. If skill can stand in for capacity, so can knowledge, and the knowledge-gated works that Chapter Six examines — in which the only capacity is understanding — are the logical terminus of the sequence break: worlds in which the key is entirely in the one who plays.

5.6 *Theriomorphic Accretion*

Lovecraft, Giger, Alien, Metroid

The historian of religion calls a god *theriomorphic* when it takes the form of a beast, from the Greek *thērion*, wild animal, and *morphē*, form. This study calls *theriomorphic accretion* the explorer's progressive acquisition of the powers of the creatures it hunts, culminating in assimilation, so that the end of the hunt is the hunter's identity with the hunted. Its literary archetype is H. P. Lovecraft's "The Shadow over Innsmouth," written in 1931 and published in 1936. Its narrator, investigating a decaying New England port whose inhabitants bear a hereditary deformity from generations of interbreeding with the amphibious Deep Ones, flees the town in horror; but his genealogical researches reveal that he is himself descended from them, and as his body begins to change, his horror turns to longing. The story ends with his resolve to go down to the sea and dwell in the city beneath the reef, among wonder and glory. The investigator becomes the investigated, and the terror of the other resolves into a recognition of the self.

Lovecraft supplied the genre with more than this charter. *At the Mountains of Madness*, written in 1931 and serialized in 1936, sends an Antarctic expedition into the ruins of a city built by the Elder Things, a vanished non-human civilization whose history the explorers reconstruct from bas-reliefs carved on its walls — the archaeological reading of an alien past that Chapter Eight examines as the genre's environmental storytelling — and whose depths still harbour the protoplasmic shoggoths that destroyed their makers. And he invented a grimoire, the *Necronomicon*, whose name the Swiss artist H. R. Giger borrowed for a book of his paintings published in 1977. Giger's art fused flesh and machine, the organic and the industrial, eros and death, in what he called biomechan-

ics. The screenwriter Dan O'Bannon, developing the script that became Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979), showed Giger's *Necronomicon* to Scott, and Giger was engaged to design the creature, derived from his painting *Necronom IV*, together with the derelict alien vessel and its fossilized pilot. The film's monster has a life cycle of exemplary abjection — egg, a "facehugger" that implants an embryo through the victim's mouth, a juvenile that bursts from the host's chest, a towering adult — and its human antagonist is the corporation, whose instructions to the ship's computer, "Mother," make the crew expendable in the interest of bringing the organism home.

Metroid descends from this lineage by documented influence. Its makers have acknowledged *Alien*; its dragon-like Space Pirate commander is named Ridley; its Metroids are parasites that latch onto the heads of their prey and drain their life; its innermost fortress, Tourian, is a biomechanical interior of tubes and tissue; and at its heart, in a glass tank, floats Mother Brain, the intelligence that governs the planet's defences — the betraying computer of Scott's film made flesh. Barbara Creed's essay "Horror and the Monstrous-Feminine" (1986), developed in *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993), read *Alien* as a meditation on the archaic mother, the parthenogenetic and all-devouring origin, figured in the ship's womb-like interiors, its scenes of monstrous birth, and the computer called Mother. Creed drew on Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980), whose concept of abjection names what disturbs identity, system, and order — the corpse, the body's fluids, and the maternal body from which the subject must separate itself in order to become a subject at all. The Metroid is abject in Kristeva's sense, a membranous, translucent parasite that dissolves the boundary between its body and its prey's; Mother Brain is Creed's archaic mother; and Tourian, as Chapter Nine argues, is a womb.

Across four decades, the *Metroid* series has made theriomorphic accretion its plot. In *Metroid II: Return of Samus* (1991), Samus is sent to the Metroids' home planet to exterminate them, a counter of survivors diminishing on her display; she spares the last hatchling, which imprints upon her as its mother. In *Super Metroid* (1994), the hatchling, stolen and grown to enormous size, seizes Samus and begins to drain her — then recognizes her and withdraws; at the climax it drains Mother Brain, transfers the stolen energy to the dying Samus, and is destroyed, and Samus's weapon takes on a power drawn from its sacrifice. The Metroid's life passes into her arm. In *Metroid Fusion* (2002), infected by the X parasite, she is saved by a vaccine cultured from the hatchling's cells: she becomes part Metroid, able to absorb the X as a Metroid would, and inherits the Metroid's vulnerability to cold, while her discarded armour, possessed by the parasite, becomes a doppelgänger that hunts her through the station. In *Metroid*

Dread (2021), the Chozo warrior Raven Beak seeks to harvest her Metroid nature, and at the climax that nature awakens: her armour transforms and she drains the life of her enemies as a Metroid does. The exterminator has become the last of the species she was sent to exterminate. The series' title, which named her prey, names by the end its protagonist.

The pattern recurs across the canon. Alucard's metamorphoses are his father's. Soma Cruz absorbs the souls of monsters and learns that he is the reincarnation of their master; Miriam absorbs demonic shards at the risk of crystallizing into a monster herself. *Hollow Knight*'s Knight, a vessel of the Void, accretes the capacities of the dead, and in the ending its players call "Embrace the Void" it assumes a form of living shadow, a creature of the Abyss from which it came. The Penitent One of *Blasphemous* takes into himself the relics and the guilt of a whole land, his sword a thorned blade forged from guilt. And *Axiom Verge*'s Trace discovers that the antagonist he has pursued is another iteration of himself.

Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* (1915) begins with the most famous sentence of modern German prose: "Als Gregor Samsa eines Morgens aus unruhigen Träumen erwachte, fand er sich in seinem Bett zu einem ungeheueren Ungeziefer verwandelt" — when Gregor Samsa woke one morning from uneasy dreams, he found himself transformed in his bed into a monstrous vermin. Deleuze and Guattari, in their book on Kafka and in the tenth plateau of *A Thousand Plateaus*, theorized such transformations as "becoming-animal": not imitation, not identification, not metaphor, but a line of flight, a passage out of the territories of the human through a zone of proximity with the animal, often by alliance with an "anomalous" individual, as Ahab allies himself with the white whale. The metroidvania's protagonists are becomings-animal in this sense: Harker becoming-lizard on the castle wall, Samus becoming-Metroid, Alucard becoming bat and wolf and mist, the Knight becoming-Void. *Hollow Knight* begins where Gregor ends. Its protagonist is already an insect, and finds in the kingdom of insects not degradation but a world. The genre completes Kafka's metamorphosis as glory rather than shame, and Lovecraft's Innsmouth, in which the investigator goes down at last to the sea, is its secret charter.

Theriomorphic accretion is the genre's dark law. Every capacity taken from the world is taken from its creatures; the explorer's growth is its assimilation; and the hunt ends with the hunter become the hunted species. Chapter Seven will argue that this is why the genre's final secret takes the form it does. The monster at the centre of the labyrinth, when the last veil is lifted, wears the explorer's face.

5.7 *The Cyborg, the Dhampir, and the Colonist Colonized*

Donna Haraway's "A Manifesto for Cyborgs," published in *Socialist Review* in 1985, defined the cyborg as a hybrid of machine and organism, a creature of social reality as well as of fiction, and argued that late twentieth-century culture had already breached three boundaries on which Western identity rested: between human and animal, between organism and machine, and between the physical and the non-physical. The cyborg, Haraway insisted, has no origin story in the Western sense — no Eden, no Oedipal family romance — and her manifesto closed with a declaration that has become a slogan: "I would rather be a cyborg than a goddess." Samus Aran is a Harawayan cyborg in every particular. Her armour is Chozo technology bonded to her body; the series' supplementary lore has the Chozo infuse her with their own blood; and *Fusion* and *Dread* add the genetic material of the Metroids. She crosses all three of Haraway's boundaries — human and animal, organism and machine, matter and energy — and her origin is adoptive rather than Oedipal: orphaned when Ridley's pirates destroyed the colony of her birth, she was raised by an avian species, a daughter of birds. When the series at last stages a confrontation with a father, in *Metroid Dread*, the father is a Chozo warlord, Raven Beak, who claims her as kin of his tribe through the blood she carries, so that the family romance is displaced onto an adoptive species.

The revelation in 1986 that the armoured protagonist was a woman was both an emancipatory surprise and the beginning of a scopic economy. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema organizes its pleasures around a gendered division of looking, in which woman is image and man the bearer of the look, and coded woman by her "to-be-looked-at-ness." The endings of *Metroid* and *Super Metroid* rewarded fast completion with progressively unarmoured images of Samus, so that the woman's body became the trophy of the player's mastery and the reveal was capitalized as spectacle. Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified in the slasher film a "final girl," resourceful, watchful, and often masculinized, who survives the monster when all others have died, and counted Ripley of *Alien* among her kin; Samus, encased in armour until the end, is a final girl of the same lineage. Later works have revised the inheritance in opposite directions. *Metroid: Zero Mission* (2004) appended a sequence in which Samus, stripped of her suit, must survive with only a pistol, making vulnerability a phase of the metamorphosis rather than a reward for the gaze. *Metroid: Other M* (2010), developed with Team Ninja, had Samus refrain from using capacities she already possessed until her former commanding officer authorized them, most notoriously withhold-

ing her protection against heat until after she had crossed a superheated region; the decision was widely criticized. Its interest for theory is that it made explicit what the genre usually leaves implicit. The ability-gate can function as authorization, the "I can" subordinated to a "you may," and in Michel Foucault's terms in *Discipline and Punish* (1975) it can become an apparatus for producing docile bodies, whose capacities are increased in utility and diminished in autonomy. The genre's best works return the capacities to the hero's own agency; *Other M* exposed the disciplinary possibility latent in all of them.

The dhampir of Balkan folklore, child of a vampire and a human, was credited with the power to detect and destroy vampires: a hybrid whose doubleness made it the mediator between worlds. Alucard is a dhampir, as is the hero of *Vampire Hunter D*, and the figure recurs whenever the genre needs a protagonist who belongs to both sides of the threshold — a liminal persona in Turner's sense. *Hollow Knight*'s Hornet, daughter of the Pale King and of Herrah the Beast, is such a hybrid, a guardian at the kingdom's thresholds who, in *Hollow Knight: Silksong* (2025), becomes the explorer of a world of her own. Homi Bhabha's *The Location of Culture* (1994) theorized hybridity as the ambivalence that colonial discourse produces within itself and that unsettles its authority, opening a "Third Space" in which the colonizer's categories no longer hold. The genre's hybrids occupy that space.

They occupy it within an imaginary that is, on its surface, frankly imperial. Chapter Two traced the genre's pleasure in the blank space to Marlow's boyhood and the monarch-of-all-I-survey. Samus is an agent of a Galactic Federation; the Space Pirates are the enemies of its order; the Chozo ruins are the remains of a vanished civilization to be read, plundered, and inherited; and the planets she visits are stocks of energy tanks and missile expansions, standing-reserve in Heidegger's sense. Extermination is progress: *Metroid II* counts down the survivors of the species Samus is sent to destroy, and its 2017 remake by MercurySteam, *Metroid: Samus Returns*, makes the genetic material of slain Metroids the key that opens the way forward, so that the key is literally the corpse. Natural history serves the same order. *Metroid Prime*'s scan visor catalogues every creature of Tallon IV in a Linnaean logbook, and Mary Louise Pratt has shown how the naturalist's apparently innocent gaze, organizing the world's flora and fauna into the system Linnaeus published in 1735, functioned as an "anti-conquest," by which European subjects secured their innocence in the very act of asserting their hegemony.

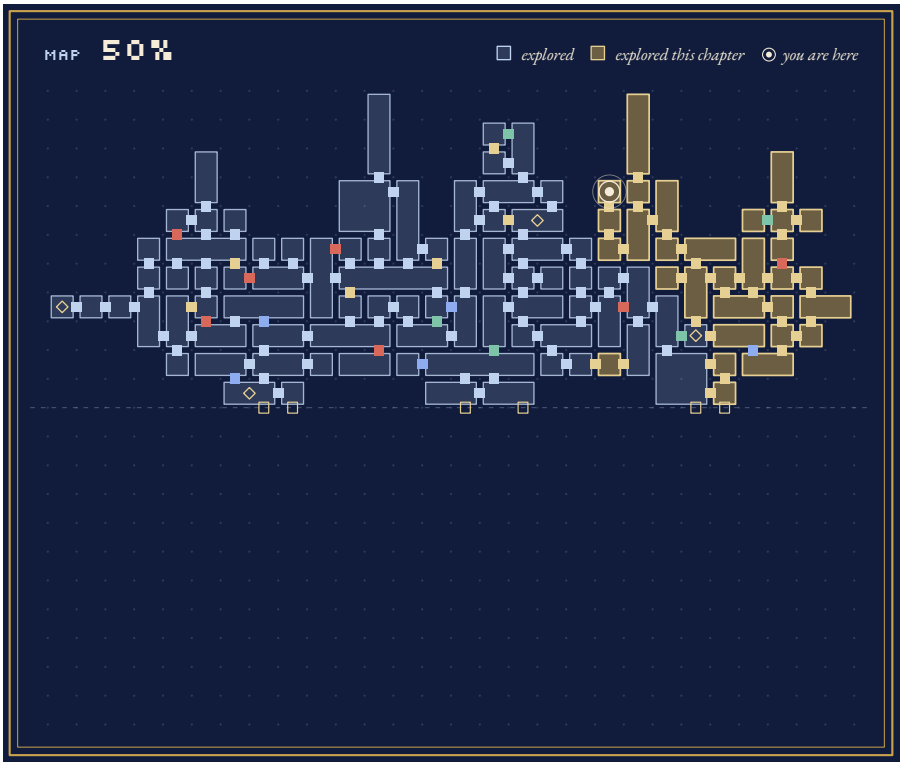
Yet the genre's canonical arcs will not let the colonist remain himself. The explorer who arrives as the agent of an external order is assimilated to the world it explores. Samus becomes a Metroid and is revealed as kin to the Chozo whose ru-

ins she plunders, their inheritor not by conquest but by blood. *Hollow Knight*'s Knight, apparently a wanderer come from outside, proves to be a native of the Abyss beneath the kingdom, returning to the place of its birth. Soma Cruz, the foreign student drawn into an alien castle, is its master's reincarnation; Alucard is its heir. The colonist is colonized by the colony — not morally redeemed, but structurally assimilated. The contrast with the literature of first contact is instructive. In Arthur C. Clarke's *Rendezvous with Rama* (1973), human explorers map the interior of a vast alien cylinder passing through the solar system, never meet its makers, and watch it depart with its purpose unknown: the explorer remains external, humbled by incomprehension. Lovecraft's Antarctic explorers flee the city they have half-understood. The metroidvania differs from both. It grants total comprehension at the price of assimilation.

This structural undoing does not absolve the genre of the pleasures it entertains. The completed map remains the monarch's survey; the extermination counter still counts down; the scan visor still classifies. The genre stages conquest and its undoing at once, and its critique of empire is formal rather than moral: it does not condemn the explorer's desire to master the world but shows, with the inexorability of a structure, where that desire leads. In Bhabha's terms, the hybrid explorer is the site at which the colonial fantasy of mastery collapses into kinship. The metroidvania's last word on empire is that to master a world is to become it.

STASIMON

V



Metamorphosis has been traced from the body outward and from the world inward. Husserl's "I can" and Merleau-Ponty's body schema showed each capacity to be a dilation of being in the world, incorporated as the feather is incorporated into the hat and the stick into the hand, rehearsed in rooms of incorporation and then withdrawn into habit; the genre's embodiment proved double, the avatar's schema dilating by acquisition and the player's by mastery, and its opening divestiture a slackening of the intentional arc that play restores. Uexküll's tick and oak showed that to acquire a capacity is to acquire a world, the same room offering different worlds to different bodies, as Figure 5.1 draws it; Spinoza's question of what a body can do found in the genre a laboratory, and Heidegger's poverty of the animal was refuted by an avatar that grows rich in world by becoming more animal. Heidegger's breakdowns of equipment disclosed the world as a network of references indexed to capacities; Gibson's affordances, scaled to the body, yielded the concept of proleptic affordance, and the tension between enframing and bringing-forth was found running through the genre's equipment. Alice's door, her mushroom, and her promotion from pawn to

queen; Ovid's flux; the curses of Wonder Boy*; Alucard's inherited shapes; the Knight as hollow receptacle; and the Morph Ball as Aristophanes' rolling sphere composed the genre's Ovidian mythography, in which each new form deepens Alice's question of who, beneath the forms, one is. Caillois's* ilinx*, disciplined by* ludus*, named the vertigo of the genre's movement; the Etecoons taught the wall jump and were repaid by an act of gratitude in the margin of an escape; the sequence break was play against the designer's law, the low-percentage run a* via negativa *of metamorphosis, and skill a key that prefigures knowledge as a key. Theriomorphic accretion, chartered by Lovecraft's Innsmouth and descended through Giger and* Alien *to* Metroid*, carried the exterminator to the condition of the last of her prey; Kafka's vermin became, in Hallownest, a citizen of a world. And the cyborg, the final girl, the dhampir, and the hybrid showed the genre's imperial imaginary undone from within: to master a world is to become it.*

The transformed hero must now go back. It must return to the places it passed when it was weaker, and it must be recognized there — by the world, and by itself. Chapter Six turns to that return, and to the mythic grammar in which humanity has narrated it: the descent of Inanna through the seven gates, the golden bough, the scar of Odysseus, Perceval's unasked question, the prisoner's return to Plato's cave, Jung's many-storeyed house, Freud's involuntary street, and the castle turned upside down.

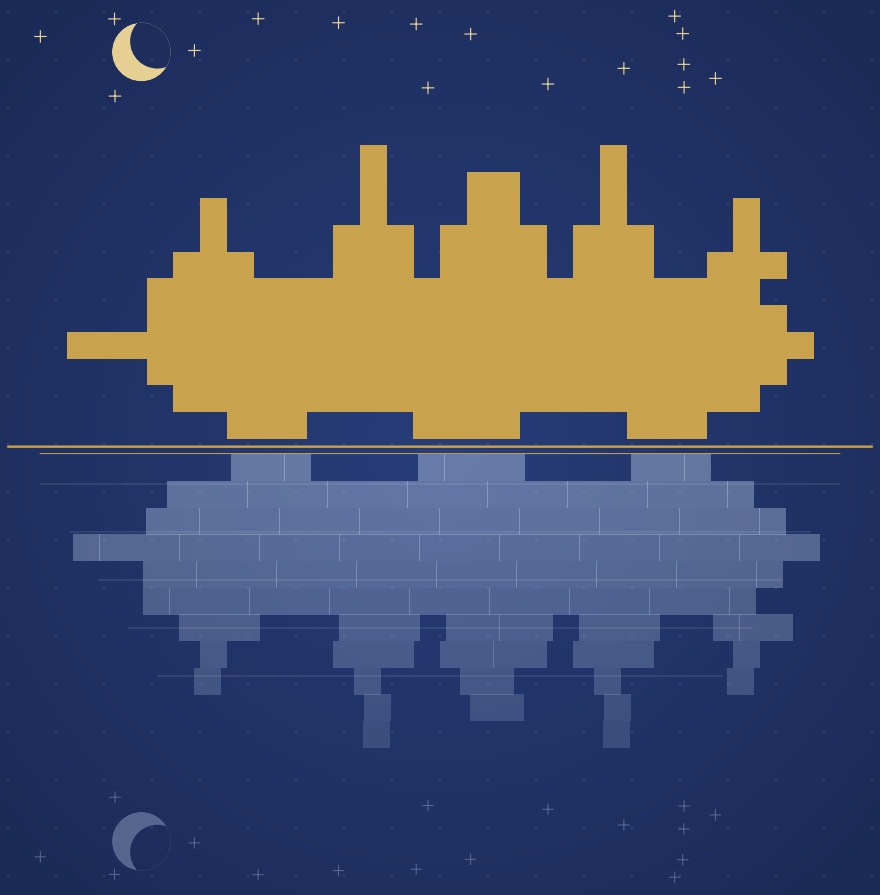
CHAPTER SIX

ς΄

Anagnorisis

ἀναγνώρισις

Katabasis and the Mythic Grammar of Return



an gal-ta ki gal-še₃ ĝeštug₂-ga-ni na-an-ĝub

From the great above she set her mind upon the great below.

— *Inanna's Descent to the Netherworld*, line 1

ἀναγνώρισις δέ, ὥσπερ καὶ τοὔνομα σημαίνει, ἐξ ἀγνοίας εἰς γνῶσιν μεταβολή.

Recognition, as its very name indicates, is a change from ignorance to knowledge.

— Aristotle, *Poetics* 1452a

6.1 *Inanna at the Seven Gates*

Divestiture and Investiture

Among the oldest written narratives of humankind is a story of descent. *Inanna's Descent to the Netherworld*, a Sumerian poem preserved on tablets of the early second millennium BCE and composed earlier still, is the oldest surviving katabasis. Inanna, queen of heaven, sets her mind upon the great below. She abandons her seven temples and takes up seven divine powers, the *me*, in the form of garments and ornaments: a crown, a necklace of small lapis-lazuli beads, a double strand of beads upon her breast, a breastplate, a golden ring upon her hand, a lapis-lazuli measuring rod and line, and the *pala* robe of ladyship. She instructs her minister, Ninshubur, to raise a lament and seek the help of the great gods should she fail to return. At Ganzer, the gate of the underworld, she demands entry of the gatekeeper Neti, who reports her coming to the queen of the dead, her sister Ereshkigal. Ereshkigal orders the seven gates bolted and opened to Inanna one at a time, and at each gate one of her powers is taken from her. When she protests, she is told that the rites of the underworld have been fulfilled and that she must not open her mouth against them. She arrives before her sister naked and bowed; the judges of the underworld fasten upon her the eye of death; and she becomes a corpse hung upon a hook.

After three days and nights Ninshubur goes from god to god. Enlil and Nanna refuse; but Enki fashions from the dirt beneath his fingernails two tiny beings who slip into the underworld unnoticed, console Ereshkigal in her groaning by echoing her cries, and, granted a gift for their sympathy, ask for the corpse on its hook. They sprinkle upon it the food and the water of life, and Inanna rises. No one, however, ascends from the underworld unmarked. Inanna must provide a substitute, and the demons who accompany her upward pass over those who mourned her until they find her husband, Dumuzi, seated upon his throne in splendour, unmourning; she gives him to them, and his sister Geshtinanna, at last, consents to share his fate, each to spend half the year below. The poem's Akkadian descendant, *Ishtar's Descent to the Netherworld*, completes a symmetry the Sumerian only implies. Its goddess threatens to break the gate and raise the dead to devour the living; at each of seven gates an ornament is taken from her — crown, earrings, necklace, breast ornaments, girdle, bracelets, and at last the cloth about her loins — and on her ascent the gatekeeper restores them to her, gate by gate, in reverse order.

Chapter Three read the metroidvania's characteristic opening — Alucard stripped by Death at the castle's threshold, Samus disarmed aboard the frigate Orpheon, the Knight returning hollow to a kingdom it has forgotten — as a

forgetting that makes recollection necessary. The Sumerian myth discloses the shape of that forgetting. Inanna's poem dwells on the descent: the progressive stripping, gate by gate, toward nakedness and death. The metroidvania dwells on the other half of the path, the half the Akkadian poem supplies: the progressive re-investiture, gate by gate, toward the light. The genre is Inanna's descent read backward. It begins at the bottom, on the hook, and its play is the long return through the gates, each power restored in turn. Divestiture and investiture are one path walked in two directions — the way down and the way up that Heraclitus declared one and the same — and Figure 6.1 draws them so.

The Sumerian *me* were the divine powers and offices that constituted civilization itself — kingship, priesthood, the crafts, the arts of love and of war — and in Inanna's case they constituted her divinity. Stripped of them, she is not a weakened goddess but a corpse. The metroidvania's capacities constitute its avatar's identity in the same way, and the return through the gates is accordingly not merely the recovery of equipment but the reconstitution of a self. Anagnorisis begins here, as the recovery of one's own regalia: at each gate the hero recognizes, in the power restored, something that was always its own. Inanna's question at every gate — *what is this?* — is the question of the stripped self, and the genre's long ascent is its answer.

Two further features of the myth illuminate the genre. The first is the manner of the rescue. The gates are governed by a law that may not be questioned, as Kafka's door is governed by its doorkeeper; but Enki's creatures pass through them unnoticed because they are too small to be stopped, like Daedalus's ant in the spiral shell, and they win the corpse not by force but by sympathy, by sharing the groans of the queen of the dead. The key to the underworld is compassion, and Section 6.4 will find the same key in Perceval's question. The second is the law of substitution: no one leaves the underworld unmarked, and the return of one requires the descent of another. The genre knows this law. In *Super Metroid* the grown hatchling gives its life so that Samus may rise from the floor of Mother Brain's chamber; in *Hollow Knight*'s first ending, the Knight takes the place of the Hollow Knight within the sealed temple at the kingdom's heart, so that one vessel goes in as another comes out. And Dumuzi's alternation with his sister, half the year above and half below, makes the descent itself a cycle — as in the Greek myth of Persephone, bound by the pomegranate seeds to return each year to the underworld — a cyclical katabasis whose ludic form is the genre's practice of beginning the journey again.

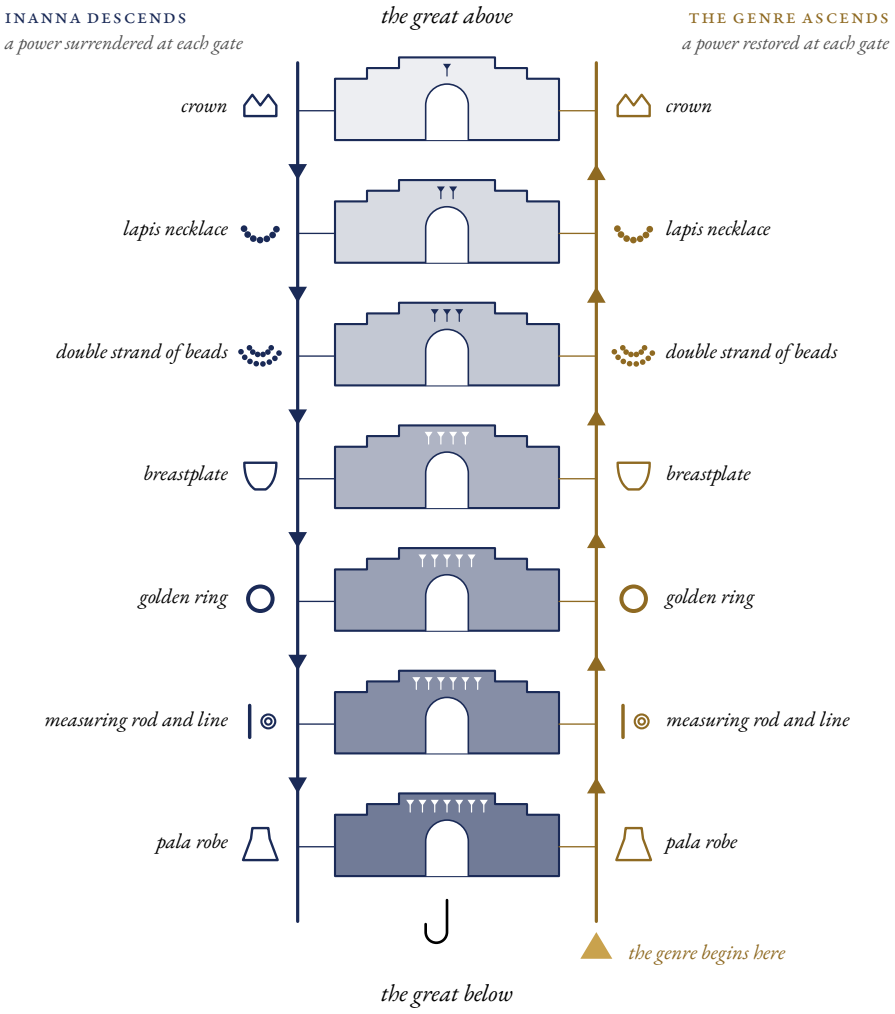


FIGURE 6.1 Inanna surrenders one of her seven powers at each gate on the way down (left, in the order of the Sumerian poem); the genre walks the same gates upward, restoring a power at each (right). The metroidvania begins at the bottom, where the myth's descent ends.

6.2 *The Golden Bough as Key Item*

In the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, Aeneas comes to the Sibyl at Cumae and asks to be led down to his dead father. Her answer is the most quoted sentence ever written about the underworld, and it reads as though composed for the genre this study examines:

> *facilis descensus Averno: / noctes atque dies patet atri ianua Ditis; / sed revocare gradum superasque evadere ad auras, / hoc opus, hic labor est.* (VI.126–129)
>
> *The descent to Avernus is easy: night and day the door of black Dis stands open. But to recall your steps and escape to the upper air — this is the task, this the labour.*

The door of the underworld, like the door of Kafka's Law, stands open; the descent is easy; and the work is the return. *Revocare gradum*, to call back the step, is a Latin name for backtracking, and the Sibyl declares it the labour of the hero. Her maxim also names a law of the genre's level design. Its descents are easy — the long fall down a shaft, the ledge from which one may drop but to which one cannot climb back — and its ascents require capacities. The one-way drop that commits the player to a region until some new capacity permits escape is the Sibyl's sentence built into architecture.

The Sibyl's further instructions (VI.136–148) describe the first key item of Western literature. Hidden in a dark tree, she tells Aeneas, is a bough golden in leaf and in pliant stem, sacred to the queen of the underworld, concealed by the grove and enclosed by shadow in the dim valleys. No one may enter the hidden places beneath the earth before plucking this golden-tressed growth from its tree, for Proserpina has ordained that it be brought to her as her due. When one is torn away, another, golden, does not fail (*uno avulso non deficit alter / aureus*), and the stem leafs again in the same metal. Search for it with your eyes on high, she says, and pluck it duly with your hand; if the Fates are calling you, it will come away willingly and easily; otherwise no strength will overcome it, and no hard steel will cut it free. Aeneas, guided through the forest by a pair of doves, the birds of his mother Venus, sees at last the glint of gold shining through the dark branches, and plucks the bough, which yields, though hesitating. At the Styx, the ferryman Charon refuses passage to the living hero until the Sibyl draws the bough from her robe, and at the sight of the venerable gift of the fated wand, long unseen, he relents. At the threshold of Proserpina's palace, Aeneas fixes the bough upon the doorway.

Every property of the golden bough is a convention of the genre's key items. Its location is marked by a glint of gold through dark branches, visible before it is reached: prolepsis. It is found by following guides, and the guides are birds, as Samus's guides are the vanished avian Chozo whose statues hold her capacities in their hands. It is demanded by a gatekeeper who yields to the token and to nothing else. It is deposited at the threshold it opens, consumed in the act of opening. It renews itself, so that its taking does not impoverish the world. And it yields only to the one for whom it is fated, resisting every other force — as the genre's coloured hatches ignore every weapon but the one they are keyed to, and as Kafka's door was meant for one man only. The genre's grammar of the key, whose forms Table 4.1 classified, has its earliest and most complete literary statement in Virgil's grove.

James George Frazer took his title from the same passage. *The Golden Bough* (1890; third edition in twelve volumes, 1906–1915) began from the grove of Diana at Nemi, where a priest-king, the *Rex Nemorensis*, guarded a sacred tree with a drawn sword: a runaway slave who could break a bough from the tree might fight him, and, killing him, reign in his place until he was himself slain. Frazer identified the bough with the mistletoe by which, in Norse myth, the god Balder was killed, and built from Nemi a vast comparative account of the dying and reviving god — Adonis, Attis, Osiris, and Tammuz, the Babylonian form of the Dumuzi whom Inanna gave to the demons. Later scholarship, Jonathan Z. Smith's prominent among it, has criticized Frazer's method for collapsing distinct phenomena into a single universal pattern, and that method is precisely the universalizing comparison this study set aside in Chapter One. But Frazer's image of Nemi survives his method. The guarded tree, the bough as the token of challenge, and the succession by which the slayer of the guardian becomes the guardian name the logic of the genre's bosses: a guardian at a threshold whose defeat yields the capacity it guarded, and a hero who, by that succession, comes to occupy the guardian's place, as the Knight of *Hollow Knight* comes to occupy the place of the vessel it was sent to relieve.

The sixth book ends with a crux that bears on the genre's ending. There are two gates of Sleep, Virgil writes (VI.893–898): one of horn, through which true shades pass easily, and one of shining ivory, through which the spirits send false dreams to the upper world. Anchises dismisses his son and the Sibyl through the gate of ivory. Commentators have debated for two millennia why Aeneas should return to the living by the gate of false dreams. The metroidvania's exodos poses the same question in its own idiom. When the player leaves the completed labyrinth, she passes through a gate back into the waking world, and it is not obvious on which side of that gate the dream lies.

6.3 *Nostos and Nekyia*

The subject of the *Odyssey* is *nostos*, homecoming, and its hero is *polytropos*, the man of many turns. The word "nostalgia" was coined from *nostos* and *algos*, pain, in 1688, when the Swiss physician Johannes Hofer used it to name the homesickness that afflicted Swiss soldiers serving abroad: a disease of return. The metroidvania is doubly nostalgic. Its culture cultivates a nostalgia for its own eight- and sixteen-bit past, so that the genre's revival in the 2000s was in part a homecoming to the forms of its practitioners' childhoods; and its works characteristically end with a homecoming within the fiction, a return to the place of origin — the gunship waiting in the rain on Crateria, the forlorn town above Hallownest, the Spirit Tree — that Chapter Three read as Bloch's *Heimat*, the home in which no one has yet been.

In the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*, the *Nekyia*, Odysseus goes to the edge of the world on Circe's instructions, digs a pit, and pours into it the blood of sacrificed sheep to summon the dead. The prophet Tiresias foretells his return and a last journey inland with an oar on his shoulder, until he meets a people who mistake it for a winnowing fan. His mother, Anticleia, who died of longing for him, appears among the shades; three times he tries to embrace her, and three times she slips from his arms like a shadow or a dream. Achilles tells him that he would rather labour as a hired man for a landless farmer than be king over all the dead; Ajax turns away in silence, unreconciled. The *Nekyia* is a descent for knowledge. Odysseus goes down to the dead in order to learn the way home, and the underworld is the archive in which the conditions of return are kept. The metroidvania's depths are archives of the same kind: the lore of the Chozo inscribed in the ruins of *Metroid Prime*'s Tallon IV, the tablets and remains of Hallownest, the thoughts of the dead that *Hollow Knight*'s Dream Nail allows the Knight to read. The genre's hero, like Odysseus, descends among the dead to learn what its return requires.

The return itself is narrated in the *Odyssey* as a sequence of recognitions so various that the second half of the poem amounts to a poetics of anagnorisis. Odysseus comes back to Ithaca disguised by Athena as an aged beggar: the returned hero is unrecognizable because he has been changed. His old dog, Argos, lying neglected on a dung heap, knows him at once, wags his tail, and dies. His nurse Eurycleia, washing his feet, finds beneath her hands the scar on his thigh that a boar's tusk gave him in his youth on Mount Parnassus, and Homer suspends the moment of recognition to tell, at length, the story of the hunt in which the scar was received. Erich Auerbach made this digression the subject of "Odysseus' Scar," the opening chapter of *Mimesis* (1946), contrasting the Home-

ric style, which externalizes everything in a uniformly illuminated foreground, with the narrative of the Hebrew Bible, fraught with background and with the unexpressed. For the present argument the digression's structure matters most: an analepsis inserted into the instant of recognition. To recognize the scar is to recall its origin, as the metroidvania's return to a room recalls, within the present visit, the first.

The decisive recognition of the poem is achieved by a bow. In the twenty-first book, none of Penelope's suitors can bend and string the great bow of Odysseus. The disguised beggar takes it, turns it in his hands, and strings it without effort, as a man skilled in the lyre and in song easily stretches a string about a new peg, fastening the twisted sheep-gut at either end; then he plucks the string, and it sings beautifully, like the voice of a swallow. He shoots an arrow through the twelve axes, and the slaughter of the suitors begins. Homer's simile joins, in the poem's climactic recognition, the two instruments that Heraclitus would name, three centuries later, as the figures of the *palintropos harmoniē*: the bow and the lyre. The returned hero's identity is proved by the back-turning tension of the bow, and the capacity that only the true Odysseus possesses is, quite literally, the palintrope itself. The remaining recognitions complete the poetics. Penelope tests the stranger by ordering their bed moved, and he reveals in anger that it cannot be moved, since he built it himself around the trunk of a living olive tree still rooted in the earth: a secret known only to the two of them. And to his father Laertes, in the orchard, Odysseus proves himself by naming the trees that Laertes gave him as a child: thirteen pear trees, ten apple trees, forty fig trees, and fifty rows of vines.

The metroidvania's return is the return of Odysseus. Its hero comes back changed, disguised by its transformations, and the world recognizes it through tokens of exactly the Homeric kinds. There is the scar: the marks that its capacities have left upon its body. There is the bow: the capacity that only the true hero can use, the door that only it can open. There is the secret of the bed: knowledge that only the true self possesses, the key of the knowledge-gate. And there are the trees of childhood: the landscape of the starting region, revisited at the end and named again. Even Argos has his counterpart. The old dog who has waited twenty years for his master dies at the moment of recognition, and the genre's worlds, which have waited for their hero, characteristically perish once the hero has been recognized — the exodos that Chapter Nine examines.

James Joyce's *Ulysses* (1922) transposed the *nostos* into a single Dublin day, and in its "Ithaca" episode Leopold Bloom, returning home late at night to find that he has forgotten his latchkey, climbs over the railings and drops into the basement area in order to enter his own house. The modern hero comes home

by an unintended route: a sequence break into his own front door. The comedy is affectionate, and it is exact. In modernity, as in the genre, the way home is rarely the way one left.

6.4 *Perceval's Second Visit*

Epistemic Gating and the "Metroidbrainia"

Chrétien de Troyes's *Perceval, or the Story of the Grail*, composed in the 1180s and left unfinished at his death, contains the medieval West's great narrative of a failed first visit. Perceval, raised by his widowed mother in the Waste Forest in ignorance of chivalry, leaves her to become a knight; she falls in a swoon as he rides away, and he learns only later that she died of grief. The nobleman Gornemant instructs him in arms and counsels him, among other things, not to speak too much. At evening Perceval comes to a castle whose lord, wounded and unable to ride, passes his days fishing. At supper a procession crosses the hall: a squire bearing a white lance from whose tip a drop of blood runs down to his hand, and then a maiden bearing a grail of gold and precious stones, so radiant that the candles pale beside it. Mindful of Gornemant's advice, Perceval asks nothing — neither why the lance bleeds nor whom the grail serves. In the morning the castle is deserted and he rides away. A cousin tells him that had he asked, the wounded king would have been healed and his land restored; later a hideous damsel curses him before Arthur's court. Perceval vows never to rest until he has learned the meaning of the grail and the lance, wanders for five years in which he forgets God, and on a Good Friday comes to a hermit, his uncle, who begins to explain. Chrétien's poem breaks off.

Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival*, composed in the first decade of the thirteenth century, completed the story. Its Grail castle, Munsalvæsche, cannot be found by one who seeks it; its Grail is a stone; its wounded king, Anfortas, suffers until the destined questioner comes. Parzival fails at his first visit as Perceval did, wanders for years in bitterness, and returns at last — not by searching but by grace — to ask the question: *œheim, waz wirret dir?*, "Uncle, what ails you?" Anfortas is healed, and Parzival becomes king of the Grail. The question is not a key that fits a lock; it is an act of attention to another's suffering. The castle is opened by compassion, as the underworld of Inanna was opened by the sympathy of Enki's small creatures.

The Grail romance is the archetype of epistemic gating, and its structure has five moments. There is a first visit in which a wonder is seen but not understood: a prolepsis of meaning. There is a failure caused not by weakness but by igno-

rance — the lack not of a weapon but of a question. There is a long wandering in which the hero acquires not strength but understanding. There is a return to the same place with the capacity that was lacking, which is a question. And there is a world healed by the asking. The castle that appears and vanishes and cannot be found by seeking is the knowledge-gated world in its purest form: a place whose gate is an understanding.

Player and critical discourse has coined, informally, the term "metroidbrainia" for exploration games of this kind, in which progress is gated by knowledge rather than by abilities, and its paradigm is *Outer Wilds* (Mobius Digital, 2019), which began as Alex Beachum's master's thesis project at the University of Southern California. The player explores a miniature solar system in a twenty-two-minute time loop that ends, every time, in a supernova. Nothing is gated by items: every location is reachable, in principle, from the first loop. What gates progress is knowledge of the system's laws and rhythms — the sand that pours from one twin planet to its partner, a planet crumbling into the black hole at its core, a moon that moves only when unobserved — and of the writings of the Nomai, a vanished species whose texts the player translates. The ship's log offers a "rumor mode" in which places and clues are displayed as a graph joined by arrows: a map not of space but of knowledge, whose blanks are questions rather than rooms. On the first loop the player sees wonders she cannot understand, as Perceval saw the procession; she returns, loop after loop, with questions; and the final passage requires understanding alone. *Outer Wilds* is the Grail romance as game.

The form has a growing literature of practice. Andrew Shouldice's *Tunic* (2022) scatters through its world the pages of an instruction manual written largely in an invented script, from which the player learns, among much else, that capacities have been available from the first moment of play. Billy Basso's *Animal Well* (2024) nests strata of secrets within one another, the deepest of which appear designed to exceed the solving capacity of any single player and to demand communal decipherment, a phenomenon Chapter Eight examines. Jonathan Blow's *The Witness* (2016) teaches its player to solve line puzzles on panels and then delivers the epiphany that the same patterns are inscribed in the island's landscape, so that the environment itself becomes a text, legible to one who has learned to see it. Lucas Pope's *Return of the Obra Dinn* (2018) sends an insurance investigator aboard a ghost ship with a pocket watch that reveals, at each corpse, the moment of death, from which the fates of the crew must be reconstructed by deduction: a *nekyia* as game, the dead consulted for knowledge. The lineage runs back through the cryptic tablets of *La-Mulana* and the cipher alphabet of *Fez* to the kneeling at Deborah Cliff in *Simon's Quest*, the Holy

Glasses of *Symphony of the Night*, and the magic word on the wall of *Colossal Cave*.

Ursula K. Le Guin's Earthsea supplies the fantasy tradition's theory of the knowledge-gate. In *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), magic rests on knowledge of the true names of things, so that to know a thing's name is to hold power over it. In *The Tombs of Atuan* (1970), the young priestess Arha, whose true name is Tenar, knows the lightless labyrinth beneath the tombs she serves by memory alone, as a sequence of turnings counted in perfect darkness. The wizard Ged enters it and is lost; only her knowledge can lead him out; and as they escape, the tombs collapse behind them in an earthquake — an exodos. The labyrinth is known not by sight but by memory, and knowledge is the thread.

Knowledge-gating is not a departure from the metroidvania but its purification. It transposes metamorphosis from the avatar's body to the player's mind: the avatar does not change; the player does. The final rows of Table 4.1 — illusion, convention, knowledge — become the whole grammar, and the sequence break, which showed that skill can stand in for capacity, proves to have been the halfway point of a movement whose terminus is understanding. Parzival's question adds what the genre's mechanics alone cannot: the knowledge that opens the castle is knowledge of another's suffering. The epistemic key is also an ethical one, and the ethics of return proposed in Chapter Nine begins here, with a question asked at the second visit.

6.5 *The Cave and the Return*

Plato's *Republic* opens with a descent. Its first word, *katebēn*, "I went down," records Socrates' walk down to the Piraeus on the evening of a festival (327a), and readers have long observed that the dialogue thus begins with the movement it will later demand of its philosophers. The allegory of the cave in the seventh book (514a–521b) describes prisoners chained from childhood so that they can see only the wall before them, on which fall the shadows of objects carried along a road behind them in the light of a fire. One prisoner is freed and compelled to turn around, a movement Plato calls *periagōgē*. The light of the fire pains his eyes. He is dragged up the rough and steep ascent into the sunlight, where he is at first dazzled and can make out only shadows and reflections, then the things themselves, then the heavens by night, and at last the sun. And then comes the part of the allegory most often forgotten. He must go back down. "You must go down, each in turn" (*katabateon oun en merei*, 520c), Socrates tells the philosophers of his city, for the one who has seen the light owes a return to the cave. Coming back, his eyes, accustomed to the sun, see badly in the dark; the prisoners laugh at him, and they would kill anyone who tried to free them and lead them up — a glance, unmistakable to Plato's readers, at the death of Socrates.

The allegory contains Plato's theory of education, and that theory is palintropic. Education, Socrates argues (518c–d), is not the putting of sight into blind eyes, as some suppose, but an art of turning-around, a *technē tēs periagōgēs*, which turns the whole soul, as one might turn the whole body to bring the eye from darkness to light, away from becoming and toward being. Learning is a turning back. The metroidvania's palintrope is a *periagōgē* in space: the player, turned around and sent back along her path, sees the familiar otherwise, and the turning is the teaching.

The genre's relation to Plato's topography is ambivalent, and the ambivalence is instructive. Its worlds are caves — the caverns beneath Crateria, the buried kingdom of Hallownest, the Mammoth Cave that lies beneath the genre's own origin — but its truths often lie below rather than above. The deepest place is frequently the place of revelation: the Abyss beneath Hallownest, where the Knight is shown the scene of its own making, or Tourian, at the root of Zebes. Its sunlight, by contrast, is often the place of departure, the dusk of the surface town from which the descent begins. Yet the genre has its ascents too, from the keep at the summit of Dracula's castle to the mountain Ori climbs near the end of its journey, and in the genre, as in Heraclitus, the way up and the way down are one. What the metroidvania honours without ambivalence is Plato's demand

for return. Its endgame sends the transformed hero back through the regions of its weakness, there to see them otherwise. It differs from Plato's philosopher in one respect only: it sees better, not worse, in the dark, because its eyes have been changed by what it has become — by the X-ray scope, the lantern, the visor, the nail that reads the dreams of the dead.

Hans Blumenberg's *Höhlenausgänge* ("Cave Exits," 1989) traced the cave through the whole history of Western thought as a metaphor of origin and shelter: the place of the first images and the first stories, from which the exit is the founding gesture of culture and to which imagination perpetually returns in dream, myth, and theory. Plato's cave is only the most famous of its avatars. The metroidvania is a culture of cave exits endlessly repeated, each world a cave entered, mapped, and left.

The oldest surviving images made by human beings were painted in caves, and often in their deepest recesses. The paintings of Altamira, in northern Spain, were recognized in 1879; Lascaux, in the Dordogne, was discovered in 1940; Chauvet, in the Ardèche, in 1994. Many such images were made in zones reachable only by crawling through narrow passages and descending into darkness. At Lascaux a shaft, the *Puits*, holds the enigmatic scene of a bird-headed man fallen before a wounded bison; at Chauvet, which Werner Herzog filmed in *Cave of Forgotten Dreams* (2010), the animals seem to move as light passes across the folds of the rock, as the painters' torches once did. The earliest art of our species is environmental storytelling of the most literal kind: images left in the dark by vanished makers, found by those who descend. The Chozo murals of *Metroid Prime* and the tablets of Hallownest are its digital descendants, and Chapter Eight returns to them. The genre's descent through narrow passages into painted depths repeats, whether its makers intend it or not, the oldest itinerary of the human imagination.

The cave fixes the genre's pedagogy: education as turning-around, the obligatory return, light and dark exchanged, and shadows reread by eyes that have seen the sun. Plato's claim is that the true philosopher is the one who comes back down. That is the metroidvania's claim about its hero.

6.6 *Jung's House, Freud's Street*

The Psychoanalysis of Backtracking

In 1909, aboard the ship that carried him and Sigmund Freud to the United States, Carl Gustav Jung had a dream that he recounted half a century later in *Memories, Dreams, Reflections* (1962). He was in an unknown house of two storeys which was nevertheless "his house." On the upper floor was a salon furnished in the rococo style, hung with fine old paintings. Descending the stairs, he found the ground floor older and darker, its furnishings medieval. Behind a heavy door a stone stairway led down to a cellar, a beautifully vaulted room of great antiquity, its walls Roman. In its stone floor was a slab with a ring; lifting it, he saw a narrow stairway of stone steps leading further down, and descending it he came to a low cave cut into the rock, thick with dust, in which lay scattered bones and broken pottery, the remains of a primitive culture, and two very old human skulls, half disintegrated. Then he woke. Jung interpreted the house as an image of the psyche: the salon as consciousness; the ground floor as the first level of the unconscious; each lower level darker and more alien; and the cave, at the bottom, as the world of the primitive within, which consciousness can scarcely reach — the stratum he would later call the collective unconscious. The dream marked, in his own account, the beginning of his departure from Freud's conception of the unconscious as personal.

The metroidvania's vertical axis follows Jung's house. *Super Metroid* descends from the storm-swept surface of Crateria through the jungles of Brinstar and the fires of Norfair into ancient ruins and, at the planet's roots, the biomechanical depths of Tourian. *Hollow Knight* descends from the surface town of Dirtmouth through the Forgotten Crossroads and the rain-drowned City of Tears to the Ancient Basin and the Abyss beneath it, where, amid the shells of countless failed siblings, the Knight is shown the scene of its own making. *Symphony of the Night* descends from galleries and libraries to catacombs and flooded caverns. The genre's descent is a descent through the strata of a psyche, and it ends, as Jung's dream ends, in a primal scene of origin among remains. Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* organized the psychology of the house along the same vertical axis, opposing the attic, the zone of rationality where fears are easily dispelled, to the cellar, the dark entity of the house that partakes of subterranean forces. Bachelard cited Jung's image of consciousness as a man who, hearing a suspicious noise in the cellar, hurries up to the attic, finds no burglars there, and concludes that the noise was imaginary — never having dared to go down into the cellar. The metroidvania's hero is the one who goes down.

Among Jung's archetypes, the one the genre has most thoroughly mechanized is the shadow: the unacknowledged and rejected aspects of the personality, frequently encountered in dreams and myths as a dark double, whose recognition and integration Jung regarded as the first task of individuation. When *Hollow Knight*'s Knight dies, it leaves at the place of its death a dark shade of itself, which holds the wealth the Knight was carrying and part of its capacity for soul; to recover them, the player must return to the place of death and defeat her own shadow. The mechanic is a ritual of individuation conducted by return: the self goes back to the place where it fell, confronts the double it left there, and reintegrates it. *Metroid Fusion*'s SA-X is Samus's own armour — her persona, in Jung's vocabulary, the mask by which the self presents itself to the world — possessed by the parasite and turned against her; *Metroid Prime 2: Echoes* (2004) gives her a dark double born of corruption and of her own armour's data; *Symphony of the Night* sets Alucard against doppelgängers that mimic his every capacity; and *Axiom Verge*'s antagonist is another Trace. The genre's antagonists are with remarkable frequency its heroes' shadows, and its victories are reintegrations.

Sigmund Freud's essay "The Uncanny" (1919) defined its subject as that class of the frightening which leads back to what is known of old and long familiar. Freud's analysis of the German *heimlich* found that the word, meaning homely and familiar, also meant concealed and kept out of sight, so that its apparent opposite, *unheimlich*, names what ought to have remained secret and hidden but has come to light — a definition Freud took from Schelling. Among his examples is an episode from his own life. Walking one hot afternoon through the deserted streets of a provincial Italian town, he found himself in a quarter whose character could not long remain in doubt, for painted women were to be seen at its windows. He hastened away at the next turning, only to find himself, after wandering for a time, back in the same street; he hurried away again and arrived there a third time by another detour, and was overcome by a feeling he could only call uncanny. Involuntary return to the same place is uncanny. The metroidvania domesticates this uncanny: its returns are voluntary and meaningful, the street revisited because one has reason to revisit it. Yet the genre preserves the uncanny's structure in its doubles, in its haunted familiar spaces, and above all in the inverted castle examined below, in which the familiar house returns estranged and the hidden comes to light.

In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud described a game invented by his eighteen-month-old grandson. The child would throw a wooden reel tied to a piece of string over the edge of his curtained cot, so that it disappeared, uttering a long "o-o-o-o" that the family understood as *fort*, "gone"; then he would pull

it back by the string and hail its reappearance with a joyful *da*, "there." Freud read the game as the child's mastery of his mother's absences, achieved by staging disappearance and return himself and so converting a suffered passivity into an exercised activity, and he made it a starting point for his theory of the compulsion to repeat. The metroidvania is a *fort/da*: departure and return, the loss and recovery of capacities, the mastery of absence by its staging. And the reel on its string is Ariadne's thread, the line that makes return possible. In the same work Freud described the course of life itself as a series of ever more complicated detours on the way back to an earlier state, the inanimate — a palintropic drive whose aim is return — and Chapter Nine will take up this darker reading in considering the genre's characteristic ending.

Marcel Proust's *In Search of Lost Time*, whose theory of involuntary memory began with a madeleine dipped in tea, ends with a recognition triggered by the body. In *Time Regained* (1927), arriving at a reception, the narrator stumbles on uneven paving stones in a courtyard, and the bodily sensation summons the uneven flagstones of the baptistery of St Mark's in Venice, and with them a joy that tells him what his vocation is: the book he has been unknowingly preparing all his life. The metroidvania's returns trigger involuntary memory in Proust's manner. The music of a revisited region, the shape of a room, the motion of the body through a familiar shaft summon the first visit entire. Proust's novel ends with the recognition that the long detour of a life was the preparation of a work; the metroidvania ends with the recognition that the long detour of play was the preparation of a self.

6.7 *Peripeteia of Space*

The Inverted Castle

Aristotle's *Poetics* (chapter 11) defines two parts of the complex plot. *Peripeteia*, reversal, is a change of the action to its opposite — as when, in Sophocles' *Oedipus*, the messenger who comes to cheer Oedipus and free him from his fear concerning his mother produces, by revealing who Oedipus is, the opposite effect. *Anagnorisis*, recognition, is a change from ignorance to knowledge. The finest recognition, Aristotle holds, is the one that occurs together with a reversal, as in the *Oedipus*. The metroidvania has produced a reversal Aristotle could not have imagined: a reversal not of fortune but of the world's orientation, a peripeteia of space.

Its canonical instance is the inverted castle of *Symphony of the Night*. When Alucard, wearing the Holy Glasses, perceives the orb by which the dark priest Shaft controls Richter Belmont, and destroys it rather than its victim, a second castle is revealed: the first, rotated through a half-turn, so that up and down, left and right, are exchanged. Ceilings become floors. The chandeliers of its galleries stand on the ground like strange candelabra. The familiar rooms must be traversed in reverse, their former floors often reachable only in the form of a bat, and their inhabitants are newer and deadlier than before. Within this inverted world Alucard gathers the five relics of his father's body, and at its summit — which was the first castle's depth — he meets Shaft and, at last, the resurrected Dracula. The world turns over at precisely the moment at which the hero sees the truth. Peripeteia coincides with anagnorisis in Aristotle's finest mode.

The inverted castle is the point at which nearly every line of this study's argument converges. It is Heraclitus's identity of the way up and the way down, realized as level design: the ascent of the first castle becomes, room for room, the descent of the second. It is Escher's *Relativity* lived at the scale of a world, and Carroll's looking-glass house, in which everything is the other way about. It is Freud's uncanny in its exact definition, the familiar house returned estranged and the hidden second castle come to light. It is the son's traversal of the paternal house forward and in reverse, by a hero whose name is his father's read backward. It is Plato's *periagōgē*, the turning-around of the soul enacted as a turning-over of the world. It recalls the scrawled word in Kubrick's *The Shining* that becomes legible, as "MURDER," only when read in a mirror: reversal as revelation. And it is a *fort/da* of the whole world, which disappears in one orientation and returns in another.

The inverted castle has a sublime antecedent in the last canto of Dante's *Inferno*, the culmination of the katabasis whose lineage this chapter has traced

from Inanna through Virgil. At the bottom of Hell, Dante's guide — Virgil, the poet of the golden bough — carries him down the shaggy flank of Lucifer, frozen in the ice of Cocytus. At the point where the thigh turns upon the swell of the hip, Virgil laboriously brings his head round to where his feet had been and begins to climb, so that Dante, looking back, sees Lucifer's legs held upward and believes for a moment that they are returning into Hell. Virgil explains that they have passed the point toward which all weights are drawn from every side, the centre of the earth, and now stand beneath the opposite hemisphere; and by a hidden path beside a murmuring stream they climb until, through a round opening, they come out to see the stars again: *e quindi uscimmo a riveder le stelle* (XXXIV.139). Dante's descent to the deepest point becomes, without any turning back, an ascent. The way down and the way up are one, and the reversal is accomplished by passing through the centre. The *Commedia* thus anticipates in a single movement both the genre's peripeteia of space and its exodos into the starfield, and its whole design — a cosmos of regions, each governed by its own law, traversed under the guidance of a mentor from the dark wood of the first canto to the stars on which each of its three parts closes — makes it the great medieval antecedent of the palintropic world.

Viktor Shklovsky's essay "Art as Device" (1917) supplies the concept that explains its peculiar power. Habitualization, Shklovsky argued, devours works, clothes, furniture, one's wife, and the fear of war; perception becomes automatic, and things are recognized without being seen. Art exists to restore the sensation of life, to make the stone stony, and it does so by *ostranenie*, estrangement or defamiliarization: by making forms difficult and prolonging perception, as Tolstoy, Shklovsky's chief example, describes a flogging as though it had never been seen before. The metroidvania's pedagogy of habit, analysed in Chapter Five, automatizes its world. By the time a player has crossed Dracula's castle many times, its rooms have become transparent, traversed without being perceived. The inverted castle is *ostranenie* at the scale of a world. It restores the castle's strangeness by inverting it, makes perception difficult and prolonged again, and makes the castle, in Shklovsky's phrase, castle-like once more. It is the genre's answer to the automatization produced by its own pedagogy.

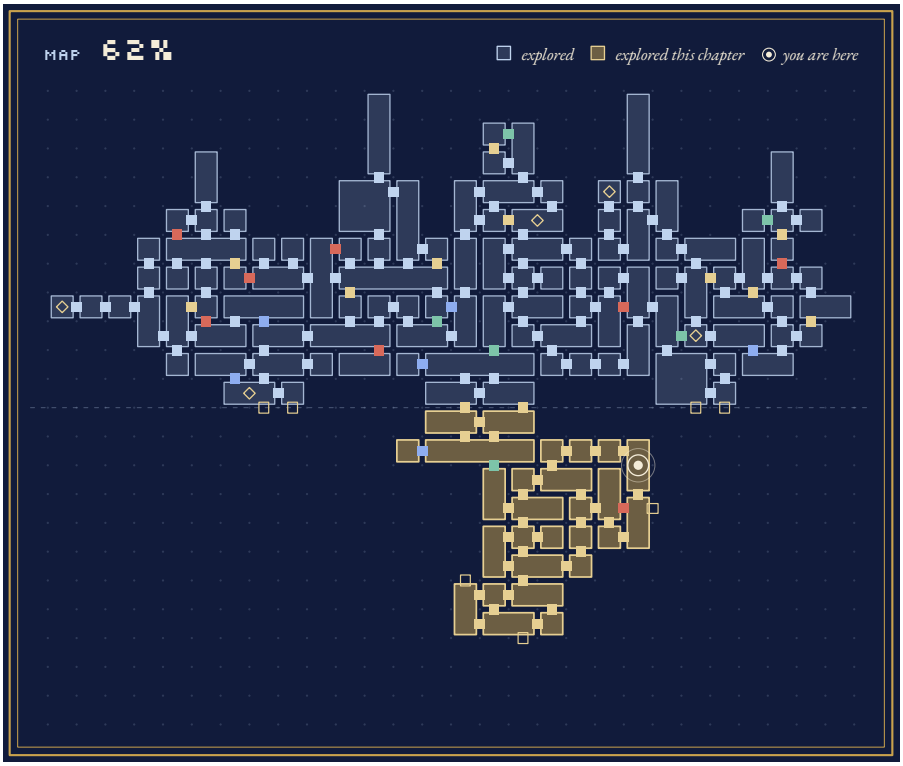
The genre has developed the doubled world into a recurrent device. Nintendo's *The Legend of Zelda: A Link to the Past* (1991) set a Light World and a Dark World of corresponding geography side by side, so that passage between them transformed each into a key to the other. *Castlevania: Harmony of Dissonance* superimposed two versions of its castle. *Metroid Prime 2: Echoes* divided its planet into a light and a dark dimension. *Axiom Verge 2* (2021) folded a digital realm, the Breach, through its physical world. *Fez*, as Chapter Four noted,

rotated its world through four views. In each case the doubled world makes the latter part of play a re-reading of the former, so that the second traversal interprets the first.

The inverted castle is, in this sense, the hermeneutic circle's second pass made visible: the whole re-read in the light of what has been learned, every part encountered again and understood otherwise. It is the genre's supreme anagnorisis, the recognition not of a room but of a world. And it was a secret. Concealed behind an obscure ritual involving two rings and a pair of spectacles, the second half of *Symphony of the Night* remained unknown to many who played it, so that the largest recognition in the genre was also its largest concealment. Recognition passes here into unconcealment, and the argument passes with it into its final movement: from anagnorisis to aletheia, from the return that recognizes to the veil that is lifted.

STASIMON

VI



The grammar of return has been assembled from its oldest sources. Inanna's descent through seven gates, read backward, proved to be the shape of the genre itself: divestiture and investiture as one path walked in two directions, the me *as the constituents of a self restored gate by gate, the underworld opened by the sympathy of creatures small enough to pass unseen, and no return without a substitute. Virgil's Sibyl declared the descent easy and the return the labour, and her golden bough displayed every property of the genre's key items, from the glint through dark branches to its refusal of every hand but the fated one; Frazer's guarded tree named the succession by which the slayer of the guardian becomes the guardian; and the gate of ivory left open the question of which side of the exit is the dream. The* Odyssey *supplied the descent for knowledge and a whole poetics of recognition — the scar, the bow strung like a lyre, the bed rooted in a living tree, the trees of childhood — while Joyce's Bloom came home by an unintended route. Perceval's failed first visit and Parzival's question made knowledge, and compassion, the key to the Grail castle, and showed the knowledge-gated games to be the genre purified,* Outer Wilds *the Grail romance as game, Le Guin's labyrinth*

a thread of memory. Plato's cave made education a turning-around and the return to the dark an obligation. Jung's house and Bachelard's cellar mapped the genre's descent onto the strata of a psyche; the shadow was confronted and reintegrated at the place of death; Freud's involuntary street, his grandson's reel, and Proust's uneven flagstones disclosed the uncanny, the mastery, and the involuntary memory that return can bring. And the inverted castle joined reversal and recognition in Aristotle's finest mode, estranging a world made transparent by habit so that it could be seen again.

The return recognizes. But what, finally, does recognition disclose? The genre's answer, in its most exalted moments, takes the form of a secret — the largest of them hidden, like the inverted castle, behind the obscurest of rituals — and the secret, when the veil is lifted, proves to be the one who lifted it. The next chapter lifts the veil.

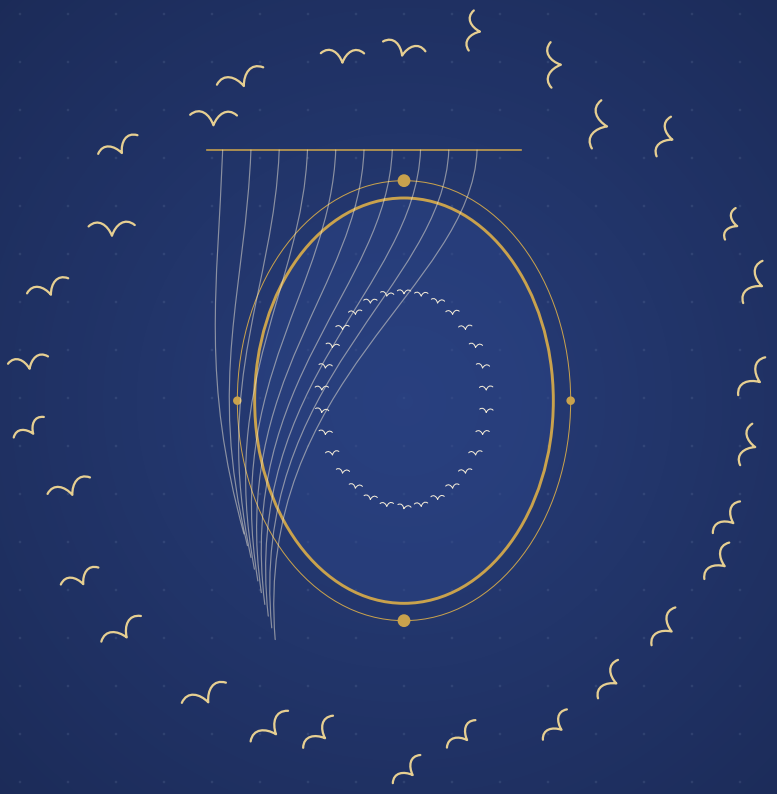
CHAPTER SEVEN

ζ'

Aletheia

ἀλήθεια

The Veil of Isis



φύσις κρύπτεσθαι φιλεῖ.

Nature loves to hide.

— Heraclitus, fragment B123 (Diels–Kranz)

ἐγώ εἰμι πᾶν τὸ γεγονὸς καὶ ὂν καὶ ἐσόμενον, καὶ τὸν ἐμὸν πέπλον οὐδείς πω θνητὸς ἀπεκάλυψεν.

I am all that has been, and is, and shall be, and no mortal has yet lifted my robe.

— Inscription at Sais, as reported by Plutarch, *On Isis and Osiris* 9

7.1 Phusis Kruptesthai Philei

The three words of Heraclitus that serve as this chapter's first epigraph, preserved by later writers among whom the fourth-century orator Themistius is the most often cited, have been translated in more ways than almost any other sentence of Greek philosophy. *Phusis*, from the verb *phuō*, to grow or come forth, meant before it meant "nature" the process of growth, the coming-to-be of a thing, or its inner constitution. *Kruptesthai* may be middle or passive, to hide oneself or to be hidden. *Philei* means "loves to," but also "tends to," "is wont to." Pierre Hadot's *The Veil of Isis* (2004) traced the fragment's career across two and a half millennia. For Heraclitus himself, Hadot proposed, it probably meant something like this: that which causes things to appear tends also to make them disappear, so that birth and death are a single process and every coming-forth carries its own withdrawal. The Hellenistic and late-antique traditions personified *phusis* as a goddess who conceals her secrets from mortal eyes; the scientific revolution set out to unveil her; and Romanticism mourned or celebrated the unveiling. Heidegger heard in the fragment the essential belonging-together of emergence and concealment: *phusis* is the self-emerging that loves to conceal itself, and *alētheia*, unconcealment, harbours *lēthē*, concealment, at its very heart, so that every disclosure is also a sheltering of what remains undisclosed — as the clearing, Chapter Four observed, is ringed by forest.

The metroidvania's world is *phusis* in both of these senses. Its things hide: false walls, breakable floors, rooms behind rooms, passages concealed in ceilings. And its disclosures produce concealments. Every room revealed discloses, in its turn, a new hiddenness — a ledge glimpsed from it, a door seen beyond it, a wall that sounds hollow when struck — just as, in Husserl's analysis, every fulfilled intention opens new horizons. The unconcealment of the world proceeds through the generation of new veils, and the process ends only at the limit at which everything has been disclosed and the world itself, as Chapter Nine will show, characteristically ends. The genre is Heidegger's *alētheia* rendered as a ludic economy: disclosure as the engine of concealment, and concealment as the reserve from which disclosure draws.

The breakable wall is the genre's ontology of the surface. In *Metroid*, certain blocks shatter under beam or bomb and reveal passages behind them; *Super Metroid* grants an X-Ray Scope that discloses the hidden constitution of walls; the first *Castlevania* conceals in its masonry joints of roast meat that restore the strength of whoever whips the right stone, so that the wall feeds the one who strikes it; *Hollow Knight* hides whole regions behind walls, floors, and ceilings

that yield to the nail. Every surface in such a world is potentially a veil, and the player learns to strike, bomb, and probe every wall in a discipline of suspicion directed at architecture. Paul Ricoeur, in *Freud and Philosophy* (1965), named Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud the "masters of suspicion," interpreters who read manifest meaning as the disguise of a latent one, and he set against their hermeneutics of suspicion a hermeneutics of faith or restoration, which trusts meaning to address us. The metroidvania demands both at once. It requires suspicion of every surface, since any wall may be false, and faith in the world's meaningfulness, since the contract of deferral guarantees that what is hidden is hidden in order to be found. The genre's player is a master of suspicion who believes.

The vocabulary of hiding confirms what the genre's structures suggest. The Latin *secretum* derives from *secernere*, to sift or set apart: the secret is what has been separated out. The crypt takes its name from the Greek *kruptē*, a vault, cognate with Heraclitus's *kruptesthai*, so that the genre's crypts and catacombs are, etymologically, its hiding-places. And *apokalypsis*, apocalypse, is an uncovering, from *kaluptein*, to cover — the root of the name of Kalypsō, "she who conceals," the nymph who kept Odysseus hidden on her island for seven years. The genre's endings are apocalyptic in the strict sense of the word: unveilings. That they are so often also destructions is a coincidence of senses this study will not regard as accidental.

7.2 *Promethean and Orphic Disclosure*

Hadot organized the history of humanity's relation to nature's secrets around two attitudes, which he named for two figures of Greek myth. The *Promethean* attitude, named for the Titan who stole fire from the gods for mortals, seeks to tear nature's secrets from her by technique, experiment, and force. Its genealogy runs through ancient mechanics, which the Aristotelian *Mechanical Problems* defined as the art of producing, by contrivance (*mēchanē*), effects contrary to nature for human benefit; through magic; and through the experimental method of the early modern period, whose program Francis Bacon articulated in calling, in his *Parasceve* (1620), for the study of nature "under constraint and vexed," forced by art and the hand of man out of her natural state — a juridical image of nature as a defendant under interrogation. The *Orphic* attitude, named for the poet whose song moved stones and beasts and the powers of the underworld, approaches nature's secret instead through contemplation, poetry, and art: through attention, imitation, and the discipline of perception. Its modern exemplar is Goethe, whose morphology distrusted instruments that interpose between the observer and the phenomenon, who held that nature falls silent under torture (*Die Natur verstummt auf der Folter*), and who spoke of nature's "open secret" (*offenbares Geheimnis*): a secret manifest to anyone who has learned how to look. Hadot's sympathies were Orphic.

The metroidvania's equipment divides along Hadot's line. Its Promethean instruments are explosive: bombs, missiles, super missiles, power bombs that blast open whole rooms, beam weapons of escalating force. Samus's arsenal, technology bequeathed by the vanished Chozo, is Promethean fire, and its characteristic act is the interrogation of walls by detonation. *Metroid Prime*'s scan visor, which extracts data from every creature and object and files it in a logbook, is Promethean too in its taxonomic mastery, though it requires a patience that is not. The genre's Orphic instruments are instruments of perception and of song. The lantern lets darkness be seen as darkness. The Holy Glasses of *Symphony of the Night* do not break the wall of illusion but see through it, disclosing the orb that force alone could never find. *Hollow Knight*'s Dream Nail is Orphic in the strictest sense: with it the Knight enters dreams, hears the dead and the sleeping speak in their own voices, and opens at last the passage to the dream in which the kingdom's forgotten god is confronted. And song itself becomes a key. In Bit Blot's *Aquaria* (2007), the heroine Naija sings verses that transform her into forms capable of passages her ordinary body cannot make; Nintendo's *The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time* (1998) opens doors and summons powers with melodies; *Animal Well* gives its player a flute whose songs answer the

world; *Blasphemous* makes its prayers, spoken verses, into powers. Orpheus's song opened the gates of Hades, and the genre has never forgotten that a gate may yield to music.

The Orphic tradition has left a remarkable material witness to the knowledge-gate. In graves of southern Italy, Thessaly, and Crete, archaeologists have found small leaves of gold, the earliest of them from around 400 BCE, inscribed with instructions for the journey of the soul through the underworld. The soul is told the way: it will find a spring beside a white cypress, from which it must not drink — the spring, scholars agree, of forgetting — and further on the lake of Memory, Mnemosyne, before which guardians stand. And it is given the words it must speak to them, which may be rendered from the tablet found at Petelia: *I am a child of Earth and starry Heaven, but my race is of heaven; I am parched with thirst and perishing; give me quickly the cold water flowing from the lake of Memory.* The Orphic gold tablets are the earliest walkthroughs. They chart the underworld's turnings, warn against the wrong water, and supply the password that opens the gate. Their governing opposition — the spring of forgetting against the lake of memory — is the opposition contained in the word *alētheia* itself, which Chapter One read as un-forgetting. Orphic disclosure is mnemonic: the soul is saved by remembering. The knowledge-gates examined in Chapter Six are Orphic in exactly this sense. They cannot be bombed open; they open to the one who remembers the word.

The Orphic tradition is also founded on a forbidden return. In the fourth book of Virgil's *Georgics* and the tenth of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Orpheus wins from the powers of the underworld the right to lead Eurydice back to the light, on condition that he not look back at her until they have reached the upper air; at the threshold he turns, and loses her forever. The founding tragedy of the Orphic tradition is a prohibited backward glance, an anti-palintrope in which return destroys what it would recover. The metroidvania reverses Orpheus. Its backward look is obligatory and redemptive, its returns the very means of recovery. Yet it preserves Orpheus's lesson in one place: the escape sequence, in which the collapsing world forbids the player to turn back, and in which the backward look survives only as the gesture of rescue that Chapter Five found in the margins of *Super Metroid*'s exodus.

The genre's history shows a drift from the Promethean toward the Orphic — from the bombs of *Metroid* (1986) to the Holy Glasses of *Symphony of the Night* (1997), from the scan visor of *Metroid Prime* (2002) to the Dream Nail of *Hollow Knight* (2017), and finally to the pure understanding of *Outer Wilds* (2019) and the manual pages of *Tunic* (2022), in which the knowledge-gated works complete the Orphic purification of the form. Yet the canonical works hold the two

attitudes in tension, as Samus carries both power bombs and visor. The tension has an ethical dimension. Promethean disclosure aligns with the extractive unveiling that Chapter Five criticized in the genre's imperial imaginary, and with what Heidegger called enframing; Orphic disclosure aligns with attentiveness, with the bringing-forth Heidegger called *poiēsis*, and with the compassion of Parzival's question. Goethe's maxim names what the knowledge-gate enforces: some secrets cannot be forced and yield only to attention. The genre's deepest secrets are Orphic.

7.3 *The Easter Egg and the Second World*

Warren Robinett's hidden room, examined in Chapter Two, was a signature concealed because it was forbidden: Atari did not credit its programmers, and so the maker signed his world in its walls. The first celebrated secret of the digital labyrinth was thus an assertion of authorship, and the name the industry gave such secrets carries its own mythology. Easter eggs are decorated and hidden for children to find, and the egg is an ancient emblem of resurrection, of life sealed within an apparent tomb. Older still is the Orphic cosmogony, in which Time fashioned a silvery egg from which burst Phanes, golden-winged and double-sexed, the first-born of the gods, whose name derives from *phainein*, to bring to light. In the Orphic myth the egg is the primal secret from which appearance itself hatches. *Animal Well* has made eggs its secrets in the most literal sense, hiding sixty-four of them throughout its subterranean world as the first of several strata of concealment that lie beneath its manifest game.

The sociologist Georg Simmel devoted one of the most penetrating chapters of his *Soziologie* (1908), published in English two years earlier as "The Sociology of Secrecy and of Secret Societies," to the secret as a form of social life. Secrecy, Simmel argued, is one of humanity's greatest achievements, an advance over the childlike condition in which every idea is immediately expressed. The secret offers "the possibility of a second world alongside the manifest world," and the manifest world is decisively shaped by that second one. Its peculiar attraction lies in a tension: the secret is surrounded by the possibility and the temptation of betrayal, and its value is heightened by the knowledge that it could be revealed. It divides insiders from outsiders, and its institutional form is the secret society.

Simmel's phrase describes the genre's architecture with literal precision. The inverted castle of *Symphony of the Night* is a second world alongside the manifest one, unknown to many who completed the first. Daisuke Amaya's *Cave Story* conceals a final region, its Sacred Grounds, reachable only by players who

have fulfilled an unannounced chain of conditions on the way to the best ending. *Hollow Knight* hides behind its manifest kingdom a palace reachable only through a dream, gauntlets within that palace, and a further realm of trials beyond. *La-Mulana* layers its ruins with puzzles that most players never perceive, and *Animal Well* stacks its strata so deep that the last of them seem addressed to a community rather than to any single player. And that community is itself a secret society in Simmel's sense. Its forums, wikis, and video essays constitute a body of initiates divided from outsiders by what they know, and its etiquette of the "spoiler" — the warnings, the concealed text, the tacit prohibition on revealing what others have not yet found — institutionalizes the tension of betrayal that Simmel located at the heart of every secret.

Frank Kermode's *The Genesis of Secrecy* (1979) argued that narratives possess secrets that invite interpretation and divide insiders from outsiders, and he took as his paradigm the Gospel of Mark, in which Jesus tells his disciples that to them has been given the secret of the kingdom, while to those outside everything comes in parables. Kermode dwelt on one of Mark's most enigmatic details, the young man in a linen cloth who follows Jesus at his arrest and, seized, flees naked, leaving the cloth behind: a figure of the narrative's radiant obscurity, which interpreters have laboured for two thousand years to explain. The genre's secret regions convert their players into exegetes of exactly this kind. The communities that reconstruct the history of Hallownest from scattered inscriptions, the dying words of its inhabitants, and the arrangement of its ruins practise Kermode's hermeneutics, and their disagreements reproduce the structure of the outsider's labour before a text that withholds its centre.

Jacques Derrida's essay "Passions" (1993) turned on a phrase — *il y a là du secret*, there is something secret there — and distinguished from the secret as a hidden content, which can be revealed, an absolute secret that consists in no hidden content at all and remains even when everything has been said: the secret of singularity, which literature keeps, Derrida suggested, without ever touching it. In *The Gift of Death* (1992) he tied responsibility itself to such a secret, reading Abraham's silence on the way to Moriah. The genre knows both kinds. There is the content secret — the item behind the wall, revealed and exhausted, recorded as a fraction of a percentage — and there is the absolute secret, which remains at one hundred per cent: the singular passage of this player through this world, which no wiki records and no percentage measures. Every walkthrough lists the content secrets. None contains the absolute one.

The genre's secrets have, finally, a social life that exceeds the works that contain them. The original *Metroid* accepted a password, JUSTIN BAILEY, that began a game with Samus out of her armour, and the coincidental string gen-

erated a folklore about who Justin Bailey might have been; the game's debug password, NARPAS SWORD, circulated as a talisman; and the playgrounds of the 1980s and 1990s teemed with rumours of secret items and hidden worlds, some true and many invented. The secret generates legend, legend generates search, and search generates new secrets. The culture of the metroidvania is a Simmelian second world of its own, alongside the manifest world of its games.

7.4 *"A Miserable Little Pile of Secrets"*

Malraux, Dracula, and the Secret Self

The prologue of *Symphony of the Night* replays the final confrontation of *Rondo of Blood*. Richter Belmont stands before Dracula's throne and condemns the vampire; Dracula replies that he was summoned by humans who wished to pay him tribute; Richter retorts that the vampire enslaves men's souls; and Dracula, in the game's 1997 English localization, answers with a question and its answer: "What is a man? A miserable little pile of secrets." Then he rises to fight. The theatrical diction of the exchange made it one of the most widely circulated pieces of dialogue in the history of the medium, quoted, parodied, and remixed for decades. Chapter One took its central sentence as an epigraph. Its genealogy, and the genre's relation to that genealogy, now come into view.

Dracula's line paraphrases the opening pages of André Malraux's *Antimémoires* (1967), the first volume of what Malraux called anti-memoirs. Malraux began by refusing the confessional self that autobiography conventionally exposes. Why should what matters only to oneself matter at all? Man, he wrote, is essentially what he hides: *un misérable petit tas de secrets*. His point was dismissive. The secrets of the individual — the material of confession and of psychoanalysis — seemed to him trivial beside the human being's confrontation with history, with death, and with destiny; he wrote anti-memoirs precisely because the pile of secrets was not worth recounting. Dracula turns Malraux's dismissal into contempt for the species: man is defined by his hidden shames, and the vampire, who conceals nothing of his monstrosity, despises him for it.

The genre accepts the diagnosis and reverses both evaluations. Man is what he hides — and what he hides is not miserable but marvellous. The castle in which Dracula speaks is itself a pile of secrets, a structure of false walls, hidden chambers, and a second castle concealed behind the first, and the castle is Dracula's in a deeper than proprietary sense: it is the house as the image of its master's psyche, in the manner of Jung's dream. To explore it is to uncover the secrets of its master, and, as the son proceeds, the secrets of the son — his mother's death,

his father's grief, the blood he carries in his veins. The argument of this study has established two equations: that the world of an embodied subject is the correlate of its capacities, and that the house the genre explores is the image of a psyche. Together they imply a third. The secrets of the world are the secrets of the self. The miserable little pile of secrets is the map.

Freud provided the image of the psyche that the genre's ruins realize. In *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) he asked his reader to imagine Rome as a psychical entity in which nothing once formed had perished, so that all its earlier phases of development coexisted with the latest — the palaces of the Caesars standing on the Palatine beside the buildings that replaced them — and conceded that the image fails even as it conveys the mind's preservation of its past. In "Constructions in Analysis" (1937) he compared the analyst to an archaeologist reconstructing a destroyed dwelling from its remains, with the advantage that the psychical object is never wholly destroyed. The metroidvania's ruins are Freud's Rome made walkable: pasts that coexist in a single space, stratified and reconstructible from fragments by one who descends through them.

Hollow Knight plots the most literal return of the repressed in the genre. Its kingdom of Hallownest was founded upon a forgetting. When the Pale King came, his light eclipsed the worship of an older god, the Radiance, deity of the moths, until she was forgotten by all but a few. The forgotten god returned through the only door left open to her, the dreams of the kingdom's inhabitants, and spread among them as an infection that consumed their minds. The king's remedy was to fashion a vessel, empty of mind and will, in which to seal her; and the secret of that remedy — vessels made in multitudes and cast into the Abyss, the one chosen to contain the god found flawed — is the kingdom's buried crime. Freud's account of the return of the repressed could hardly be more faithfully dramatized: a forgotten god returns through dreams as a sickness, and the explorer's task is to descend through the strata of a kingdom's forgetting to the secret at its origin. That origin, Chapter Six showed, is the explorer's own. Hallownest's secrets are its founding repressions, and the Knight, a vessel from the Abyss, is one of them.

The genre returns repeatedly to the self that is what it hides. In *Metroid Fusion*, the station computer that has guided Samus throughout is revealed to carry the mind of her dead former commander, so that the voice of authority proves to be a buried intimacy. In *Blasphemous*, the Penitent One leaves at the place of each death a fragment of guilt that must be sought out and absolved, so that the hidden self takes the form of a guilt left behind and recovered. In *Axiom Verge*, the scientist discovers that the antagonist he has hunted is another version

of himself. Again and again, the genre's narratives are narratives in which the self is constituted by what it conceals, and in which the concealed is found.

Malraux judged the pile of secrets miserable and turned away from it toward history and fate. The metroidvania turns toward it and finds there the hero's inheritance. And it suggests, as the next sections argue, that when the last veil of the world is lifted, what lies behind it is not an object, a relic, or a treasure, but this self — the one who has been lifting veils all along.

7.5 *Sais*

Schiller, Novalis, and the Unveiled Self

Plutarch's treatise *On Isis and Osiris* reports, in its ninth chapter, the inscription that serves as this chapter's second epigraph: at Sais, in the Nile Delta, the seated statue of Athena, whom the Egyptians called Isis, declared itself all that has been, and is, and shall be, and announced that no mortal had yet lifted its robe. The Neoplatonist Proclus, commenting on Plato's *Timaeus*, knew a fuller version that ended: the fruit I brought forth was the sun. The same treatise of Plutarch tells the myth of Osiris. Murdered by his brother Seth, the god's body was cut into fourteen pieces and scattered across Egypt; Isis searched the land and found every piece but one, which had been devoured by fish, fashioned a likeness to replace it, and celebrated rites for each piece where she found it, which is why so many places in Egypt claimed the tomb of Osiris. Chapter One promised to return to this myth. The relic-hunt of *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest*, in which the hero gathers the scattered rib, heart, eye, nail, and ring of Dracula, and its inverted repetition in *Symphony of the Night* are Isiac quests: the gathering of a scattered divine body by one who travels the land. And Isis is at once the veiled goddess of secrets and the gatherer of the scattered body. She unites in a single figure the genre's two fundamental operations, concealment and reassembly.

The veiled goddess became, in the eighteenth century, the emblem of nature's sublime secret. Kant, in a note to the forty-ninth section of the *Critique of Judgment* (1790), wrote that perhaps nothing more sublime had ever been said, nor any thought more sublimely expressed, than the inscription over the temple of Isis, Mother Nature — I am all that is, that was, and that will be, and no mortal has lifted my veil — and he praised the physicist Segner for placing it as a vignette before his natural philosophy, to fill the student with sacred awe. Beethoven kept a copy of the inscription, in the form Schiller had given it in his essay "The Mission of Moses" (1790), framed beneath glass on his writing desk. Hadot devoted much of *The Veil of Isis* to this afterlife, in which the goddess's robe

became a veil and the veil a figure for the boundary between human knowledge and the hidden truth of the whole.

Friedrich Schiller's ballad "The Veiled Image at Sais" (1795) gave the figure its tragic form. A youth, driven by a thirst for knowledge, comes to Sais to learn the secret wisdom of its priests. The hierophant shows him a colossal veiled image: behind the veil is Truth, and a law of the deity forbids any mortal to lift it until she herself raises it; whoever lifts it with unconsecrated and guilty hand will see the truth. At night the youth enters the temple and lifts the veil. In the morning the priests find him pale and senseless at the statue's foot. What he saw he never told; the joy of his life was gone forever; an early grave received him; and his last warning was a couplet: *Weh dem, der zu der Wahrheit geht durch Schuld, / Sie wird ihm nimmermehr erfreulich sein* — woe to him who comes to truth through guilt, for it will never bring him joy. Schiller's unveiling is Promethean and punitive, the forbidden chamber of Bluebeard and the lamp of Psyche raised to the level of metaphysics: the transgressive disclosure destroys the one who achieves it.

Novalis — Friedrich von Hardenberg, who died in 1801 at the age of twenty-eight — answered Schiller in a fragmentary novel, *The Novices of Sais* (*Die Lehrlinge zu Sais*), written in 1798–99 and published posthumously in 1802. Its first sentence might stand as the motto of this dissertation: *Mannigfache Wege gehen die Menschen* — manifold are the ways that human beings go. Whoever follows and compares them, Novalis continues, will see wondrous figures arise, figures that seem to belong to that great cipher-script which one finds everywhere: on wings, on eggshells, in clouds, in snow, in crystals and in the forms of stone, on freezing waters, in the interior and exterior of mountains, of plants, of animals, of human beings. The genre has populated its worlds with Novalisian ciphers — the glyphs of the Chozo, the invented alphabet of *Fez*, the script of *Tunic*'s manual, the tablets of *La-Mulana* — inscriptions in the world awaiting the novice who can read them. At the novel's centre stands a tale. Hyacinth, who loves the girl Rosebud, falls under the spell of a book left by a stranger and departs to seek the Mother of Things, the veiled Virgin. He wanders through deserts and forests and at last reaches her temple, where he falls asleep and in a dream is led into the sanctuary; he lifts the light, gleaming veil — and Rosebud sinks into his arms. What he sought at the end of the world was what he had left at home. Among the fragments associated with the novel, Novalis set down a distich that compresses the whole into a single turn:

> *Einem gelang es — er hob den Schleier der Göttin zu Sais — / Aber was sah er? Er sah — Wunder des Wunders — sich selbst.*

One succeeded — he lifted the veil of the goddess at Sais. But what did he see? He saw — wonder of wonders — himself.

Novalis offers two forms of the unveiling, and both are anti-Schillerian. Behind the veil lies either the beloved one left behind — the origin, home, the beginning found again at the end — or oneself. These are precisely the two forms the metroidvania's final unveilings take. There is the return to origin: Bloch's *Heimat*, the Knight's birthplace in the Abyss, Samus's discovery of her kinship with the birds whose ruins she has plundered, Alucard's passage through his father's house toward the memory of his mother. And there is the disclosure of the self: Samus beneath her helmet at the end of her first adventure, Samus become the Metroid she was sent to destroy, Soma Cruz become Dracula, Trace confronting Trace. The genre's Isis has the explorer's face. And because the genre's explorer reaches the veil only by the long palintropic journey, the self it discloses is not a self that was simply there, waiting behind the robe. It is the self the journey has made.

This distinguishes the genre's reflexive secret from the self-recognition that destroys. Ovid's Narcissus, gazing into the pool, recognizes at last that the beloved image is his own — *iste ego sum*, "I am he" — and wastes away beside the water, captive to an identity that has no history and no road. Novalis's novice and Hyacinth arrive at themselves only by way of the manifold ways; their self-recognition is the end of a journey, not the arrest of one. In Hadot's terms, the unveiling Novalis imagines is Orphic: Hyacinth reaches the veil through love and dream, and the novice lifts it not by force but by grace, whereas Schiller's youth seizes it with guilty hand. The genre's finest unveilings are Novalisian. They are earned by the journey and granted by the world, and the contract of deferral, which guarantees that every veil will in time be lifted, is the genre's secular name for grace.

7.6 *The Thirty Birds*

Attar's Simurgh and the Reflexive Secret

The most complete statement of the reflexive secret in world literature was written in Persian in the twelfth century. Farid ud-Din Attar (c. 1145–c. 1221), a poet and apothecary of Nishapur, completed *The Conference of the Birds* (*Mantiq al-Tayr*) around 1177. The birds of the world assemble, and the hoopoe — messenger, in the Qur'an, of King Solomon — proposes that they set out in search of their king, the Simurgh, who dwells beyond the mountain of Qaf at the edge of the world. The birds plead excuses, each bound to an attachment: the nightingale to its rose, the parrot to its golden cage and its dream of the water of life, the peacock to its memory of paradise, the duck to its water, the partridge to its jewels, the hawk to the wrist of its royal master, the owl to its ruins and their buried treasure. The hoopoe answers each with parables, and at last they set out. The way crosses seven valleys — of Quest, of Love, of Knowledge, of Detachment, of Unity, of Bewilderment, and of Poverty and Annihilation — and most of the birds perish along it. Thirty arrive. Repulsed at first by a chamberlain at the gate, they persist, and are admitted. They behold the Simurgh, and they see themselves. In Persian *si murgh* means "thirty birds": when they look upon the Simurgh, they see the thirty birds; when they look upon themselves, they see the Simurgh. They are annihilated in it and subsist in it, in the twin moments that Sufi thought calls *fana'* and *baqa'*.

Attar's poem contains, in its own idiom, nearly every movement this study has traced. Its sixth valley is the valley of Bewilderment, *hayrat*: the amazement of the maze, which Chapter Two found at the etymological root of the labyrinth, is here a station on the way to truth. Its journey strips its travellers, as Inanna was stripped at the seven gates, and most of those who set out do not arrive. And its final secret is the self — but not the self that set out. The Simurgh is a mirror, and what the thirty birds see in it is what the valleys have made of them. The reflexive secret, in Attar's form, is not narcissism but transfiguration: the self disclosed at the end is the remainder of a transformation, and its recognition of itself is also its recognition of the whole.

The Simurgh has an older and more domestic role in the Persian epic tradition, and it bears on the genre's most famous protagonist. In Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh*, completed in 1010, the warrior Sām abandons his newborn son Zāl on Mount Alborz because the child has been born with white hair. The Simurgh finds the infant, carries him to her nest, and raises him among her young. Years later, warned in a dream, Sām seeks his son, and the Simurgh returns Zāl to the human world, giving him one of her feathers to burn should he ever need her.

When Zāl's wife, Rūdābeh, suffers a labour that threatens her life, he burns the feather; the Simurgh appears and instructs the delivery of the child, Rostam, by opening his mother's side, then heals her with herbs and the touch of a feather. Long afterward she heals the wounded Rostam and reveals to him the means of defeating an invulnerable foe. The correspondence with Samus Aran is analogical, and it is offered as such: an orphaned human child taken in and raised by a race of birds in a mountain fortress-world; endowed by her avian guardians with gifts that answer every need, held out to her across every world she explores by statues of birds, as Zāl holds out the Simurgh's feather; returning to human society as its greatest warrior; and confronting at last, in *Metroid Dread*, a bird-patriarch who claims her as kin. That the father who abandons the child to the bird in Ferdowsi's epic is named Sām is an onomastic accident of the kind a Warburgian atlas might pin to the same panel and leave without comment. The bird's instruction in the birth of a hero is a motif Chapter Nine will take up.

The genre, in its fourth decade, has come to Attar's mountain. Ubisoft Montpellier set *Prince of Persia: The Lost Crown* upon Mount Qaf, the cosmic mountain of Persian tradition that encircles the world and beyond which, in Attar's poem, the Simurgh dwells. And the genre has possessed its own Simurgh since 1986. The Chozo are vanished birds whose ruins the hero explores, whose gifts she gathers from the hands of their statues, and whose blood she discovers in her own veins. *Si murgh*: the explorer of the ruins of the birds discovers that she is, in part, a bird.

The oldest Greek formulation of the reflexive imperative was inscribed at the temple of Apollo at Delphi: *gnōthi seauton*, know thyself. In the *Phaedrus* (229e–230a), Socrates, invited to rationalize an old myth, declines on the ground that he has no leisure for such inquiries, since he does not yet know himself, and he describes his self-inquiry in startling terms: he investigates whether he is a beast more complex and more furious than Typhon, the many-headed monster, or a gentler and simpler creature, sharing by nature in some divine and un-Typhonic lot. Socrates' question — am I a monster? — is the question that theriomorphic accretion poses, and the genre's reflexive secret answers it. The self discovered at the end is both: monster and kin, Typhonic and divine, the explorer become the explored.

The twentieth century produced the reflexive secret's most sobering counter-image. In Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's novel *Roadside Picnic* (1972), visitors from elsewhere have touched the earth briefly and departed, leaving behind Zones of lethal anomalies and incomprehensible artefacts, into which illegal guides called stalkers venture to retrieve them; a scientist in the novel likens the visitation to a picnic by a roadside, whose litter baffles the creatures that come

upon it after the picnickers have gone. Andrei Tarkovsky's film *Stalker* (1979), written by the brothers themselves, reduced the Zone to a single expedition. A stalker leads a Writer and a Professor through a landscape of overgrown ruins toward a Room said to grant the innermost wish of whoever enters it. The Zone is a labyrinth whose rules shift and whose traps cannot be seen, and the stalker navigates it not by map but by knowledge and ritual, throwing ahead of him metal nuts tied with strips of cloth to test the way and insisting that in the Zone the straight path is never the safe one: the detour as the law of passage. Yet when the three men reach the threshold of the Room, they do not enter. The stalker has told them of another guide who entered to wish his dead brother back and returned instead to sudden wealth, and who hanged himself, having learned from the Room what he truly wanted. The Room discloses not what one asks but who one is, and the travellers, afraid of that disclosure, sit at its threshold in the rain. *Stalker* is the reflexive secret refused: the veil at Sais left unlifted, not out of piety but out of dread of the face behind it. The metroidvania, with Novalis and Attar, lifts the veil; Tarkovsky's film is a reminder of what the lifting risks.

The reflexive secret may now be defined. It is the genre's terminal disclosure: an anagnorisis of the self, characterized by four features. It arrives at the end of a palintropic way, Novalis's manifold paths or Attar's seven valleys. It discloses a self transformed by what it has passed, stripped and re-invested, its world remade with each capacity. It is disclosed by the world as the world's own secret, behind the veil of Isis or in the mirror of the Simurgh. And it recognizes itself in kinship with the monstrous and the other, as Socrates feared and the genre accepts. Table 7.1 traces the reflexive secret across the canon.

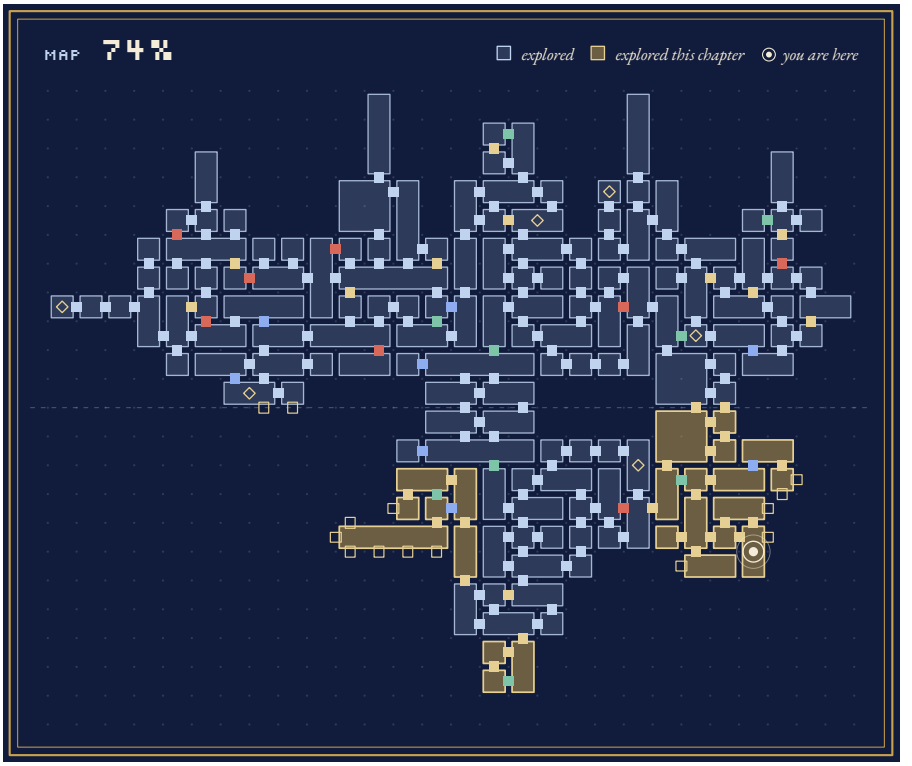
In every case the last veil hides not an object but a relation of the explorer to itself: a face, a parentage, a double, an origin, a role, a nature. The genre's treasure, at the end of the hunt, is the hunter.

TABLE 7.1 *What the last veil hides.*

WORK	THE LAST VEIL	WHAT IT DISCLOSES
Metroid (1986)	The armour, removed at completion	The hunter is a woman: the face beneath the mask
Symphony of the Night (1997)	The master of the castle	The father, whose name the son bears reversed
Metroid Fusion (2002)	The SA-X; the station's guiding voice	Samus's own armour turned against her; her dead commander's mind as her guide
Aria of Sorrow (2003)	The identity of the castle's heir	Soma Cruz is Dracula reborn
Axiom Verge (2015)	The antagonist Athetos	Another iteration of Trace himself
Hollow Knight (2017)	The Abyss beneath the kingdom	The Knight's birthplace, among its dead siblings
Outer Wilds (2019)	The Eye of the Universe	The traveller's part in the birth of the next universe
Metroid Dread (2021)	Samus's latent nature	The exterminator is the last Metroid

STASIMON

VII



The veil has been lifted, and what lay behind it has been named. Heraclitus's hiding nature, read through Hadot and Heidegger, showed the genre's world to be one in which every appearing carries its own withdrawal and every disclosure generates a new concealment, so that unconcealment is the engine of the hidden; the breakable wall made every surface a candidate veil and the player a master of suspicion who believes; and the words for secret, crypt, and apocalypse confirmed that the genre's endings are unveilings. Hadot's Promethean and Orphic attitudes divided the genre's equipment between the bomb and the glass, the missile and the song, and the Orphic gold tablets, with their directions through the underworld and their password at the lake of Memory, proved to be the earliest walkthroughs and the oldest knowledge-gates, while Orpheus's forbidden backward look was reversed into the genre's obligatory return. The Easter egg recalled the Orphic egg from which the revealer hatched; Simmel's second world described the genre's hidden halves and its communities of initiates, with the spoiler as the betrayal every secret invites; Kermode's insiders and outsiders, and Derrida's absolute secret — the singular passage

that no wiki records — distinguished the secrets that percentages count from the one they cannot. Malraux's miserable pile of secrets, spoken by Dracula with contempt, was accepted as diagnosis and reversed as verdict: the secrets of the world are the secrets of the self, and Hallownest's secret is the return of a repressed god and of the vessel the explorer is. Isis, veiled and gathering, joined concealment to reassembly; Schiller's youth was destroyed by the truth he seized; Novalis's novice, travelling the manifold ways, lifted the veil and saw himself. And Attar's thirty birds, crossing the valley of Bewilderment, beheld in the Simurgh their own transfigured faces, as the orphan raised by birds discovers at last the birds in her own blood. Table 7.1 found the reflexive secret across the canon: the treasure at the end of the hunt is the hunter.

The pentad is complete. Prolepsis, aporia, metamorphosis, anagnorisis, and aletheia have each been traced through their mythic, philosophical, and ludic forms. Two tasks remain. The first concerns memory: how the palintropic world is held, archived, catalogued, completed, and shared — the memory palace, the bestiary, the community that remembers together, and the utopia of the hundred per cent. The second concerns the end: the escape through a collapsing world, the measured womb from which the hero is expelled, the labyrinth that destroys itself upon being known, and the ethics of return that the whole structure implies.

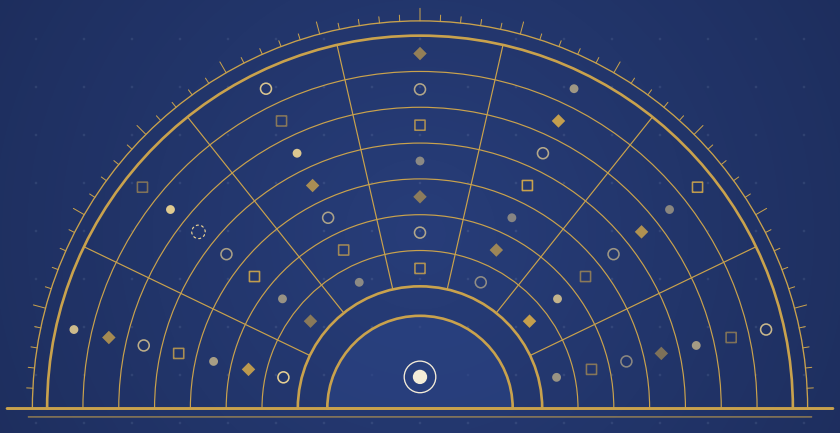
CHAPTER EIGHT

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Ars Memoriae

μνήμη

The Memory Palace, the Bestiary, and the Utopia of the Hundred Percent



... hac tum re admonitus invenisse fertur ordinem esse maxime qui memoriae lumen adferret.

... prompted by this event, he is said to have discovered that it is order above all that brings light to memory.

— Cicero, *De Oratore* II.353, on Simonides of Ceos

Mi memoria, señor, es como vaciadero de basuras.

My memory, sir, is like a rubbish heap.

— Jorge Luis Borges, "Funes el memorioso" (1942)

8.1 *Simonides' Banquet*

Loci and Imagines

The art of memory was founded, according to the legend Cicero tells in *De Oratore* and Quintilian repeats in the *Institutio Oratoria*, upon a ruin full of the dead. The lyric poet Simonides of Ceos, dining at the house of the Thessalian nobleman Scopas, chanted a poem in his host's honour that included a passage praising the twin gods Castor and Pollux, and Scopas, in a mean jest, paid him only half the agreed fee, telling him to collect the rest from the Twins. Shortly afterward a message came that two young men were waiting outside to see the poet. Simonides went out and found no one; and in his absence the roof of the banqueting hall fell, crushing Scopas and his guests so completely that their kinsmen could not identify the bodies for burial. Simonides identified them by remembering the places at which each had reclined at table. Prompted by this event, Cicero writes, he is said to have discovered that order, above all, brings light to memory, and to have devised an art. Those who would train this faculty must select places (*loci*) and form mental images (*imagines*) of the things they wish to remember, storing the images in the places, so that the order of the places preserves the order of the things and the images denote the things themselves; the places serve as the wax tablet and the images as the letters written upon it.

The fullest classical account of the technique is the anonymous *Rhetorica ad Herennium*, composed in the 80s BCE. Its author advised that the places be chosen in a building, deserted rather than crowded, of moderate size, moderately lit, differing distinctly from one another, and marked at regular intervals — a golden hand at the fifth place, a friend named Decimus at the tenth — so that their sequence could be traversed forward or backward from any point. Its images should be *imagines agentes*, active or striking images: exceptionally beautiful or exceptionally ugly, adorned with crowns or purple cloaks, disfigured, stained with blood or smeared with mud, comic or grotesque, since ordinary things slip from memory while the extraordinary are retained. Its most famous example compresses a lawsuit into a single scene: a sick man in bed, a cup in one hand, and in the other a ram's testicles, whose Latin name, *testes*, recalls the witnesses. Quintilian described the practice as a walk. The orator places the first image in the vestibule of a large house, the second in the atrium, and the rest around the impluvium and into the bedrooms and parlours, entrusting even the statues with something to recall; and when he must remember, he walks again through the house, retrieving each image from its place.

Frances Yates's *The Art of Memory* (1966) traced the technique from antiquity through the scholastics, who made memory a part of prudence, to the occult memory systems of the Renaissance. Giulio Camillo's Memory Theatre, built in the 1530s and seen in Venice and Paris, placed its user on the stage looking out at seven tiers of seven gangways, whose images and boxes of documents were meant to hold the whole of knowledge arranged by the planets: a theatre of the world in which the cosmos could be remembered as a building. Giordano Bruno's memory wheels and seals, beginning with *De umbris idearum* (1582), which Yates read as Hermetic instruments for imprinting the structure of the universe upon the mind, and Robert Fludd's memory theatre, carried the art to its most ambitious and most esoteric forms. Jonathan Spence's *The Memory Palace of Matteo Ricci* (1984) followed the Jesuit missionary who, in 1596, composed a treatise on the memory palace in Chinese to win the admiration of scholars preparing for the imperial examinations. The method survives today among competitive mnemonists, whose world Joshua Foer described in *Moonwalking with Einstein* (2011), and neuroscience has given it a physiological footing. Eleanor Maguire and her colleagues found the posterior hippocampi of London taxi drivers, who memorize the city's labyrinth of streets, enlarged in proportion to their years of navigation (2000), and found that superior memorizers rely disproportionately on spatial strategies such as the method of loci (2003).

The metroidvania is the art of memory made playable. Its loci are rooms, memorized in sequence and in plan; its *imagines agentes* are its glimpsed items, its colossal landmarks, its grotesque guardians, the energy tank gleaming behind glass. Its designers follow the precepts of the *Ad Herennium* without needing to have read them. Its places differ distinctly, each region given its palette, music, and ecology; they are of moderate size, sized to the screen or to a few screens; they are marked at intervals by rooms of rest and conspicuous landmarks; and its images are striking by design, since the visible unreachable must be remembered across hours if it is to be returned to. The player's return through the world is the orator's walk through the memory palace, retrieving each deferred promise from its place. The genre's interfaces regulate the art's difficulty. The original *Metroid*, providing no map, obliged its players to build their palaces on graph paper; *Hollow Knight*, withholding its maps until they are purchased and inscribing them only at rest, obliges its players to build them, in part, in the mind.

The founding legend carries one further correspondence. Simonides' first memory palace was a ruin, and the art began as the identification of the dead by the places they had occupied. The metroidvania's most celebrated worlds are Simonidean palaces in exactly this sense: collapsed halls of fallen civiliza-

tions, whose dead the explorer identifies by place — the corpses of Hallownest's knights at their posts, the remains of Chozo in their temples, the bodies whose last thoughts the Dream Nail recovers where they fell. To remember the world, in such works, is to remember where the dead lie.

Gene Wolfe's tetralogy *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83) gave the art of memory its most labyrinthine modern fiction. Its narrator, Severian, an apprentice of the guild of torturers on a far-future Earth called Urth, claims to forget nothing, and recounts his life from within a Citadel whose ancient towers, readers gradually infer, are grounded starships whose purpose their inhabitants have long forgotten: a ruined architecture of a vanished technology, walked by one who does not know what he walks through. Severian acquires memories as the genre's heroes acquire capacities. At a feast of conspirators he eats, mixed with a drug drawn from a beast that devours the dead, the flesh of a woman he loved, and her memories come to live in him beside his own; at the end, by a similar rite, he receives the memories of a long line of rulers. The narrator becomes a palace of the dead, a Simonidean hall whose occupants he can name because they now dwell within him. And Wolfe's books are constructed, by notorious design, to be read twice: their clues disclose their meaning only on a second passage, when what was obscure in the first reading becomes legible in the light of the whole. *The Book of the New Sun* is a palintropic text in exactly this study's sense, and its narrator's total memory, unlike that of Funes, is not a rubbish heap but a labyrinth, re-entered by every reader who returns.

8.2 *Inventio and Inventory*

Mary Carruthers's *The Book of Memory* (1990) and *The Craft of Thought* (1998) transformed the understanding of medieval memory by showing that it was not conceived as mere storage but as the matrix of thought and composition. The trained memory was imagined as a storehouse — a treasury (*thesaurus*), a cellar (*cella*), a strongbox (*arca*), a dovecote of pigeonholes, a hive — and as a building of many rooms. Hugh of St Victor, in his treatises on Noah's Ark composed in the 1120s, made the ark a vast mnemonic structure whose decks and compartments held the whole of sacred history, to be walked and rewalked by the contemplative mind. Carruthers's decisive observation concerned the first canon of rhetoric, *inventio*, the finding of one's matter. Medieval writers understood invention as a form of recollection: one finds what one has to say in the places of one's memory, where it has been stored. *Inventory*, the list of what is stored, and *invention*, the finding of it, share the root *invenire*, to come upon. Invention is retrieval made creative.

The metroidvania's inventory screen is an inventory in Carruthers's medieval sense: the strongbox of what has been found, the treasury of capacities, relics, charms, and souls that the hero carries. Play proceeds by invention in her sense. The player consults the inventory against the remembered impasses, matching stored capacities to stored places, and finds a passage where none had been — an act of recollection that is also an act of discovery. When no single capacity suffices, the player combines them: the grapple and the speed of the run, the dash and the cling to walls, the form of the bat and the form of mist. The combination of stored tools to reach what none could reach alone is Köhler's ape fitting together two sticks, transposed into the inventory of a self.

The art of combining stored elements has its own venerable history. Ramon Llull (c. 1232–1316), in the *Ars generalis ultima* of 1305–08, inscribed letters standing for divine attributes and fundamental concepts on rotating concentric wheels, whose combinations were meant to generate all possible truths and to persuade the unbeliever by demonstration. Bruno joined Llull's wheels to the classical art of memory, and Leibniz, in his *Dissertation on the Art of Combinations* (1666), dreamed of a universal characteristic by which all thought could be computed. The genre's systems of equipping are Lullian combinatories. The equipment and relics of *Symphony of the Night*, the absorbed souls of *Aria of Sorrow*, the charms of *Hollow Knight* — whose limited notches compel the player to compose, from a finite store, the self that will meet the next region — and the rosary beads and prayers of *Blasphemous* each make the hero's identity at any moment a combination drawn from an inventory. Play becomes the art of com-

bining stored powers to meet the world, and the self becomes a configuration rather than a substance.

The original *Metroid*'s password system, examined in Chapter One, carried this logic to a remarkable extreme. Its twenty-four characters encoded the whole of Samus's inventory and the state of the world she had explored, so that the player, transcribing a string of apparently meaningless letters into a notebook, held the entire state of a self in a cipher. The memory palace was compressed into a line of text: an inventory reduced to its notation, the opposite of Funes's limitless and useless retention. The password belonged to the lineage of mnemonic ciphers that runs from the shorthand of the ancient *notae* to the characters Ricci taught his Chinese students to lodge in the rooms of their palaces.

The genre's places of rest are its scriptoria, the rooms in which memory is written into the persistent world. Capcom's *Resident Evil* made the act of saving literal writing: its save rooms contain typewriters, and each save consumes one of a finite supply of ink ribbons, so that memory becomes a scarce inscription. The kneelers of *Blasphemous*, the save stations of *Super Metroid*, and the benches of *Hollow Knight*, at which alone the day's paths are inscribed into the map, are variations on the scriptorium. And the genre inherits, with its scriptoria, an ancient ambivalence about external memory. In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274c–277a), the god Theuth presents writing to King Thamus as a remedy for memory, and Thamus replies that it will produce forgetfulness in the souls of those who learn it, since they will cease to exercise their memories and rely instead on external marks: writing is a *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison, a means not of memory (*mnēmē*) but of reminding (*hypomnēsis*). Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) made the passage the starting point of a theory of writing. The automatic map is the genre's *pharmakon*. It cures disorientation and weakens the palace within. The designers who withhold it — who give no map, as the first *Metroid* did, or who sell it and inscribe it only at rest, as *Hollow Knight* does — restage Thamus's warning, and their players, drawing their own maps or carrying them in the mind, rediscover the art that the auto-map renders unnecessary.

8.3 *The Bestiary and the Wunderkammer*

The *Physiologus*, composed in Greek, probably in Alexandria, between the second and fourth centuries of the common era, described some fifty animals, plants, and stones and followed each description with a moral or Christological interpretation: the pelican that revives its slain young with its own blood, the phoenix that rises from its ashes, the panther whose sweet breath draws all other beasts to it, the lion that sleeps with its eyes open. Translated into Latin and many vernaculars, and enlarged with material from Isidore of Seville's *Etymologies* in the seventh century, it became the medieval bestiary, of which illuminated manuscripts such as the Aberdeen Bestiary of around 1200 are the most splendid survivals. In the bestiary the creatures of the world compose a book of moral signs, each animal a sentence in the scripture of nature, legible to one who knows how to read it.

The metroidvania keeps bestiaries. *Symphony of the Night* maintains a catalogue of the enemies Alucard has defeated, with their strengths, weaknesses, and spoils; *Aria of Sorrow* records the souls of the creatures Soma has absorbed; *Metroid Prime*'s logbook holds the scanned data of every creature on Tallon IV, with its anatomy and vulnerabilities; and *Hollow Knight* entrusts the Knight with a Hunter's Journal, given by a solitary hunter dwelling in the overgrowth of Greenpath, in which each creature of Hallownest is recorded with the hunter's own laconic, often elegiac commentary — but only after a set number of that creature has been killed. Knowledge, in the Hunter's Journal, is purchased by slaughter. The genre's bestiaries thus stand at the intersection of two traditions. With the medieval bestiary they share the impulse to read creatures as signs: the Hunter's entries are as much moral and poetic meditations as natural histories. With modern natural history they share a lethal epistemology. John James Audubon shot the birds he painted for *The Birds of America* (1827–38) and wired their corpses into lifelike attitudes; and Donna Haraway's essay "Teddy Bear Patriarchy" (1984–85) read the African dioramas that Carl Akeley assembled for the American Museum of Natural History as the production, by the hunter's rifle and the taxidermist's art, of an eternal and frozen nature, in which each animal is known through its death. The Hunter's Journal is Akeley's African Hall rendered as a ledger, and its completion, like the completion of the logbook in *Metroid Prime*, joins the anti-conquest of natural history that Chapter Five criticized to the bestiary's older desire to find meaning in every living thing.

The Renaissance and Baroque collector organized the world's wonders differently. The *Wunderkammer*, or cabinet of curiosities, gathered naturalia (shells, corals, fossils, the narwhal tusks sold as unicorn horns), artificialia (automata,

carved ivories, turned wood), scientific instruments, and the exotica of distant lands into rooms that were understood as microcosms, theatres of the world. Samuel Quiccheberg's *Inscriptiones* (1565), often called the first treatise on museums, conceived the collection as a theatre of wisdom; the frontispiece of Ole Worm's *Museum Wormianum* (1655) shows a room whose walls and ceiling are entirely covered with specimens; Athanasius Kircher's museum at the Collegio Romano and the Kunstkammer of the Emperor Rudolf II in Prague were famous throughout Europe. Lorraine Daston and Katharine Park's *Wonders and the Order of Nature, 1150–1750* (1998) showed that such collections were ordered by wonder rather than by taxonomy, and that wonder itself, a cognitive passion of the first importance for medieval and early modern natural philosophers, declined as the Enlightenment came to regard it as the vice of the credulous. The metroidvania's inventories and collections are *Wunderkämmern*, assemblages of objects valued for their strangeness and their histories. In *Hollow Knight*, the relic seeker Lemm, who keeps a shop of antiquities in the City of Tears, buys the journals of dead wanderers, the seals of the kingdom, the idols of its king, and the eggs of a vanished people, and tells the story of each: a curator of the kingdom's past, whose cabinet the Knight fills as it explores.

Borges supplied the bestiary's limit case. In "The Analytical Language of John Wilkins" (1942), he cites a certain Chinese encyclopedia, which he attributes to a translator named Franz Kuhn, in which animals are divided into such classes as those that belong to the Emperor, embalmed ones, suckling pigs, fabulous ones, those included in the present classification, and those that from a long way off look like flies. Michel Foucault opened *The Order of Things* (1966) with the laughter this passage provoked in him, a laughter that shattered the familiar landmarks of thought and exposed the historicity of every order of knowledge. The genre's bestiaries are such emporia. Their creatures are ordered not by nature but by play: by the number of kills required to record them, by the spoils they drop, by the elements to which they are vulnerable, by what they do to the player and what the player may take from them. They disclose, as Borges's encyclopedia disclosed for Foucault, an episteme — the episteme of the hunter, for whom a creature is known by the manner of its death and the value of its remains.

8.4 *Environmental Storytelling and the Ruin*

The genre's privileged narrative form is the ruin. Its explorer arrives, characteristically, after the catastrophe. Hallownest has already fallen to the infection when the Knight descends; the Chozo of Zebes and of Tallon IV have already vanished when Samus walks their temples; Dracula's castle has risen from its own ruins; Cvstodia already groans under the curse its people call the Grievous Miracle; the forest of Nibel is already decaying when Ori wakes; the kingdom of *Ender Lilies* has already been drowned by a rain of death that turned its people into monsters. The genre's temporality is post-apocalyptic in the literal sense. Its story has already happened, and the player's task is to read it in what remains. Henry Jenkins's embedded narrative, examined in Chapter One, finds here its natural habitat, for the ruin is the form in which a history persists as a space.

The ruin has its own philosophy. Georg Simmel's essay "The Ruin" (1907) described architecture as the momentary victory of spirit's upward striving over the downward pull of matter, and the ruin as the moment at which nature takes its revenge and reclaims the work, producing a new unity in which human purpose and natural process are reconciled: the peace of the ruin, in which a past whose life has departed retains its form, so that the present feels the past as present. Denis Diderot, contemplating Hubert Robert's paintings of ruins in his *Salon* of 1767, set down a meditation that the Romantic century would repeat in a thousand variations: *Les idées que les ruines réveillent en moi sont grandes. Tout s'anéantit, tout périt, tout passe. Il n'y a que le monde qui reste. Il n'y a que le temps qui dure* — the ideas ruins awaken in me are grand; everything comes to nothing, everything perishes, everything passes; only the world remains; only time endures. Robert himself painted, in 1796, an imaginary view of the Grande Galerie of the Louvre in ruins, the museum imagined as its own future wreck; and Volney's *The Ruins, or a Meditation on the Revolutions of Empires* (1791) set its traveller among the columns of Palmyra to contemplate the fall of nations. The genre inherits this sensibility, and its ruined kingdoms invite exactly the melancholy Diderot described, in which the explorer, walking among the remains of a civilization, feels time itself as the only survivor.

The ruin is also a text, and the genre's explorers read it as Lovecraft's explorers read the bas-reliefs of the Elder Things in *At the Mountains of Madness*: in the order of their discovery rather than the order of their events, reconstructing a history from fragments whose sequence must be inferred. *Metroid Prime*'s Chozo Lore, scanned from glyphs on the walls of Tallon IV's temples, narrates in scattered entries the Chozo's settlement of the planet, the fall of a poisonous meteor they called the Great Poison, the corruption that spread from it, and their

withdrawal from the flesh. *Hollow Knight* inscribes its history on tablets beside its roads, in the poses of its statues, and in the last thoughts of its dead. And the genre has widely adopted the convention, developed in FromSoftware's *Souls* games, of depositing its mythology in the descriptions of items, so that the inventory becomes an archive of fragments. Hidetaka Miyazaki, FromSoftware's director, has recalled reading as a child books that exceeded his understanding and filling their gaps with his own imagination, and he has connected that practice to the fragmentary storytelling of his games, whose influence on the recent masterpieces of the genre — *Hollow Knight*, *Blasphemous*, *Ender Lilies* — is evident. The ruin is Iser's text of blanks in its purest form, and the communities examined in the next section are its readers.

Walter Benjamin's last completed work, the theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), contains the most famous image of the ruin in twentieth-century thought. Contemplating Paul Klee's drawing *Angelus Novus*, Benjamin describes the angel of history, its face turned toward the past: *Wo eine Kette von Begebenheiten vor uns erscheint, da sieht er eine einzige Katastrophe, die unablässig Trümmer auf Trümmer häuft und sie ihm vor die Füße schleudert. Er möchte wohl verweilen, die Toten wecken und das Zerschlagene zusammenfügen* — where a chain of events appears before us, he sees one single catastrophe, which keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage and hurls it at his feet; he would like to stay, to awaken the dead, and to make whole what has been smashed. But a storm blowing from Paradise has caught in his wings with such violence that he can no longer close them, and it drives him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned, while the pile of debris before him grows skyward. This storm, Benjamin wrote, is what we call progress.

The metroidvania's explorer walks through the angel's wreckage. The single catastrophe lies piled at its feet in every ruined hall. And the genre grants, within play, precisely what history denied the angel. The explorer may stay, because the world waits for it. It may awaken the dead, as the Dream Nail awakens the last thoughts of Hallownest's fallen and as Simonides named the crushed by their places. And it may make whole what has been smashed, as Isis gathered Osiris, as the relics of a dismembered body are reassembled, as the map is completed cell by cell. Above all, the genre permits what the storm forbids: it permits the explorer to turn back. In a culture whose dominant image of time is the storm of progress, the metroidvania is a form in which the past is not irretrievable, and this may be the most political content it possesses. Its palintropy is a small, persistent refusal of the wind.

8.5 *The Collective Palace*

Wikis, Speedruns, and Communal Decipherment

Simonides' palace was one man's; the metroidvania's has become many people's. The history of the genre's reception is a history of the progressive externalization and socialization of its memory. In 1986, players drew the corridors of Zebes on graph paper and traded their maps with friends; from 1988, Nintendo's house magazine, *Nintendo Power*, printed maps and strategies that circulated through schoolyards; in the 1990s, plain-text walkthroughs and "frequently asked questions" composed by individual players were gathered on sites such as GameFAQs, founded in 1995; in the 2000s and 2010s came collaborative wikis, video essays, and the leaderboards of Speedrun.com, founded in 2014. Each epoch moved the memory palace further from the private notebook toward the collective archive, until the map of a world like Hallownest came to exist, in its fullest form, nowhere but in the distributed memory of its players.

The sociology of memory anticipated this condition. Maurice Halbwachs argued in *Les Cadres sociaux de la mémoire* (1925) and in the posthumously published *La Mémoire collective* (1950) that individual memory depends upon social frameworks: we remember as members of groups, and our memories are localized in spaces we share with others. Pierre Nora's multivolume *Les Lieux de mémoire* (1984–92) studied the "sites of memory" in which a collective memory crystallizes once living memory has receded. The genre's iconic rooms are *lieux de mémoire* of a player culture: the rain-swept landing site on Crateria, the entrance hall of Dracula's castle, the King's Pass through which the Knight first enters Hallownest, recognized at a glance across the culture, quoted in fan works, and revisited in remakes. Pierre Lévy's *L'Intelligence collective* (1994) described an intelligence distributed everywhere and coordinated in real time; Henry Jenkins's *Convergence Culture* (2006) showed how fan "knowledge communities" pool their findings, recounting the online community that collaborated to discover the secret outcomes of a television competition before they were broadcast. Stanley Fish's "interpretive communities" (*Is There a Text in This Class?*, 1980) named the groups whose shared strategies produce the meanings their members find in texts. The communities that reconstruct the history of Hallownest or of Cvstodia from fragments of inscription, dialogue, and item description are interpretive communities in Fish's sense and knowledge communities in Jenkins's, and the histories they agree upon are collective constructions.

Some works have been designed, or have come to be played, as objects of communal decipherment. Polytron's *Fez* concealed an invented alphabet that its players decoded within days of release; its final puzzle, a code for which the game

offered no clue, was solved in 2013 only through a coordinated effort in which players divided the possible solutions among themselves and tested them one by one. The script of *Tunic*'s manual was decoded by players who discovered that it encodes the sounds of English. *Animal Well*'s deepest strata of secrets were, by its designer's account, intended for a community rather than an individual to solve. *La-Mulana*'s cryptic tablets were glossed in communal hint guides; and the community surrounding *Outer Wilds* has made protective silence its ethic, guarding the discoveries of newcomers by refusing to disclose them.

The speedrunning communities constitute a collective palace of a different kind. Their exploration of the labyrinth's unconscious, the graph that physics permits beneath the graph the designer intended, is cumulative and public: each discovery is timed, verified, documented, and absorbed into routes that are refined over decades, so that the history of a single game's routes is a palimpsest of collective intelligence. The world record, in such a community, is less an individual achievement than the current state of a shared knowledge, and the live race, performed before an audience, is a communal ritual in which that knowledge is displayed.

The collective palace carries a tension that the genre's culture has learned to manage. The walkthrough threatens discovery. It is the betrayal of the secret that Simmel placed at the heart of secrecy, and Thamus's warning about writing applies to it at the scale of a culture: the wiki is a *pharmakon*, curing the frustration of the impasse and poisoning the possibility of finding one's own way. The genre's communities have accordingly evolved norms that balance memory against discovery: the etiquette of the spoiler warning, the practice of playing "blind," and hint systems that disclose their help by degrees. The Universal Hint System, distributed since the late 1980s for adventure games, revealed its hints one line at a time, so that the stuck player could take only as much as needed; it was, in effect, a community-built prolepsis, a glimpse calibrated to preserve the remainder of the mystery. The collective palace keeps some of its doors closed for those who have not yet arrived. It is a mnemonic commons regulated by secrecy, and the *communitas* of the lost that Chapter Four found among the genre's wanderers becomes, in its culture, a society of rememberers who remember, in part, by agreeing what not to say.

8.6 Etwas Fehlt

Bloch, Adorno, Hegel, and the Ninety-Nine Percent

In 1964, Ernst Bloch and Theodor W. Adorno met for a radio conversation on the contradictions of utopian longing, later published as "Something's Missing." Bloch took as his text a line from Bertolt Brecht and Kurt Weill's opera *Rise and Fall of the City of Mahagonny* (1930). In Mahagonny, a city founded for pleasure in which everything is permitted, the lumberjack Jim Mahoney, surrounded by every satisfaction, protests: *etwas fehlt* — something's missing. Bloch called it one of the most profound sentences Brecht ever wrote. The consciousness that something is missing, even amid abundance, is the beginning of utopian longing; it is the Not-Yet announcing itself within the already-there. Adorno agreed and sharpened the point. Utopia, he insisted, exists essentially in the determinate negation of what merely is; it cannot be painted in positive images without betraying itself, and he invoked the ancient prohibition of images of the divine as the model of a utopian consciousness that knows what is wrong without presuming to depict what would be right. The "something missing" is utopia's negative trace.

The metroidvania has given *etwas fehlt* a number. *Super Metroid* tallies the percentage of items collected; *Symphony of the Night* tallies the percentage of the castle explored, to its celebrated 200.6; *Hollow Knight*'s completion climbs past one hundred to one hundred and twelve; *Metroid Dread* reports an item rate. Each converts the Not-Yet into a figure. And the figure that most powerfully moves the genre's players is not one hundred but ninety-nine: a world in which every corner seems explored and yet one item eludes the search — the last missile expansion, the last trapped grub, the last seal. The missing one per cent provokes the most intense searching the genre knows, frequently communal, as forums fill with players comparing maps in quest of a single cell. It is the purest *etwas fehlt* in contemporary culture: Bloch's utopian longing reduced to its formal essence, a lack known precisely without being located, and the counterpart in play of the fifteenth stone at Ryōan-ji, which Chapter Two found withheld from every point of view.

What the genre awards at one hundred per cent is characteristically meagre: an altered ending image, a line of text, an achievement, a slightly faster clock. The disproportion that Chapter One observed between the intensity of the return and its rewards appears here inverted. The labour of completion vastly exceeds what completion confers, and the disproportion confirms Bloch and Adorno at once. The value lay in the lack. Utopia attained becomes trivial, as Adorno feared; the longing was the substance, as Bloch held. Borges's "Funes the Mem-

orious," from which this chapter's second epigraph is taken, imagines the completion of memory as a catastrophe. Ireneo Funes, after a fall from a horse, can forget nothing: every leaf of every tree, every perception of every instant, is preserved in him entire. And he cannot think, the narrator concludes, for to think is to forget differences, to generalize, to abstract, and in Funes's teeming world there are only details. The completed map approaches Funes's condition: total retention, with nothing left to recollect toward, a palace without a locus yet to be sought. The genre's characteristic ending, which destroys the completed world, spares its player Funes's fate.

The philosophical prototype of a journey completed in recollection is Hegel's. "The true is the whole" (*Das Wahre ist das Ganze*), the preface to the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) declares, and the absolute is essentially a result, which is only at the end what it truly is. The *Phenomenology* is circular: its end returns to its beginning, now comprehended. In its final chapter, absolute knowing recollects the entire path of spirit as a gallery of images, each shape taken inward in an act Hegel names, with a hyphen that splits the word into its parts, *Er-Innerung*: recollection as inwardization. In the *Encyclopaedia* he called philosophy a circle of circles. Hegel's system is the great philosophical antecedent of palintropic form — a journey whose end is the recollection of the journey — and the completed metroidvania is absolute knowing in miniature: the player recollecting, on the map, the gallery of shapes through which the journey passed, each region taken inward as a station of a single path.

Adorno inverted Hegel's sentence in *Minima Moralia* (1951): "the whole is the false" (*Das Ganze ist das Unwahre*). The closed totality, for Adorno, is the lie of an administered world that admits nothing outside itself. The metroidvania stands between the two sentences. It grants Hegel's recollected whole, and then, characteristically, it annihilates it, as though acknowledging Adorno's warning that a completed whole is untrue. The completed totality, in any case, is true only within a designed world, the just world whose ideology Chapter Three diagnosed, and the genre's destruction of that world at the moment of its completion refuses to let a designed totality pass for the world itself. The player, expelled from the completed labyrinth, returns to a world in which something is still missing, a world in which, as Bloch would say, home has not yet been reached. *Etwas fehlt* is at once the genre's motor and its final truth.

8.7 *Roguevania, Metroidbrainia, and the Futures of Return*

The metroidvania's nearest neighbours are themselves forms of return, and they are most clearly distinguished by what persists between one attempt and the next. The roguelike, named for *Rogue* (1980), a dungeon game of procedurally generated levels and permanent death, generates a new world for each attempt and resets its avatar at each death; only the player's knowledge survives. In Derek Yu's *Spelunky* (2008; remade 2012), the modern exemplar of the form, the caves are never the same twice, so that the player learns not places but principles. The roguelike's return is Nietzsche's eternal recurrence inverted. In *The Gay Science* (§341, 1882), a demon proposes that one must live one's life again innumerable times, every pain and every joy returning in the same sequence; the roguelike returns its player endlessly, but never to the same world, so that the self recurs while the place is always new. Supergiant Games' *Hades* (2020) gave the form a mythology: Zagreus, son of the lord of the dead, attempts again and again to fight his way out of the underworld, a perpetual anabasis whose story accumulates across its failures. Albert Camus's Sisyphus, whom one must imagine happy, presides over the whole family.

The roguevania hybridizes recurrence with accumulation. Motion Twin's *Dead Cells* (2018), which named itself a "roguevania," assembles its levels procedurally within a fixed world structure and kills its protagonist permanently, but certain capacities, which it calls runes — a vine to climb, a means of teleportation, a ram to break floors — persist across all future attempts once found, opening paths in every subsequent world. Cellar Door Games' *Rogue Legacy* (2013) passes the quest at each death to an heir with randomly assigned traits, while the family's manor accumulates improvements and the castle regenerates around it: a genealogical return that recalls the Belmont dynasty of *Castlevania*. In the roguevania, return is at once repetition and progress, Sisyphus with a growing inheritance.

The time-loop form of the knowledge-gated game returns its player to a world that does not change at all. In *Outer Wilds*, the solar system resets to an identical state every twenty-two minutes; the avatar acquires no new capacities; and only knowledge persists, recorded in the ship's log. It is the purest palintrope the medium has produced, for the room — here, the planet — is literally the same, and only the traveller has changed. Heraclitus's river is made exact: the same river, entered by a different person every time.

Table 8.1 sets these forms of return side by side.

TABLE 8.1 *What persists across the return.*

FORM	THE WORLD BETWEEN ATTEMPTS	THE AVATAR'S CAPACITIES	THE PLAYER'S KNOWLEDGE	INSTANCES
Roguelike	Generated anew	Reset	Persists	*Rogue* (1980); *Spelunky* (2008)
Roguevania	Regenerated within a fixed structure	Partly kept	Persists	*Rogue Legacy* (2013); *Dead Cells* (2018)
Metroidvania	Persistent and cumulative	Accumulated	Persists	*Super Metroid* (1994); *Hollow Knight* (2017)
Time-loop metroidbrainia	Reset to an identical state	Unchanged	Persists, and is the only progress	*Outer Wilds* (2019)

The metroidvania appears in the table as the form of total memory: world, body, and knowledge all persist and accumulate. The roguelike keeps only the player; the roguevania keeps the player and some of the avatar's powers; the time-loop form keeps only knowledge but returns it to a world that has kept nothing at all. Each is an answer to the question of what a return preserves, and each embodies a distinct metaphysics of repetition. Søren Kierkegaard, in *Repetition* (1843), published under the pseudonym Constantin Constantius, distinguished repetition from recollection as the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been, and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward. Kierkegaard's formula is the most exact description of the metroidvania's return ever written before the genre existed. Its returns are recollections forward: the player goes back to a remembered place in order to move ahead, and what is recovered there is not the past but the future the past had held in reserve.

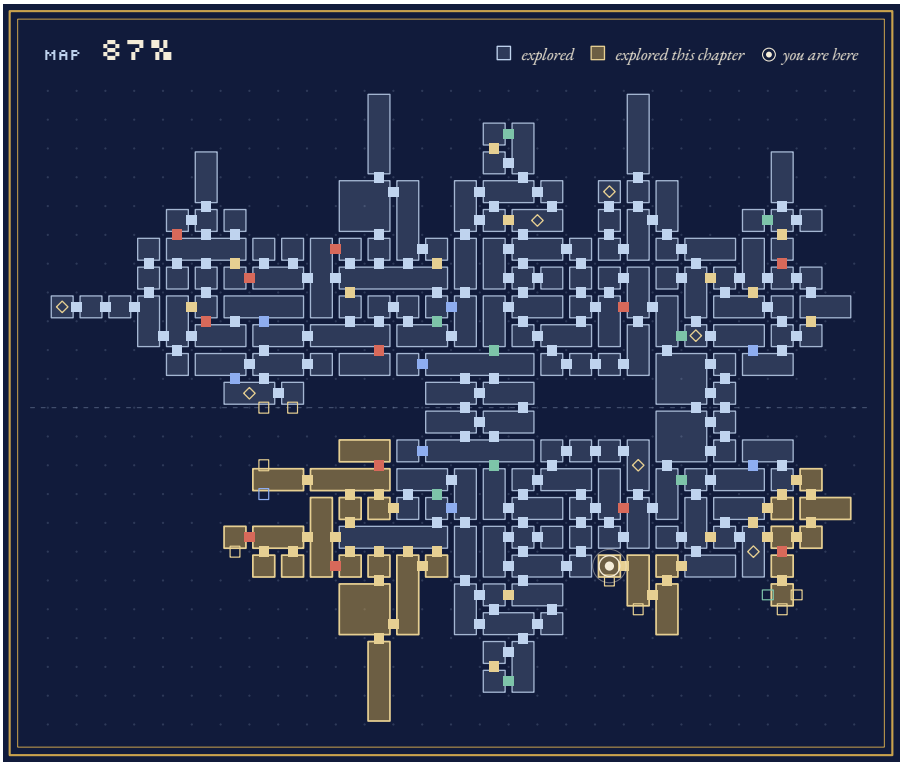
The form's futures are being explored at its margins. Communities of players have built "randomizers" for *Super Metroid*, *Hollow Knight*, and many other works, modifications that shuffle the locations of capacities so that a memorized palace becomes a new labyrinth: a collective *ostranenie*, estranging worlds that habit had made transparent. The genre's syntax, meanwhile, has been exported to three-dimensional action. Rocksteady's *Batman: Arkham Asylum* (2009) organized an island asylum by gated return; Arkane Studios' *Prey* (2017) made an interconnected space station its labyrinth; and Remedy Entertainment's *Control* (2019) set its exploration in the Oldest House, a shifting brutalist building larger on the inside than out, ability-gated and haunted — Danielewski's house rendered as a metroidvania. Against these the open world, which Chapter Two compared to Borges's desert labyrinth, stands as the genre's other, a freedom

without walls whose expanses make the metroidvania's gates appear, once again, as mercies.

The futures of return lie within the space Table 8.1 maps: worlds that remember and worlds that forget, selves that accumulate and selves that begin again. The question these forms pose is ethical as well as formal. What should a return preserve, and what should it allow to be lost? It is to that question, and to the end that gives it urgency, that the final chapter turns.

STASIMON

VIII



The palintropic world has been considered as a thing remembered. Simonides' banquet, which founded the art of memory upon a ruin full of the dead, showed the metroidvania to be the art of memory made playable: its rooms are loci*, its glimpsed items and grotesque guardians* imagines agentes*, its return the orator's walk through the palace, and its ruined kingdoms Simonidean halls in which the dead are known by their places. Carruthers's medieval memory disclosed the inventory as a treasury from which invention draws, Llull's wheels the combinatory art by which the hero composes itself from its stored powers, the password a palace compressed to a cipher, and the save room a scriptorium haunted by Thamus's warning that the external aid weakens the memory it serves. The bestiary and the cabinet of curiosities named the two traditions in which the genre catalogues its creatures and its relics — the medieval book of moral signs, the lethal epistemology of natural history, and the Baroque theatre of wonder — while Borges's encyclopedia exposed the hunter's episteme beneath its orders. The ruin proved to be the genre's privileged narrative form, its explorer an archaeologist arriving after the catastrophe, and Benjamin's angel of history, driven*

forward by the storm of progress, found in the genre the one thing history denied him: the power to stay, to wake the dead, to piece together what was smashed, and to turn back. The memory palace became collective — a distributed archive of maps, wikis, and routes, a mnemonic commons regulated by the etiquette of secrecy. The completion percentage gave Bloch and Adorno's etwas fehlt *a number, the ninety-nine per cent its purest expression, and Hegel's recollected whole a playable form that the genre, mindful of Adorno and of Funes, destroys upon completion. And the neighbouring forms of return were distinguished by what they preserve, with the metroidvania as the form of total memory and Kierkegaard's recollection forward as its formula.*

One movement remains: the way out. The final chapter turns to the genre's characteristic ending — the escape through a collapsing world — and reads it as a birth; examines the maternal figures who preside over the genre's deepest chambers; considers the labyrinth that destroys itself upon being known; and proposes, at last, an ethics of return.

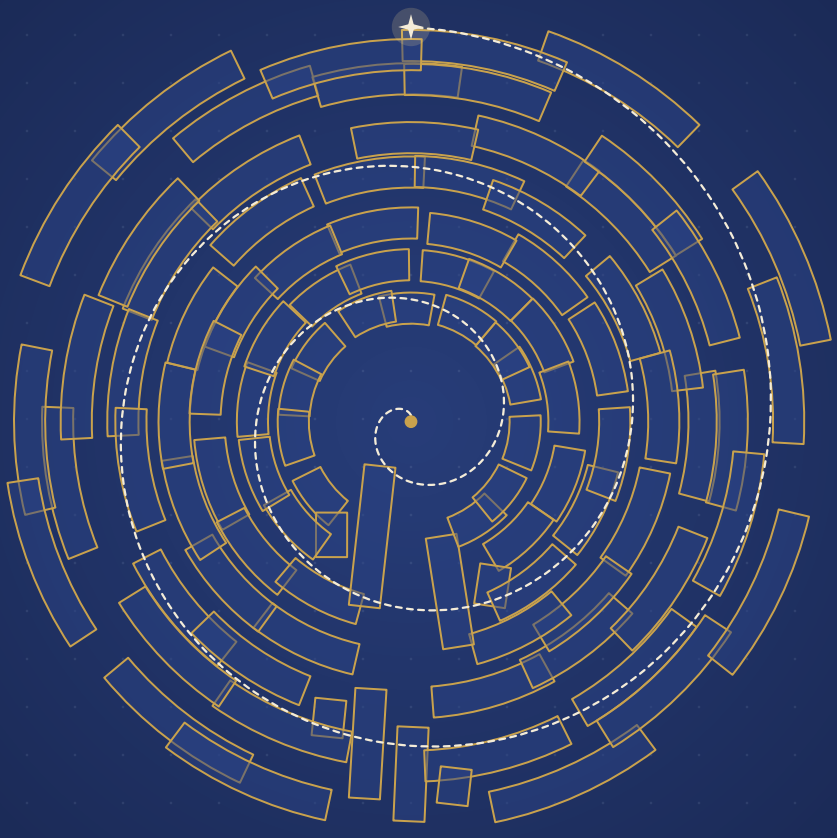
CHAPTER NINE

θ'

Exodos

ἔξοδος

The Palintropic Imperative



ξυνὸν γὰρ ἀρχὴ καὶ πέρας ἐπὶ κύκλου περιφερείας.

On the circumference of a circle, beginning and end are common.

— Heraclitus, fragment B103 (Diels–Kranz)

... to arrive where we started / And know the place for the first time.

— T. S. Eliot, "Little Gidding" (1942)

9.1 *The Escape Sequence as Parturition*

The genre's most persistent ending was established in its first work. When Samus destroys Mother Brain at the heart of Tourian in the original *Metroid*, a countdown begins, and she must climb a long vertical shaft before the fortress explodes. *Super Metroid* raised the stakes to the scale of a world: after Mother Brain's death, a timer counts down while Samus flees through Tourian and up through the caverns of Crateria to her gunship, which rises into the storm as the planet Zebes is consumed. In *Metroid Fusion* she steers a space station into the planet below, destroying both; in *Metroid Prime* the crater at the heart of Tallon IV collapses behind her. The first *Castlevania* ends with Simon Belmont watching from a hillside as Dracula's castle crumbles; *Symphony of the Night* ends with the castle collapsing as Alucard, Maria, and Richter depart. *Ori and the Blind Forest* stages its climactic passages as flights — up the hollow Ginso Tree before rising waters, up Mount Horu before rising lava. The escape sequence reverses every characteristic of the genre's tempo. Leisure gives way to the clock; the labyrinth's many paths narrow to one; return gives way to flight; and the persistent world, which had waited patiently for every return, is destroyed.

This study proposes to read the escape sequence as parturition. Its form is the timed expulsion of a body from an interior that collapses behind it. The genre's deepest interiors are presided over, with remarkable frequency, by maternal figures — Mother Brain above all — and they are figured, in the biomechanical idiom the genre inherited from Giger and *Alien*, as organic, tubular, and membranous: the archaic mother of Barbara Creed's analysis, examined in Chapter Five, given architectural form. The escape itself is a labour. It is a passage through narrowing channels — the vertical shaft of the first *Metroid* is nothing else —

under the pressure of a countdown that functions as the clock of labour, and it ends in the emergence of the hero into open space: the starfield into which the gunship rises, the empty sky above the crumbling castle, the desert without walls that Chapter Two found at the end of Borges's labyrinths. The hero is delivered from the world it explored. And Chapter Five's promised second reading of the Morph Ball may now be given. The protagonist curled into a sphere to pass through the narrowest channels of the world resembles nothing so much as a creature not yet born. Its long accretion of capacities is a gestation, and its escape is a delivery.

The reading has theoretical warrant. Otto Rank's *The Trauma of Birth* (1924) argued that birth is the primal anxiety, restaged throughout human culture in myth, art, and the fantasy of a return to the womb, and Rank counted the labyrinth among the symbolic restagings of the passage through the maternal body. Mircea Eliade's *Birth and Rebirth* (1958), republished as *Rites and Symbols of Initiation*, described initiation across cultures as a *regressus ad uterum*: the novice enters a hut, a cave, or the belly of a monster, a symbolic womb, dies symbolically within it, and is reborn; and Eliade read the labyrinth as an initiatory ordeal of exactly this kind. Joseph Campbell's monomyth, whose universalizing method this study set aside, nevertheless named the hero's passage into the unknown "the belly of the whale," after Jonah's three days within the great fish. The metroidvania stages the initiatory womb at the scale of a world. The hero enters, descending; is gestated, accreting the capacities of the world; and is born, expelled through the narrowing channel as the womb collapses behind it.

Super Metroid concentrates this maternal drama into its final sequence. Samus is herself a mother, since the Metroid hatchling imprinted upon her at its birth in *Metroid II*; Mother Brain is the archaic mother of the planet. At the climax the grown child saves its mother from the mother, draining Mother Brain's life to restore Samus's and dying under Mother Brain's attack; and Samus, armed with the power the child has left her, destroys Mother Brain and flees the dying world. The birth that ends the game is accomplished through the death of the child and of the archaic mother, and the only other lives the escape preserves are those of the animals who taught Samus to move, if the player turns back to free them. The genre's purest ethical gesture, examined in Chapter Five, is thus set within a birth scene, and it consists in carrying the teachers out of the womb.

Chapter Seven noted that in Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh* the Simurgh, who had raised the abandoned Zāl in her nest, returns at his summons to preside over the birth of his son, instructing the delivery of Rostam by opening his mother's side and healing her afterward. The bird who fosters the orphan becomes the midwife of the hero. The correspondence is again analogical rather than genealog-

ical, but it completes a figure: the genre's avian guardians, who raised Samus and infused her with their blood, stand at the threshold of her becoming as the Simurgh stood at Rostam's.

The genre's darkest works invert the parturition. In the first of *Hollow Knight*'s endings, the Knight does not escape at all. It enters the Black Egg Temple at the kingdom's heart and takes the place of the Hollow Knight within it, sealing the infection inside its own empty body. The hero does not emerge from the egg; it returns into it. This is the *regressus ad uterum* without rebirth, the initiatory womb become a tomb, and it is governed by the law that Chapter Six found in the Sumerian underworld: no one leaves without a substitute, and here the hero is the substitute, remaining below so that the kingdom may live. Against the Orphic egg from which the revealer hatched, *Hollow Knight* sets an egg into which the hero is sealed. The genre's exodos, in its brightest and its darkest forms, is a meditation on birth: on what it costs to be delivered from the world that formed one, and on what it costs to stay.

9.2 Metron, Mētra, Mētēr

The Measured Womb

The genre's deepest chambers are maternal, and the catalogue of its mothers is long. Mother Brain governs the heart of Zebes. *La-Mulana*'s final antagonist is named Mother, the ancient creator for whom, in the game's mythology, its ruins were raised, and who longs to return to the heavens from which she came. *Ori and the Blind Forest* gives its orphaned spirit two mothers: Naru, who adopts and raises it after the storm that tore it from the Spirit Tree, and Kuro, the great owl whose eggs were destroyed by the tree's light, whose fury against the forest is a mother's grief, and who sacrifices herself at the end to restore the light she hated, her one surviving egg hatching in the sequel. *Hollow Knight* has the White Lady, who bore the vessels with the Pale King and has bound herself within her overgrown gardens, and Herrah the Beast, mother of Hornet, sleeping as one of the seals in the depths of Deepnest. *Symphony of the Night* turns on Lisa, Alucard's mother, whose burning as a witch turned Dracula against humanity and whose last counsel to her son was that he not hate humans. *Blasphemous* names one of its cathedral regions the Mother of Mothers and houses a convent of Our Lady of the Charred Visage. Behind them stand *Alien*'s computer "Mother"; Samus herself as mother to the hatchling; Ereshkigal, queen of the dead, whom Enki's small creatures find groaning as though in labour; and, at the beginning of the labyrinth's recorded history, the Mistress of the Labyrinth to whom a jar of honey was offered at Knossos. The labyrinth, as its first textual trace announced, belongs to a Mistress.

The genre's very name inscribes the maternal. *Metroid* is reportedly a compound of "metro," for the game's subterranean setting, and "android." But "metro" abbreviates the French *métropolitain*, the name given in 1900 to the underground railway of Paris, from *métropole*, from the Greek *mētropolis*, "mother-city," compounded of *mētēr*, mother, and *polis*, city. The genre's eponym thus contains, without its makers needing to have intended it, the Greek word for mother. And the coinage invites a further reading through the Greek, offered here openly as interpretive play: *mētra*, the womb — a word that in the botanical writings of Theophrastus also names the heart-wood of a tree, its innermost core, the *oku* of the trunk — and *metron*, measure. Mother, womb, measure: read through Greek, the genre's name condenses the argument of this chapter.

The genre is, first, a form of measurement. Its completion percentage is a metric; its map is a survey, the work of the land-surveyor whom Kafka could not let complete his task; its capacities are measured against its gaps in the body-scaled ratios that William Warren found governing the perception of stairs; its speedruns

are measured by the clock; and its worlds, as the next section shows, are kindled and quenched in measures. It is, second, a form of the womb. Its deepest interiors — Tourian, the Abyss in which the vessels of Hallownest were born, the keep where the father waits and the mother is remembered — are places of origin from which the hero emerges. And its map unites the two. The Latin *mātrix*, from *māter*, meant a womb, a breeding animal, and later a source or a mould; when the mathematician James Joseph Sylvester needed a name, in 1850, for a rectangular array of numbers, he called it a matrix, because it was the womb from which determinants were born. The genre's map is a matrix in the modern sense, a grid of cells, and in the ancient sense a womb. The metroidvania is a *measured womb*: a space that measures the body growing within it and releases that body when its measure is complete. Its hundred per cent is the full term; its exodos is the delivery.

Plato's *Timaeus* supplies the philosophical ground of this figure. Having described the eternal forms and the becoming things that copy them, Timaeus finds himself compelled to introduce a third kind, difficult and obscure: the receptacle (*hypodochē*) of all becoming, "as it were its nurse" (49a). It is proper, he says, to liken the receptacle to a mother, the model to a father, and what arises between them to their offspring (50d). This third kind he names *chōra*, space: it admits no destruction, provides a seat for all that comes to be, and is apprehended without the senses by a kind of bastard reasoning, scarcely an object of belief, as though in a dream (52a–b). Plato's cosmology identifies space itself with a maternal receptacle, the nurse of becoming. The metroidvania's space is *chōra* in exactly this sense: the receptacle in which the hero takes form, the nurse of its becoming, the mother whose measure it grows to fill. Julia Kristeva, in *Revolution in Poetic Language* (1974), adapted Plato's term as the "semiotic *chora*," a pre-linguistic, maternal space of rhythms and drives that precedes and underlies the symbolic order of language. The genre's characteristic near-wordlessness — the silence of *Super Metroid*, the sparse and riddling speech of Hallownest — makes its worlds semiotic *chorai* in Kristeva's sense, spaces whose meaning is carried less by words than by rhythm, music, light, and the movement of a body through them.

Luce Irigaray's *Speculum of the Other Woman* (1974) reread the allegory of the cave in a chapter titled "Plato's *Hystera*," taking up the Greek word for womb. The cave, Irigaray argued, is a maternal space, and the philosopher's ascent from it toward the paternal sun is a flight from the mother; Western metaphysics is founded upon the forgetting of the maternal origin, upon a symbolic matricide. The metroidvania's relation to Irigaray's critique is double. On the one hand, it descends into the *hystera* rather than fleeing it. Its truths lie below, as Chapter Six

showed, and its deepest revelations are revelations of maternal origin: the birthplace of the vessels in the Abyss, the chamber of Mother Brain at the planet's root. On the other hand, its ending repeats the philosopher's flight: the escape from the collapsing womb, the archaic mother destroyed behind the fleeing hero. The genre stages both the return to the mother and the matricidal exodus. Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine and Kristeva's abjection, examined in Chapter Five, name the horror that motivates the flight; Lisa, Naru, and the White Lady name the tenderness that the genre also remembers. Its maternal figures divide accordingly into two kinds — the archaic mother, whom the hero must leave or destroy, and the nurse, who forms the hero: Naru, the Chozo, the Simurgh — and the division corresponds to the two aspects of Plato's *chōra*, the receptacle that holds all things and the nurse that raises them.

The argument may now be stated in its boldest form. The metroidvania is a measured womb. Its space is a *chōra*, its map a matrix, its completion a full term, its escape a birth, its antagonist the archaic mother, its guardian the nurse; its eponym contains the word for mother, and its labyrinth belonged, in the first record of the word, to a Mistress. The woman concealed in the Gothic house — Bertha Mason in the attic at Thornfield, and, as the next section recalls, Madeline Usher in the vault — and the mother concealed at the heart of the genre's worlds are one figure. This reading is interpretive, and it is offered as such. Its evidence is the recurrence of maternal figures across the corpus, the structure of the genre's ending, and the etymologies that inscribe the maternal at the root of the genre's name.

9.3 *The Labyrinth That Destroys Itself*

Why do the genre's worlds destroy themselves upon completion? Three answers may be given, and they are not exclusive. The first is narrative convention: the villain's lair falls with its master, as it has in adventure fiction since the Gothic novel. The second is structural. A palintropic world exists in order to be returned to, and when it has no more returns to offer, its reason for being is exhausted. The labyrinth that is wholly known is no longer a labyrinth; Eco observed that the classical labyrinth, which offers no choice, needs its Minotaur to remain interesting at all, and the completed metroidvania is a labyrinth that has become a diagram. The exodos closes the palintropic economy. The completed map, which Chapter Eight compared to the useless total memory of Borges's Funes, is not preserved but consumed, and the Hegelian whole the genre grants is annihilated in the moment of its granting. The third answer is mythic: the collapsing labyrinth recurs throughout the traditions this study has traced, and the genre's endings reactivate a figure older than its medium.

The palace at Knossos was destroyed in the fourteenth century BCE, and the labyrinth survived only as story and as image. Walpole's Otranto ends, as Chapter Four recalled, with its walls thrown down and the giant form of its rightful lord rising among the ruins; the tombs beneath which Le Guin's Tenar served collapse behind her and Ged as they escape. Edgar Allan Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839) gives the figure its most concentrated form. The narrator visits his ailing friend Roderick Usher in a decaying mansion marked by a barely perceptible fissure running from roof to foundation. Roderick's sister Madeline, cataleptic, is entombed in a vault beneath the house; days later, during a storm, she returns from the tomb, bloodied from her struggle to escape it, and brother and sister fall dead together. The narrator flees, and behind him the fissure widens, the walls rush asunder, "and the deep and dank tarn at my feet closed sullenly and silently over the fragments of the 'House of Usher.'" The Gothic house collapses at the moment its buried woman returns. Sedgwick's live burial is undone, the concealed feminine of the previous section rises from the vault, and the house cannot survive her emergence. In a single page Poe joins the genre's exodos to its maternal secret.

The tradition's cosmologies extend the figure from the house to the world. Heraclitus's fragment B30 describes the cosmos itself in terms that this chapter's etymology has prepared: κόσμον τόνδε, τὸν αὐτὸν ἁπάντων, οὔτε τις θεῶν οὔτε ἀνθρώπων ἐποίησεν, ἀλλ' ἦν ἀεὶ καὶ ἔστιν καὶ ἔσται πῦρ ἀείζωον, ἁπτόμενον μέτρα καὶ ἀποσβεννύμενον μέτρα — this world-order, the same for all, no god nor man made, but it ever was and is and shall be: an ever-living fire, kindling in measures

and going out in measures. The world is a fire kindled and quenched *in measures*, *metra*: the *metron* of the previous section appears at the root of Heraclitus's cosmology. The Stoics developed from such fragments the doctrine of *ekpyrōsis*, a periodic conflagration in which the cosmos is consumed and from which an identical cosmos is regenerated. The Norse *Vǫluspá* sees the world consumed at Ragnarök by fire and flood and then, beyond the destruction, the earth rising again from the sea, green. And the Book of Revelation, whose very name means unveiling, closes with a vision of renewal after ruin: "And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away" (21:1). Apocalypse, as Chapter Seven observed, is at once disclosure and destruction, and in these traditions it is also renewal.

The genre knows the renewal as well as the destruction. Its practice of the "new game plus," in which the destroyed world is rebuilt and re-entered with capacities retained, kindles the world again in measure, so that the player returns, in Kierkegaard's phrase, by a recollection forward to a beginning now seen from its end. Some works intensify the renewal into austerity: *Hollow Knight*'s Steel Soul mode grants a single life, so that the world rekindled can be lost entirely. At the level of the series, the genre rebuilds its destroyed labyrinths as remakes. *Metroid: Zero Mission* (2004) rebuilt the first *Metroid*; *Metroid: Samus Returns* (2017) rebuilt *Metroid II*; the *Castlevania* collections return the castle to circulation, as Dracula's castle in the series' lore rises again with each century. Ise's shrine, rebuilt in identical form every twenty years, supplies the architectural parallel noted in Chapter Two. The labyrinth that destroys itself is the labyrinth that returns.

Borges's parable of the two kings, read in Chapter Two, locates the ultimate labyrinth in the desert, a labyrinth without stairs, doors, or walls. The exodos delivers the genre's hero, and its player, into exactly this desert. When the game ends, the player leaves the designed labyrinth for the undesigned world, in which no designer has placed the keys and no contract of deferral guarantees that the visible ledges can be reached. The genre's destruction of its world is, in this light, its final pedagogy. It releases its player into a world without its consolations and leaves open the question that the next section must address: what the habits learned in a designed world — patience, memory, hope, the detour, the return — are worth in a world that keeps no such promises.

One thing, in the paradigmatic ending, survives the destruction. As Zebes dies, the player who turns back may free the small creatures who taught Samus the wall jump and the shinespark, and in the closing sequence their ship is glimpsed fleeing the explosion. The labyrinth is consumed; the map is lost; the

mother is destroyed. What is carried out of the dying world is not a treasure but a debt honoured. What survives the labyrinth's destruction is gratitude.

9.4 *Toward an Ethics of Return*

A form that renders the structure of understanding as navigable space implies an ethics, though it need not preach one. The ethics proposed here is not the explicit morality of any game, which is frequently thin or absent, but what Theodor Adorno called the truth content (*Wahrheitsgehalt*) of an artwork: the knowledge a form embodies, sometimes in spite of itself, which interpretation draws out. Aristotle argued in the second book of the *Nicomachean Ethics* that the virtues are acquired by habituation, as the crafts are — we become just by doing just acts, as builders become builders by building — and Merleau-Ponty's account of habit, examined in Chapter Five, gave that insight a phenomenology. The claim made here is modest. The metroidvania does not make its players virtuous. It rehearses, within what Donald Winnicott in *Playing and Reality* (1971) called the potential space of play — the space between inner and outer worlds, first opened between infant and mother, in which play, creativity, and culture occur — a set of dispositions that the world may later call upon. That Winnicott located the origin of play in the maternal relation, and its maturity in a separation the play itself prepares, gives the genre's measured womb and its exodus a further resonance. From the analyses of the preceding chapters, eight precepts may be drawn.

Return in order to recognize, not to repeat. The scandal with which this study began dissolved when the genre's return was understood as recursion rather than iteration, as re-reading rather than rote. The first precept generalizes the distinction. Texts, places, persons, and histories are to be revisited not to confirm what one already saw but to see them transformed by who one has become, in the fusion of horizons that Gadamer described and the circle that Heidegger said must be entered rightly rather than escaped. Kierkegaard's repetition, recollected forward, is the precept's formula.

Keep the unreachable desirable, and learn to discern. The anti-Aesopian machine refuses the consolations of sour grapes and trains a disciplined hope against the adaptive preferences that Elster, Sen, and Nussbaum identified as deprivation's disguise. But Chapter Three found the pedagogy's shadow in the just-world ideology: in an undesigned world, not every ledge is reachable, and some impasses are permanent. The precept therefore joins Bloch's *docta spes* to the oldest discipline of discernment in the Western tradition, the distinction with

which Epictetus opened his *Handbook*, between the things that are within our power and the things that are not. Hope educated by the genre must learn to ask which ledges are provisional.

Take the detour. Köhler's apes reached the fruit by turning their backs on it; Kafka's man from the country waited before the law for a lifetime and never entered; the Sibyl declared the return the hero's labour. The precept counsels patience against immediacy: the willingness to leave what cannot yet be reached, to go elsewhere to learn, and to come back. In a culture organized around the immediate satisfaction of desire, the genre's insistence on the long way round is a quiet counter-discipline.

Acknowledge what the world gives, and what it costs. Theriomorphic accretion revealed that every capacity the explorer gains is taken from the world and its creatures, and that the colonist who masters a world becomes it. The precept converts this structural law into an ethic of kinship — what Donna Haraway, in *Staying with the Trouble* (2016), called the work of making kin across species and kinds — and it prefers, where it can, the Orphic disclosure of attention to the Promethean disclosure of extraction. It remembers the Hunter's Journal, in which knowledge was purchased by slaughter, and asks what knowledge can be had otherwise.

Ask the question. The Grail castle opened not to force but to Parzival's question, "what ails you?", and the Sumerian underworld yielded Inanna's corpse to creatures who shared the groaning of its queen. The highest form of return, on the genre's own evidence, is attention to another's suffering. The epistemic key is also an ethical one, and the knowledge that heals is knowledge of what another bears.

Remember the substitute. No one leaves the underworld unmarked: Inanna's return cost Dumuzi; Samus's escape cost the child that saved her; the peace of Hallownest is purchased by a vessel sealed in the dark. Every homecoming is paid for by someone, and the precept asks that the price be remembered. Benjamin's angel wished to stay, to wake the dead, and to make whole what had been smashed; the genre grants that wish in play, and its ethics extends it to the world. Its emblem is the act of mercy at the end of *Super Metroid*: turning back, at cost and without reward, to carry the teachers out.

Hold memory in common, and keep secrets generously. The collective palace examined in Chapter Eight is a mnemonic commons, and its communities have learned to protect the first visits of those who come after them, keeping silent about what newcomers have not yet found. Derrida's absolute secret, the singularity of each passage that no record contains, gives this etiquette its depth. To respect another's discovery is to respect the secret of another's way, and the pre-

cept asks that shared memory be held in a form that leaves room for others to find what one has found.

Know yourself as what the journey has made. The genre's reflexive secret, the self disclosed behind the last veil, is not a self that was simply there but the self the journey produced. Socrates asked whether he was a monster more furious than Typhon or a gentler creature with a share of the divine, and the genre answers that one is likely both. The final precept asks that one take responsibility for the self thus disclosed: for its kinship with the monstrous it absorbed, and for the debts its transformations incurred.

The eight precepts may be gathered into a single formula, which this dissertation calls the *palintropic imperative*: return to every place you have passed as one who has changed, so that you may recognize it for the first time; and when you leave a world, carry out of it what you owe.

The ethics has limits, and they should be stated plainly. The genre's ideological components — the just world, the pleasures of extraction, the scopic economy of its earliest endings, the imperial imaginary of the blank map — are not dissolved by the reading offered here. The truth content of a form is not its whole content, and the palintropic imperative is drawn from the genre's structures against some of its pleasures, in the manner of an immanent critique. Nor is there any guarantee that the dispositions rehearsed in play transfer to the world. The claim is only that the genre, uniquely among popular forms, makes the return the medium of its meaning, and that a culture which plays such forms in great numbers is rehearsing, whether it knows it or not, a way of being in time: one in which the past is not merely behind but available, the impasse not final but instructive, and the self not given but made by the way it walks.

9.5 *The Way Up and the Way Down*

This study began with a scandal: a genre whose defining operation would, in almost any other form, be diagnosed as a failure of design. The scandal has dissolved. The metroidvania's return is not iteration but recursion, not rote but re-reading, and it produces meaning because it enacts the structure of understanding itself. The genre is the hermeneutic circle made walkable: a form in which wholes are grasped through parts and parts through wholes, so that every comprehension is a re-comprehension and every arrival is a return. Its deep structure, palintropic form, takes its name from Heraclitus's back-turning harmony of the bow and the lyre and from his identity of the way up and the way down, and it is articulated through five movements — prolepsis, aporia, metamorphosis, anagnorisis, and aletheia — that recur at every scale of the world. Around them this study has developed a secondary lexicon: the palintrope, the locus whose meaning is reconstituted by return; the stasimon, the room of stillness in which the map is contemplated; the cartographic suspension, the Icarian view from above granted only to one who has stopped moving; theriomorphic accretion, the explorer's assimilation to the monstrous world it explores; the reflexive secret, the self disclosed behind the last veil; and the exodos, the way out through a collapsing world. It has proposed a fourth labyrinth beside Eco's three, the palintropic labyrinth whose topology changes as it is walked; a reading of the genre's ending as birth, and of its space as a measured womb; and a palintropic imperative for play, interpretation, and life. Table 9.1 gathers the pentad with its principal sources, figures, and exemplars.

The dissertation was organized, in deference to its object, as a palintropic structure. It opened with an *eisodos* and closes with an *exodos*; it paused at the end of each chapter in a *stasimon*; and it returned at every stage to the same works — the rain on Crateria, the inverted castle, the Abyss beneath Hallownest — finding them, as the first stasimon promised, unchanged and altogether transformed. The rain on Crateria was, in the first chapter, the weather of an opening scene; by the last, it falls on a world that will be consumed, from which a hunter raised by birds rises in her gunship, born. The inverted castle was a curiosity of level design; it became a peripeteia of space, an estrangement in Shklovsky's sense, the father's house read backward by the son who bears the father's name reversed. The Abyss beneath Hallownest was a deep region of a large map; it became Jung's cave beneath the house, the birthplace of vessels, the womb to which the hero returns and into whose egg, in one ending, it is sealed. Heraclitus's fragment on the circle, set at the head of this chapter, describes the shape the study has tried to take: on the circumference, beginning and end are common.

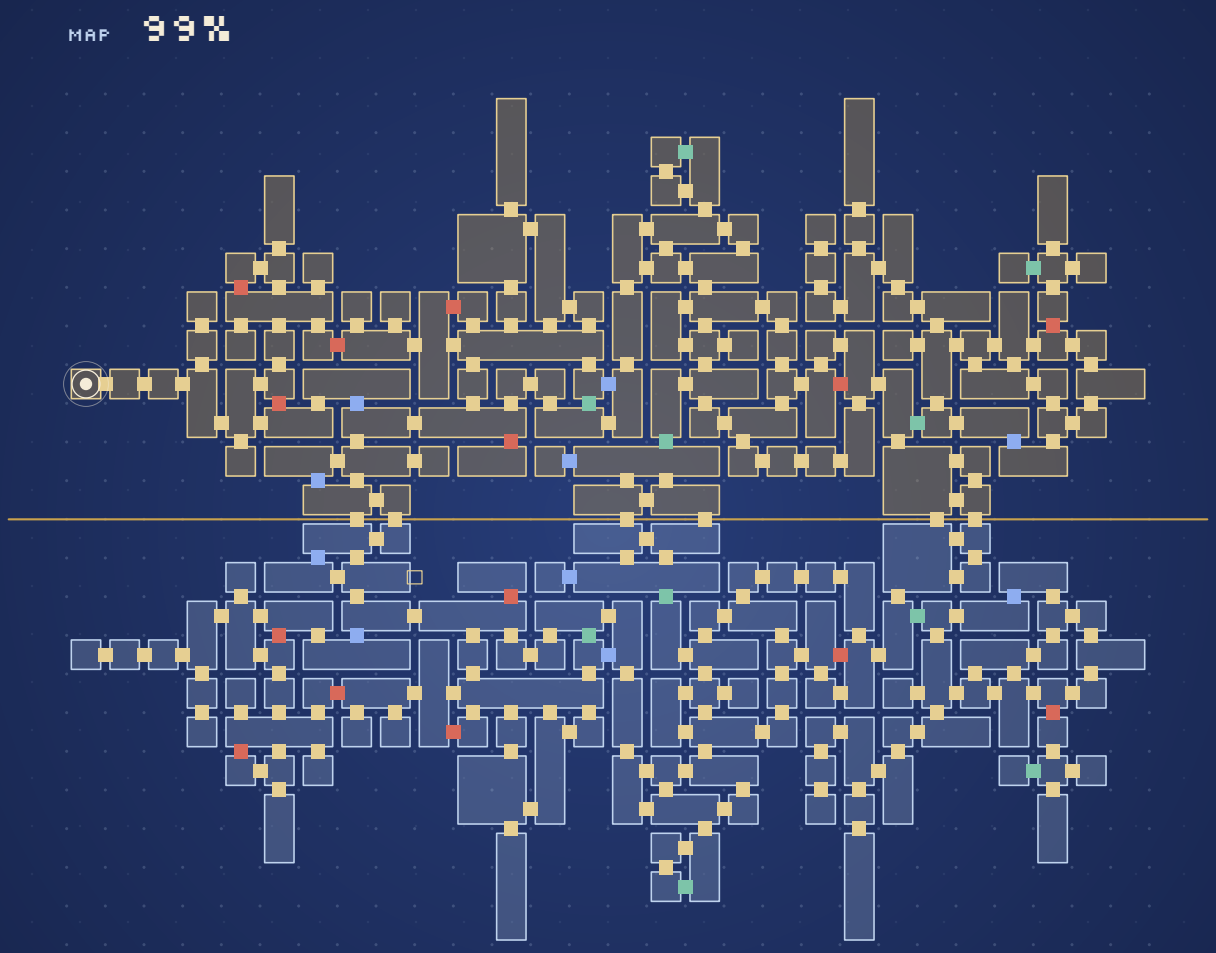
TABLE 9.1 *The palintropic pentad: sources, figures, and exemplars.*

Prolepsis *πρόληψις* *chapter three*	PHILOSOPHICAL SOURCES Husserl's empty intention; Bloch's anticipatory illumination; the Epicurean preconception MYTHIC AND LITERARY FIGURES Sappho's unreached apple; Diotima's Eros; the borrowed mountain of the stroll garden LUDIC EXEMPLARS The ledge beyond the leap; the item behind glass; backgrounds painted with regions to come
Aporia *ἀπορία* *chapter four*	PHILOSOPHICAL SOURCES Heidegger's *Holzwege*; van Gennep's threshold; Sedgwick's blocked self MYTHIC AND LITERARY FIGURES Bluebeard's chamber; Kafka's door; the gateless gate LUDIC EXEMPLARS Coloured hatches; one-way drops; the grammar of gates (Table 4.1)
Metamorphosis *μεταμόρφωσις* *chapter five*	PHILOSOPHICAL SOURCES Merleau-Ponty's "I can"; Uexküll's Umwelt; Gibson's affordances MYTHIC AND LITERARY FIGURES Ovid's changed forms; Alice's little door; Lovecraft's Innsmouth LUDIC EXEMPLARS The Morph Ball; Alucard's shapes; Samus becoming Metroid
Anagnorisis *ἀναγνώρισις* *chapter six*	PHILOSOPHICAL SOURCES Aristotle's recognition; Plato's recollection; Freud's uncanny MYTHIC AND LITERARY FIGURES Inanna's seven gates; the scar and bow of Odysseus; Perceval's question LUDIC EXEMPLARS The inverted castle; the Shade reclaimed; the loops of *Outer Wilds*
Aletheia *ἀλήθεια* *chapter seven*	PHILOSOPHICAL SOURCES Heraclitus's hiding nature; Heidegger's unconcealment; Hadot's two attitudes MYTHIC AND LITERARY FIGURES The veil at Sais; Novalis's novice; Attar's thirty birds LUDIC EXEMPLARS False walls; the hidden second castle; the reflexive secret (Table 7.1)

The bow and the lyre have accompanied the argument from its first chapter. Heraclitus named them as figures of an attunement that agrees with itself by differing, and the *Odyssey*, three centuries earlier, joined them at the moment of its decisive recognition, when the disguised wanderer strings his bow as a singer strings a lyre and the string sings like a swallow. The genre's progress is a bowstring drawn backward, each return the tension that sends the arrow forward; its music is the lyre's, a harmony produced by a string held in tension between two arms. The returned hero is recognized, as Odysseus was, by the one capacity that only the true self possesses, and that capacity is the palintrope itself: the power to turn back in order to go on.

Ovid's Daedalus, who filled his labyrinth with wandering, could scarcely find his own way back to its threshold, and Ovid compared his building to a river at play that runs back upon itself and beholds its own waves still to come. T. S. Eliot's "Little Gidding," whose lines also stand at the head of this chapter, gave the same discovery its most famous modern form: that the end of all exploring is to come back to the place from which one set out and to know it for the first time. The metroidvania has made that discovery playable. Its heroes leave in order to return, and return in order to recognize; they descend to rise, and rise to go down again; they become the world they explore, until, in *Ori and the Will of the Wisps* (2020), the small spirit that fell from the Spirit Tree at the beginning of its first adventure becomes, at the end of its second, the new Spirit Tree, the axis of the world it once crossed as an orphan.

The player, closing the game, leaves the designed labyrinth for the undesigned one, where no contract of deferral guarantees the ledges and no designer has hidden the keys. The reader, closing this study, does the same. If the argument of these chapters holds, what the genre has offered to both is not an escape from that world but a rehearsal for it: a training in return, in which the places one has passed are entered again by one who has changed, and are known, at last, as they could not be known the first time. The way up and the way down are one and the same. Whoever has walked them both arrives, at the end, at the threshold from which the journey set out — and sees it, for the first time.



ξυνὸν γὰρ ἀρχὴ καὶ πέρας ἐπὶ κύκλου περιφερείας

On the circumference of a circle, beginning and end are common.

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